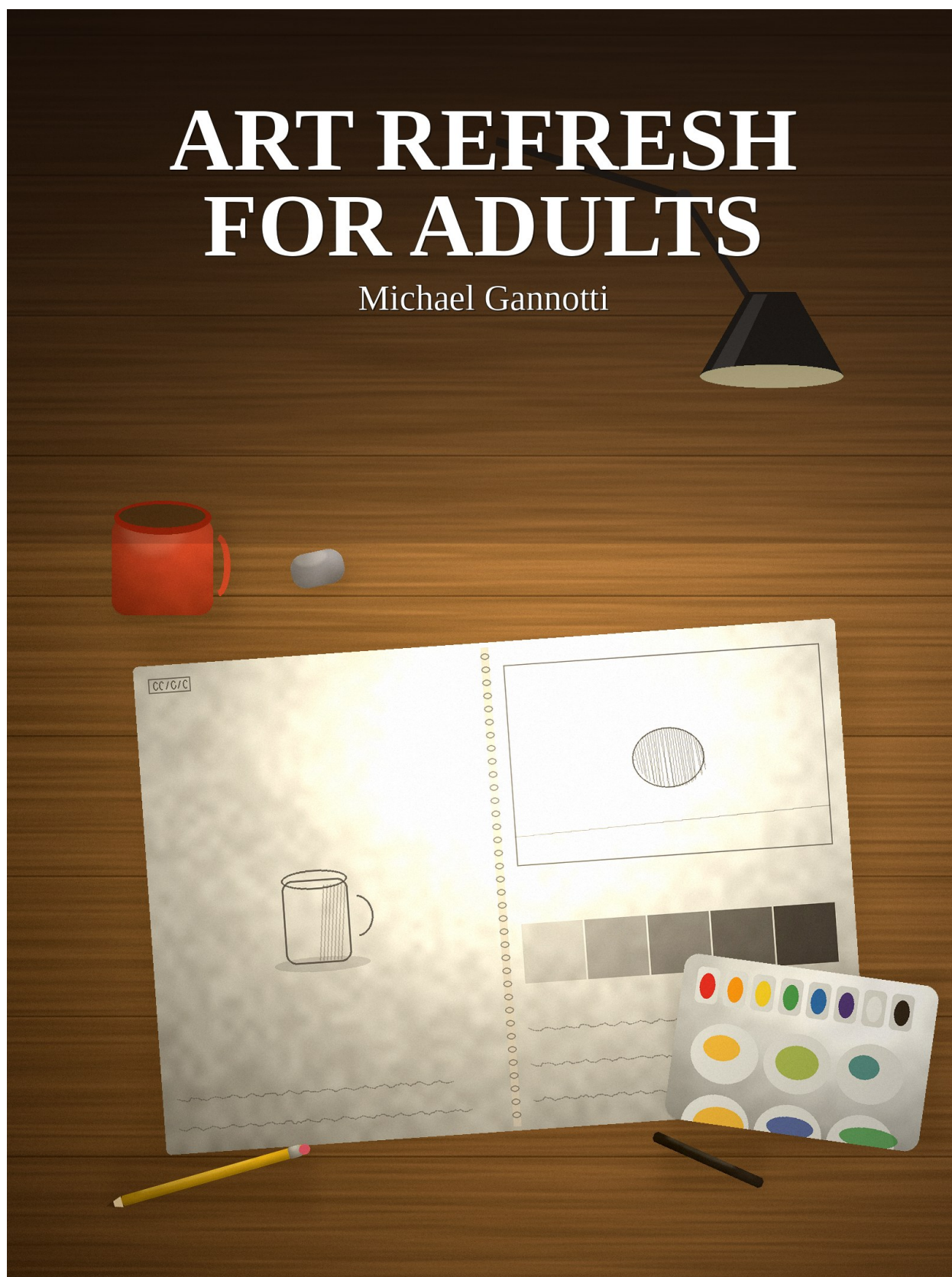


ART REFRESH FOR ADULTS

Michael Gannotti



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A warm self-study manual for adults coming back to art. Illustrated edition, 29 September 2026. Notes run in one series at the back; the superscript numbers link to them. The images are original still lifes, with no people and no brands.

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Welcome

Maybe you drew all the time as a kid and then, somewhere around twelve, stopped. Maybe you took art in school, loved it, and haven't opened a paint box in twenty years. Maybe you've said "I can't draw" so many times it sounds like a fact. Maybe you've just retired, and a wish you kept putting off is finally sitting across the table from you. Maybe you have fifteen minutes on a train and a coat pocket that would hold a small notebook. Maybe you'd like to make something at the kitchen table next to your kids instead of just handing them the markers.

This book is for all of you, one reader at a time. You're the learner here. There's no teacher's edition and no student section, because you're both, and that turns out to be a good arrangement.

Rust is ordinary

If the first page you draw after years away feels clumsy, good. That's what the first page feels like for nearly everyone who comes back. Rust isn't a verdict on you. It's what happens to any skill you set down for a while, and it comes off the way it came on: a little at a time.

"Refresh" in this book doesn't mean proving you were never rusty. It means rebuilding a practice you'll actually keep. Small enough to survive a busy week. Steady enough that in three months you can lay your first page beside your newest one and see the difference with your own eyes.

"I can't draw" is a starting place

Here is the most encouraging true thing I know about adult drawing.

Researchers who studied why most adults struggle to draw what they see tested the usual suspects one at a time. Was it the hand not doing what it was told? Hardly at all. Was it misjudging your own drawing as you went? No. The big source of trouble was in how people saw the object in front of them. They drew what they knew about it instead of what was actually there.¹

That changes where you start. If you've always said "I can't draw," the likely truth is that you haven't yet trained your eye to see shapes, sizes and angles as they really land in front of you. And seeing can be trained. In another study, college students who took a single term of drawing from observation got clearly better at drawing what they saw, while their basic perception tests didn't change at all.² They didn't need special eyes. The skill was in the practice.

So you can say “I can’t draw” once more, kindly, if you need to. Then put a mug on the table and we’ll look at it together.

What an Art Refresh Hour feels like

Picture a Wednesday evening. (It’s an illustration, not a real person.) The dishes are done. You clear one end of the kitchen table, turn a lamp so it lights a pear from the side, and leave your phone in the other room.

Look. For three minutes you only look. Where’s the darkest part? Where does the pear’s edge slip into shadow? You name one thing you’ll watch for: *the shadow side is bigger than I think*.

Sketch. Five minutes of stamp-sized boxes on a scrap page, three quick tries at the pear: closer, farther, lower.

Make. Twenty minutes on the drawing itself, with a pencil, a cheap sketchbook and a timer running. It goes wrong in the middle, the way drawings do. You keep going.

Step back. You prop the page against the sugar bowl and walk to the far side of the room. You ask yourself one question: what do I actually see, what was I after, and what’s the one change I’ll try next? You write one line: *shadow works; stem too big*.

File. You date the page and jot the minutes on a strip inside the cover. Thirty-five minutes, one honest page, and a note for tomorrow.

That’s the whole thing. Nothing heroic.

On a Monday it might be smaller: twelve minutes on the train with a pocket sketchbook, drawing the umbrella folded on the seat opposite, one line at your stop, the date in the corner. On a Saturday it might be larger: an hour at a museum bench with one painting, or a slow still life on a table you can leave set up. Same five steps, different sizes. It’s called the Art Refresh Hour even when it lasts fifteen minutes, and the front of the book teaches it once, so every chapter after that can simply say “run the Hour.”

You need less than you think

A pencil. A pen that doesn’t smear. A cheap sketchbook, cheap on purpose, so no page feels too good to spoil. A lamp you can aim. Something in front of you to look at, which your house is already full of.

That’s the kit for the first month. Paint, a corner studio and outings come later, when you know what you want from them. Chapter 2 helps you set up a small, safe corner without buying much at all, and the resources chapter starts with the library and the free museum day before it mentions anything with a price.

The line that holds the book together

Look long before you judge; sketch before you polish; sign only what you made.

Your eye is what you're training, so give it time before it hands down a verdict. Cheap, fast tries come before the careful piece. Your name goes only on marks and choices that are yours.

You'll meet that line again. It's short on purpose, so you can carry it.

What this book will do

It will give you a rhythm: a daily page of ten to fifteen minutes, a longer sit once or twice a week, and an outing when you can manage one. It will teach drawing from observation, painting, photography, digital work and design, looking at art, critique, and the harder trick of keeping going once the first excitement wears off. It will help you set up a corner at home that's safe and pleasant to work in, and show you how to keep simple, honest records.

At every step it will tell you what to try today: on the commute, at the table, in a weekend sit.

What this book won't do

It won't test you for talent. There's no quiz at the front to sort the artists from everyone else.

It won't promise you'll draw like a master in thirty days. If you practice most days, you'll see real progress in weeks, and that's a better promise because it's true.

It won't tell you art will make you smarter or treat an illness. Chapter 1 says plainly, and carefully, what art can and can't be counted on to do.

It won't sell you a course, rank products, or push a brand. The resources chapter sorts options by fit and starts with what's free.

It won't hand you a certificate or invent a course credit. The records in Chapter 9 are honest ones a stranger could read.

It won't treat a generated image as your work.

And it won't repeat the books that came before it. This is the fourth and final title in the Art Hour family, after *Art for Little Thinkers*, *Art for Young Minds* and *Art for Emerging Adults*, which teach children and teens with a parent at the table. If you make art with kids, the resources chapter points you to them. This one is yours.

Where to begin

Read *How to Use This Book This Week* next. It's short, and it gets you started. Then the five things, then *The Art Refresh Hour*, then Chapter 1.

Tonight, find a pencil, any paper, and a mug. Tomorrow, write the date in the corner of the page.

That's enough to begin.

— Michael Gannotti

How to Use This Book This Week

Start with this week, not the whole book. You don't need to read every chapter before you draw a line. You need a pencil, a few pockets of time, and the five steps below.

This week, in five steps

1. The baseline page. One sitting of about thirty minutes: ten minutes each drawing a mug, your non-drawing hand, and a corner of the room. Date it. No erasing. Then put it away and leave it alone. It isn't a test. It's the "before" photo you'll be glad of in twelve weeks, when you draw the same three things again. Chapter 1 gives you the full try-it.³

2. The why card. An index card and ten minutes. One line: why art, and why now. A second line: what a good month would look like. Tape it inside your sketchbook's front cover and reread it on the week that goes badly.

3. Daily pages, most days. Ten to fifteen minutes, dated, one thing in front of you, one line of writing underneath. Tie it to something you already do every day, like the first coffee, the train, or the ten minutes after dinner. A missed day is just a missed day. It doesn't reset anything.⁴

4. One desk sit. Twenty-five to forty minutes at a table, with a try-it from Chapter 2 or Chapter 3: nine small thumbnails before a drawing, or a chair drawn only by the empty shapes between its legs.

5. One deep sit or outing. Forty-five to seventy-five minutes somewhere with room to settle: one room of a museum with a pencil, a drop-in class, an open drawing session, or an unhurried study at home on a table you can leave set up.

At the end of the week, flip through what you made and write one line on your practice strip, the running log you'll keep inside the sketchbook cover. That's week one. It's allowed to be lopsided. A week with the baseline page and two daily pages in it is a real week.

Where to start: place by the page, not by age

Once the baseline page has sat for a day, take it out and look at it with a friendly eye. It will tell you where to go after Chapters 1 and 2, which set up the rhythm and the corner for everyone.

- **If proportions wobble**, the mug leans, the fingers all come out the same length, or the corner of the room tips like a ship's deck, spend real time on the looking moves in Chapter 3. That's where most of the fastest gains are.
- **If the drawing is fairly solid**, move through Chapter 3 briskly and on to value and paint in Chapter 4.
- **If you already have a stack of finished pieces** and want to do something with them, Chapter 7 (critique and your own statement) and Chapter 8 (projects, a body of work, showing or sharing) are ready for you.

Picture two readers. (Illustrations, not real people.) A retired engineer measures beautifully and has never been told she can draw; her baseline mug is exact and stiff. She can head straight for value and perspective, and learn to loosen up with fast gesture. An art-school graduate who hasn't drawn in twelve years finds his baseline shaky and frustrating. He may start with a month of daily pages before he touches paint. Same Hour. Different targets.

Your age isn't a placement. Neither is your diploma, or the art grade you got in seventh grade. The page is.

The three bands

Every chapter offers its work in three sizes, named for where adults actually find time, not for anyone's age.

- **Commute or lunch** (about 15–20 minutes): a pocket sketchbook on the train, a parked car at lunch, a bench outside the break room.
- **Desk or shift** (about 25–40 minutes): the kitchen table after work, a desk at lunch, a corner studio.
- **Weekend deep sit** (about 45–75 minutes): a table you can leave set up, a museum, an open figure session, a community studio.

A retiree may live mostly in deep sits. A parent of toddlers may live in fifteen-minute sessions for a year. Both are doing the book.

How each teaching chapter is built

Chapters 1 through 8 use the same seven headings, in the same order, so you always know where you are.

- **Why this matters:** what this part of practice opens up for you.
- **Understand it yourself:** the idea in plain words, an everyday picture and a precise one, the wrong turns you'll hear (including from yourself), and a five-minute warm-up.
- **How to try it this week:** the Hour in all three bands, words to say to yourself, the first try-it, and when to stop fiddling.
- **Practice that actually builds it:** named try-its, the chapter's talk-to-yourself box, and one wrong example to diagnose.

- **If it isn't clicking:** three common snags and the next move for each, and when to ask a person.
- **Tools, including AI:** short. What helps, one good use of an AI tool, and one this book rules out.
- **What “done enough” looks like:** a checklist before you move on.

Chapter 9 (records) and Chapter 10 (resources) use their own plain headings.

The try-its are a menu

Each teaching chapter draws its try-its from a small bank of named exercises, a hundred across the book. They're a menu, not a calendar. Pick the ones that fit your week, repeat the ones that work, skip the ones that don't suit you yet. Every try-it tells you four things: **time, materials, safety, the move**. If a try-it needs something you don't have, there's almost always a version that doesn't.

Twelve weeks, if you like a map

Some people like to see a whole route. Here's one, offered as a sketch, not a schedule. Weeks 1–2: Chapters 1 and 2, the baseline, the daily page, the corner. Weeks 3–4: drawing from observation. Weeks 5–6: painting, with your first progress redraw at the end of week 6. Week 7: photography, digital and design. Week 8: looking at art. Week 9: critique and a short statement. Weeks 10–11: a small series and a first showing, even if it's three friends and a kitchen wall. Week 12: records, and your second redraw.

Stretch it, loop it, skip around. A week that slips is still a week. A reader with more time can double the deep sits; a reader with less can live in commute sessions and move through the chapters over six months. The route carries no credit and no finish line. It exists to show that the book fits a life.

Where the notes live

Each file ends with its own notes: sources, dates, and the details behind any claim. The teaching stays plain; the evidence waits at the back for when you want it.

Now read the five things. They fit on one page.

If You Only Remember Five Things

Keep this page. The chapters add moves, materials and questions. They don't replace these.

Look long before you judge; sketch before you polish; sign only what you made. That's the whole book in one line. Here it is in five.

1. Look long before you judge

Your eye is what you're training. Most drawing trouble turns out to be seeing trouble, not hand trouble: we draw what we know about a thing instead of what's in front of us.¹ So before you mark, look. Before you decide a drawing, a painting in a museum, or your own page is good or bad, describe it first. The verdict can wait. It's usually better after it has.

2. Small and often

A daily page and one deeper sit a week beat a rare marathon. Ten to fifteen minutes, dated, one thing in front of you, one line underneath, on most days, tied to something you already do. Habits like this take weeks to months to settle, and a missed day doesn't reset you.⁴ The Saturday you finally have free is a bonus, not the plan.

3. Step back before you fix

When something looks wrong, the urge is to erase, repaint or ask for help right away. Step back first: arm's length, across the room, upside down, or a quick black-and-white photo. Name one part that works and one change to try. Then fix one thing, not five. Your talk-to-yourself question is always the same at heart: *what do I actually see, what was I after, and what's the one change I'll try next?*

4. Sign only what you made

Your name goes on the marks and choices that are yours. A generated image isn't your mark, however carefully you wrote the prompt, and the US Copyright Office agrees that prompts alone don't make someone the author of a picture.⁵ Copies of other artists' work are labelled "copy after

____.” For any piece you keep, fill a whose-mark card: what you made, which tools and references you used, what help you had, and what AI did, which in this book is usually nothing.

5. Keep the studio safe and kind

Read labels. Bring in fresh air and send used air out; a fan that only stirs the room isn’t ventilation.⁶ Keep a food line, and lid any oily rags. Send darkroom, kiln, press and etching work to community venues with proper ventilation and staff. Ask people before you draw or post them. Keep photos of children and family off shared computers and out of AI tools; if you use an agent service like Grok Bot, remember that all your bots share one computer, files and logins included.⁷ Kind counts too: a studio where bad pages are allowed is a studio you’ll keep coming back to.

That’s it. Five things. Now go and find a mug.

The Art Refresh Hour



Every session in this book has the same five steps: **Look** · **Sketch** · **Make** · **Step back** · **File**. Learn them once, here. When a chapter says “run the Hour,” this is what it means. The only thing that changes is what’s on the table.⁸

Look comes before any mark: you look at the subject, the reference or the artwork, and name one thing you’ll watch for. **Sketch** is the warm-up, the thumbnails, or the daily page itself. **Make** is the chapter’s try-it or the longer piece. **Step back** is the painter’s old move: arm’s length, across the room, upside down, or a quick black-and-white photo, then one thing that works and one change to try. **File** is the date, a line on your practice strip, and, for anything you’d keep, a whose-mark card.

The whole book rests on one line, and the Hour is how you live it: **Look long before you judge; sketch before you polish; sign only what you made.**

It's called an Hour because that's the shape at full size. Most days it will be smaller. That's the design, not a compromise.

Step	Commute or lunch (~15–20 min)	Desk or shift (~25–40 min)	Weekend deep sit (~45–75 min)
Look	1–2 min	3 min	5–10 min
Sketch	10–13 min (the daily page)	5 min	10 min
Make	folded into Sketch	15–25 min	25–45 min
Step back	1–2 min	3–5 min	5–8 min
File	1 min	2 min	3–5 min

A good default week: a daily page on most days, one or two desk sits, and one deep sit or outing. A thinner week still counts.

1. Micro (commute or lunch, about 15–20 minutes)

A pocket sketchbook on the train. A parked car at lunch. A bench outside the break room. One pen, one small book, one thing to look at.

Look (1–2 minutes). Pick one thing: your coffee cup, the bag on the seat opposite, the tree through the windshield. Find its biggest shape before you draw anything.

Sketch (10–13 minutes). This is the daily page, and on a micro day it's nearly the whole session; Make folds in here. Draw the one thing slowly, looking at it more than at the page.

Step back (1–2 minutes). Hold the book at arm's length. Write one line: one thing that works, one to try next time.

File (1 minute). Date the page. Put a tick and the minutes on your practice strip.

If your stop comes early, the date and three honest lines of a cup is a real session. Stopping when the time's up is part of the skill.

2. Desk sit (about 25–40 minutes)

The kitchen table after work. A desk at lunch with a small kit. A corner studio. Phone face down or in another room, and a timer on the table.

Look (3 minutes). Look at the subject or reference and name one thing you'll watch for, in the margin: *the far mug is smaller than I think.*

Sketch (5 minutes). Line warm-ups, or a few stamp-sized thumbnails to try the arrangement before you commit.

Make (15–25 minutes). The chapter’s try-it. You hold the pencil or brush the whole time. If you get stuck, ask yourself what you were trying to do right there, look back at the subject, and try again before you reach for help of any kind.

Step back (3–5 minutes). Across the room, or turn the page upside down. Ask the chapter’s talk-to-yourself opening and one follow-up (the shape is below).

File (2 minutes). Date the page and add a line to your **practice strip**: date, minutes, band, what you did, one note. *Thu, 35 min, desk, mug and pear, far mug finally smaller.* Wash your hands, and put things back so tomorrow’s start takes two minutes.

3. Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes)

A table you can leave set up. A museum bench. An open figure session. A community darkroom or print shop. This is where the longer piece, the museum study and the first visit to a class belong.

Look (5–10 minutes). A slow look. At home, squint at the setup and make a tiny thumbnail of just the light and dark shapes. In a museum, sit in front of one work for a while before you open the sketchbook.

Sketch (10 minutes). Thumbnails and a value plan: where the lights, middles and darks will go.

Make (25–45 minutes). The longer piece. At a class or open session, the venue sets the rhythm; follow it, and let your own steps be the frame around it.

Step back (5–8 minutes). The full talk-to-yourself box. Take a black-and-white photo, look at it for ten seconds, and put the phone away. Then look again from across the room.

File (3–5 minutes). Date it, add your strip line, photograph anything finished, and fill a **whose-mark card** for any piece you’d keep. The card records whose marks are on the page: title, medium, date and hours; what you made; the tools you used; any reference, with its source; any help you had, and from whom; what AI did, if anything (in this book, usually “none”); consent from anyone pictured; and your signature. The busy-day version is three things: title, date, and “all mine” or “help from ____.” Chapter 9 teaches the card in full.

The daily page

Ten to fifteen minutes. Dated. One thing in front of you. One line of writing underneath about something you noticed. That’s all.

The daily page is the heartbeat of this book. On a busy day it is the micro session. It’s private: nobody needs to see it, and it doesn’t need to be good. It needs to exist. Keep it in a cheap book so the stakes stay low, and tie it to something you already do, like coffee, the train, or the ten minutes after dinner. Chapter 2 builds the habit in detail.

The talk-to-yourself shape, once

Every teaching chapter has a talk-to-yourself box. You're the teacher and the student, so you ask and you answer. The shape never changes.

The opening. Each chapter gives you one exact question. On any day, you can use this one instead: *"Before I fix, erase, or ask a tool: what do I actually see, what was I after, and what's the one change I'll try next?"*

Three to five follow-ups. Pick what helps.

- **Meaning:** "What do I mean by 'off'?"
- **Representation:** "What does the black-and-white photo show? What does the thumbnail show?"
- **Alternative:** "What else could make that corner feel heavy?"
- **Check:** "How will I know the change worked?"
- **Revise:** "I'm allowed to change my mind about what I was after."

How to wait alone. After you ask, look back at the subject or the piece, not at your phone. Count a slow three. That's a habit borrowed from classrooms, not a rule, and it works surprisingly well on your own. If you're really stuck, cover the reference or turn the piece to the wall for a minute, then look again. Rescue at one second is still rescue.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was too vague. You're hunting for a "right" answer. You're judging before you've described. You're tired. Or worry is eating your attention. The move is the same for all five: shorten the session, get one small win (a thumbnail, a value strip, one slow contour), and come back tomorrow.

The on-the-go try-it shape, once

Every named try-it lists four things: **time, materials, safety, the move.** On-the-go try-its fit a pocket and a short break. Here's the shape, with one you can do today.

Slow contour of your own shoe

- **Time:** 10 minutes.
- **Materials:** a pen, a pocket sketchbook, the shoe you're wearing.
- **Safety:** on a train or bus, keep track of your stop and your bag. A parked car stays parked.
- **The move:** Put your foot where you can see it. Start at the toe and let the pen crawl along the shoe's edge exactly as slowly as your eye moves along it. Look at the shoe far more than at the page. When you meet a lace or a seam, follow it in. Stop at ten minutes, finished or not. Date it and write one line: *where did I look longest?*

It will look lumpy. The lumps are your eye slowing down, which is the point. Chapter 3 teaches this move and the looking sequence behind it.⁹

The deeper try-it shape, once

Deeper try-its belong to a desk sit or a weekend deep sit. Same four fields, more room.

A five-value study of an egg in side light

- **Time:** 30–45 minutes.
- **Materials:** an egg on a sheet of white paper, a lamp to one side, a soft pencil or three gray markers, your sketchbook.
- **Safety:** lamp heads get hot, so keep paper and cords clear. Wash your hands after graphite. The egg is a model today, not a snack.
- **The move:** First make a strip of five boxes, from white paper to your darkest dark. Squint at the egg until the detail goes and only light, middle and dark shapes remain. Draw those three shapes flat, like puzzle pieces: the lit side, the shadow side, the shadow the egg casts on the paper. Then split them into five: the brightest spot, and the darker band where the shadow side turns away from the light. Step back, take a black-and-white photo, and compare it with your strip.

“Value” means how light or dark something is, ignoring color. Almost every drawing and painting chapter leans on it.⁹

Safety spine, once

A home studio is safe and pleasant when a few habits are automatic. Here they are, said once. Chapters point back here and add what their own materials need.⁶

1. **Read the label.** Under a federal law, the Labeling of Hazardous Art Materials Act, art materials must carry labelling that meets a standard called ASTM D-4236.¹⁰ That line means the label went through a toxicologist’s review. It isn’t a “non-toxic” stamp. The Art & Creative Materials Institute’s **AP Seal** is for children in sixth grade or younger, which makes AP products the ones for a shared family table. Its **CL Seal** is for adults and older kids; read the whole label before you open the product.¹¹
2. **Keep a food line.** No eating, drinking or smoking while you work. Wash your hands afterward. Use a water jar that looks nothing like your mug.
3. **Choose water-based first.**
4. **Smell isn’t a safety test.** You can’t judge how toxic something is by whether it smells.
5. **Fresh air in, dirty air out.** Ventilation means clean air flowing toward you and used air flowing away and outside. A fan that just stirs the room isn’t ventilation, and it can make exposure worse.
6. **Lid the rags.** Rags with linseed or other drying oils can heat up and catch fire on their own. Put them in a closed metal can, or soaked in water in a sealed jar, then in the outdoor trash.^{6,12}
7. **Sprays go outside.** Aerosol fixatives and varnishes belong outdoors, or in a spray booth with a NIOSH-approved respirator. Never in the living room.
8. **Keep dust down.** Tap pastel dust off the page instead of blowing it; wipe with a damp cloth; skip pastels made with lead chromate. Oil pastels make less dust.

9. **Send the heavy processes to venues.** Darkroom chemistry, kilns, printing presses and etching belong at community studios with proper ventilation and staff.
10. **Look after eyes, hands and screen time.** Bright, even light; reading glasses or a magnifier for close work; fat grips; short, frequent breaks. Pain means stop and ask a clinician.^{13,6}
11. **Keep the studio apart.** Away from food and out of kids' reach. Exposures from a home studio can reach the rest of the household.
12. **Look after people, too.** Ask before you draw or photograph someone. Figure-drawing sessions follow the venue's code of conduct, and codes vary.¹⁴ Photos of children and family members stay off shared computers and AI tools.
13. **Poison Control: 1-800-222-1222.** Twenty-four hours a day, every day, with help in more than 100 languages.¹⁵

The AI rules, once

You hold the account. You're an adult. The children's online privacy rules (COPPA) don't apply to you, and they were never a licence for anything anyway. Try first; then, if you like, use a tool.

After your own attempt, you may:

- ask for a study plan (eight weeks of drawing, a month of color);
- ask for questions about a photo of your work, cropped to the work, with no faces;
- ask how a technique works (wet-in-wet, two-point perspective, a two-rag cleanup);
- ask for public-domain works to study, then check each one on the museum's own page;
- ask what to look at again;
- ask for a quick quiz on the terms you're learning.

By this book's rule, you don't:

- file, sign, show or sell a generated image as your work;
- trace over a generated image and sign it;
- let AI finish a piece and call it yours;
- ask for a verdict before your own step back;
- generate work "in the style of" a living artist to post or sell;
- upload photos of children or family members to AI tools or to a shared bot computer.

Why "try first." In one study of high-school math students in Turkey (not adult art learners), unrestricted chatbot practice made practice look better and left students worse once the chatbot was gone.¹⁶ A tool can prepare you. It can't practice for you.

Whose picture is it? The US Copyright Office says typing prompts doesn't make you the author of an image; what you draw, paint, arrange or meaningfully change yourself is yours.^{5,17,18} So sign only what you made, and note any tool's part on your whose-mark card.

Privacy. Many AI services keep a broad licence to whatever you upload, in some cases including the likeness of anyone pictured, and some have people review a share of chats.¹⁹ Assume a person might see what you upload. If you use Grok Bot, know that all of your bots share one computer, with the same files, browser sessions and logins, so keep photos of children and family off it.⁷ Grok (a chatbot) and Grok Bot (an agent service) are different things. Terms change; these were read at the time of writing (September 2026), so check the current page.

Work accounts. On a work device or account, open your employer's acceptable-use page first.

You can practice this entire book without any AI at all. Nothing in it depends on a tool.

A life of the habit

A practice that lasts is built from three plain things: a cue, a kit and forgiveness. The cue is something you already do every day. The kit is small enough to live where the cue happens. Forgiveness means a missed day is just a missed day. In a well-known study of how everyday habits form, missing a single day didn't materially set people back, and habits took weeks to months to settle, not days.⁴ Be patient with the first stretch.

Once a month, do the **monthly flip**: page through the month, star three pages, and write one sentence about what changed. At week 6 and again at week 12, redraw your baseline page (the mug, your hand, the corner of the room) and lay the pages side by side. After that, redraw once a season. Those redraws are this book's honest progress check, and they're usually more encouraging than you expect.

Stop a session while you still want one more line. It makes tomorrow easier to start.

A Tuesday, said plainly

Picture someone who takes the 7:40 train. (An illustration, not a real person.) On Tuesday they open a pocket sketchbook on their knee, write the date, and spend twelve minutes on the folded umbrella on the seat beside them. One stop early, they hold the book at arm's length for a minute: *handle curve works; the folds are all the same size, and they aren't*. They add a line to the strip inside the cover, *Tue, 13 min, micro, umbrella*, and put the book away. On Thursday, after dinner, they clear the end of the table for a thirty-five-minute desk sit with the chapter's try-it. On Saturday, maybe nothing, and that's fine.

That's a week of the Art Refresh Hour.

Chapter 1 — What coming back to art looks like



Why this matters

You're not the only one. In a recent national survey, about half of American adults said they had made or performed some kind of art in the past year. Far more of them had learned on their own than in a class.²⁰ So if you're sitting down with a new sketchbook after a long gap, or for the very first time, you're in large and ordinary company. You don't need anyone's permission, a degree, or

a studio. You need a pencil and a few minutes.

Here's what coming back usually looks like, honestly. The first pages feel awkward. You may remember being better than this, or you may remember a teacher who decided you weren't "the artistic one." Both memories are common, and neither predicts much. What does predict progress is what this book is built around: looking long, drawing small and often, and stepping back before you judge.

Picture three people starting the same week. (Illustrations, not real people.) One took painting in college, then spent twenty years on a career and two children, and has a box of old sketchbooks in the attic she's slightly afraid to open. One is a retired machinist who has never drawn anything but diagrams and wants to draw the birds at his feeder. One is a nurse on rotating shifts who has fifteen spare minutes on a good day and says, cheerfully, that she can't draw a straight line. They'll start in different places, and they'll use the same Hour. By week 12, each of them will be able to lay a first page beside a newer one and see a real difference. That's the promise worth making, because it's the one practice keeps.

This chapter gives you three things. The first is the most encouraging true fact about adult drawing, and what it means for where you start. The second is a baseline page: a dated snapshot of how you draw today, which you'll draw again at week 6 and week 12. The third is a rhythm that fits a real life, including the lives with the least spare time.

It also tells you plainly what art will and won't do for you, because you deserve a straight answer rather than a sales pitch. The short version: art is worth doing for itself. For seeing more, for making things with your own hands, and for the pleasure of both.

Why the awkward start is worth it. For the first few weeks, your pages will probably look worse than the pictures in your head. That gap feels discouraging, but it's actually good news in disguise. Your taste is ahead of your hand because your eye already knows what it likes. The practice in this book closes the gap from the eye's side, which is the side that turns out to matter most.

Understand it yourself

The everyday picture: the mug you already know

You've seen thousands of mugs. Somewhere in your head is a tidy file labelled MUG: a straight-sided cylinder, a round opening, a handle like an ear.

When you sit down to draw the mug in front of you, that file opens first. So you draw the opening as a circle, because you *know* it's round, even though from where you're sitting it's a squashed oval. You draw the sides straight and parallel, because you know they are, even though from here they lean slightly toward each other. You draw the handle as a neat ear, when from this angle it's a thin sliver curling out of sight.

Nothing went wrong with your hand. Your hand drew exactly what it was told. It was just told about the idea of a mug instead of the mug.

That idea is called a **symbol**. Most of us stopped growing our drawing at about the age we settled on

symbols: lollipop trees, almond eyes, a house with a triangle roof and a curl of smoke. The symbols worked well enough, so we kept them. The first stage of coming back to drawing is learning to close the file and look.

The precise picture: where drawing actually goes wrong

Two researchers, Dale Cohen and Susan Bennett, set out to answer a question with a wonderful title: why can't most people draw what they see? They tested the usual explanations one at a time, with adults who had some art training and adults who had none.

Was the trouble motor control, the hand not doing what you ask? That turned out to be a very minor source of error. Was it deciding what to put down? Relatively minor. Was it misjudging your own drawing as you went? That wasn't a source at all. The major source of error was misperceiving the object itself: seeing it, in a sense, through what you already knew about it.¹

It was a laboratory study with college students, not a promise about every adult. But it points in a clear and hopeful direction. Your hand is probably better than you think. Your eye is the thing to train.

Other research fills in what trained eyes do differently. People who draw realistically tend to resist what psychologists call **constancy**, the brain's habit of seeing things as the size and shape you know they are, rather than as they land in front of you. A plate across the table "is" round, so you see it rounder than it looks. A person at the far end of a room "is" full height, so you draw them too big. Good observational drawers also get better at picking out the visual information that matters and letting the rest go.^{21,22} Studies of artists suggest these differences grow with training, though researchers haven't fully settled which comes first. Either way, it's a skill you build, not a gift you have or lack.

You can catch constancy at work right now. Hold one hand up close to your face and the other at arm's length, both palms toward you. Your brain insists they're the same size, because you know they are. Now close one eye and compare them honestly: the far hand looks much smaller, often about half the size of the near one. Drawing from observation is largely the practice of believing the second look over the first.

The skill grows with practice

In one study, college students who took a single term of introductory drawing or painting from observation were compared with students who took no art. By the end of the term, the art students were clearly better at drawing what they saw. Their scores on basic perception tests hadn't changed.² It was a small study of young adults in one course. Its point is still the one this book leans on: the improvement showed up in the drawing, and it came from practice. Nobody had to start with special eyes.

What kind of practice? The best lever you control is practice that's focused and a little hard: a clear, small target, some way of seeing how it went, and repetition. A large review of practice research, across music, games, sports and other fields, found that this kind of practice matters but isn't the whole story. People differ for plenty of other reasons too.²³ That review didn't include visual art,

so treat it as sensible guidance rather than a formula. You may have heard that mastery takes some magic number of hours. Nobody needs to count. You need a target for today and a way to see how it went, which is exactly what the Look and Step back steps of the Hour give you.

And if you're wondering whether it's too late: a review of research on older adults found that they keep the capacity to learn new motor skills. Age differences show up more on complex tasks, and older learners may need a few more repetitions to reach the same level.²⁴ That's an argument for patience and a good setup, not for staying away.

What does a good setup look like? If close work blurs, brighter, even light and reading glasses help a great deal, and many eyes start asking for that help in middle age.¹³ If your hand tires or aches, work bigger, draw from the shoulder and elbow instead of the wrist, and try a fatter pencil or a foam grip. Chapter 3 has more on drawing comfortably.

Small and often: the rhythm that fits

Put those findings together and a rhythm falls out of them. Your eye needs regular, focused looking. Your hand needs repetition, and maybe a few more repetitions than it once did. Both need a way of seeing how it went. None of that requires long sessions. It requires frequent ones.

So the default week in this book is small and often: a daily page of ten to fifteen minutes on most days, one or two desk sits of half an hour or so, and one longer sit or outing when you can manage it. Study-habit research, mostly with students, has long found that practice spread across days tends to stick better than the same amount crammed into one sitting.²⁵ That's school learning rather than drawing, but the logic carries, and it matches what artists who keep sketchbooks have always done.

What does progress look like on that rhythm? Not overnight change. If you practice most days, you'll usually notice something within a few weeks: lines that are slower and surer, ellipses that stop looking like footballs, a mug that finally sits on the table instead of floating above it. The clearest evidence comes from the baseline redraws at week 6 and week 12, when you put the pages side by side. You'll see it with your own eyes, which is better than being told.

The brain story, gently retired

You may have heard that drawing means switching to the "right side of the brain." The exercises that came with that idea are genuinely useful: copying a drawing upside down, drawing the empty shapes between things, following an edge slowly with your eyes. The brain explanation hasn't held up. A large brain-imaging study found no evidence that people are "left-brained" or "right-brained" overall.²⁶

The exercises work for a plainer reason. They slow you down and make it hard to draw the symbol, so you end up drawing what's there. Keep them. Chapter 3 is full of them.

What art will and won't do for you

Many adults say that making art calms them, and some small studies point the same way. In one, a stress hormone measured in saliva dropped, on average, after a single session of art making, whether

or not people had any art experience.²⁷ It had no comparison group, so treat it as encouraging, not proof. A large World Health Organization review mapped hundreds of studies on the arts and health. It's a map of promising evidence of mixed quality, not a prescription.²⁸

So if your daily page leaves you calmer, enjoy that. It's a real and common experience. But a home sketchbook isn't art therapy, which is a licensed clinical field, and nothing in this book treats anything.

Art won't make you smarter, either. Large reviews found no good evidence that studying visual art raises general academic or verbal skills.^{29,30} Art is worth doing for itself; it won't raise your test scores, and it doesn't need to.

Wrong turns you'll hear (including from yourself)

"I have no talent." Usually means: I haven't trained my seeing yet. That's not the same thing, and it's fixable. The move: do the baseline page this week, then a slow contour (the shoe in *The Art Refresh Hour*) on the train.

"I'm too old for this." Usually means: my setup is fighting me. Dim light, small paper and a thin pencil gripped tight would make anyone's drawing worse. The move: brighten the light, go bigger, loosen the grip, draw from the shoulder.

"I'll start when I have a free weekend." Usually means: perfectionism dressed up as scheduling. The perfect weekend rarely arrives, and when it does it carries too much weight. The move: fifteen minutes today, and a week of one-inch drawings.

"I'll just trace photos for now." Tracing can be a useful study, labelled as one. But it skips the part you most need, which is your eye doing the flattening of a real object onto paper. The move: draw from the object first; trace afterward, if you like, to compare.

"It has to be good to count." Every page counts as practice, especially the bad ones, which usually teach the most. The move: date it, write one line, turn the page.

A five-minute warm-up: your other hand

Set a timer for five minutes. Rest your non-drawing hand on the table in a relaxed pose.

Draw it slowly, looking at your hand far more than at the page, three or four seconds on the hand for every glance at the paper. Follow one edge at a time: the side of the thumb, the crease at a knuckle, the line where a nail meets skin. When the timer goes, stop.

It will look strange. Look at it anyway, and find one place where the line really does match what you saw. That place is your eye doing its job.

How to try it this week

The Hour this week, in three bands

Run the Hour as *The Art Refresh Hour* describes it. This week, it looks like this.

Commute or lunch (about 15–20 minutes). Look: pick one small object, like a key, a coin or a bottle cap. Sketch: a one-inch drawing (the one-inch return, below) or a daily page. Step back: hold it at arm's length and write one line. File: date it. On one of these sessions this week, write your why card instead.

Desk or shift (about 25–40 minutes). The baseline page, the first try-it below. Look at the mug for three full minutes before you start, and let yourself notice how far the opening is from a circle. Do the page. Skip the step back for now; the baseline page gets filed untouched, and you'll step back from the whole week at the end.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes). The old-sketchbook audit, if you have old work (or its alternative, if you don't), followed by an unhurried drawing of the baseline mug from a new angle, as long as you like, with a step back halfway through. If you'd rather get out of the house, a single room of a museum with a pencil makes a good first outing; Chapter 6 shows how.

At the end of the week, spread everything out and run this chapter's talk-to-yourself box.

A word about time

If you're in your late thirties or early forties, working, perhaps with young children, you likely have less free time than almost anyone. The national time-use survey puts that age group's leisure at just under four hours a day on average, the lowest of any age.³¹ Much of it arrives in scraps. That's exactly why this book counts fifteen minutes as a real session.

If you're retired, you may have more hours and the opposite challenge: structure. A long empty afternoon can be harder to start than a short full one. The same Hour works for both of you. One of you will live in commute-sized sessions for a while; the other in deep sits.

Your first week, day by day

If it helps to see the week laid out, here's one way. It's a sketch, not a schedule; move the days around to fit your life.

- **Day 1 (desk):** the baseline page, then the why card if you have ten minutes left.
- **Day 2 (commute or lunch):** a one-inch drawing.
- **Day 3 (commute or lunch):** a one-inch drawing, and the five-minute warm-up with your other hand.
- **Day 4 (desk):** the old-sketchbook audit, or its alternative.
- **Day 5 (commute or lunch):** a one-inch drawing, or skip it. A missed day is fine.
- **Weekend (deep sit or outing):** the long drawing of the mug from a new angle, or one room of a museum with a pencil.

- **End of the week (ten minutes):** spread everything out, run the talk-to-yourself box, and write one line on your practice strip.

That's about two and a half hours across a whole week, most of it in small pieces. It's enough.

Words to say to yourself

- Before you start: "Draw what's there, not what I know."
- When the symbol sneaks in: "Is that what I see, or what I know?"
- Midway, when it's going badly: "Keep going. The middle always looks like this."
- At the end: "One thing that works. One thing to try."
- When the voice from school shows up: "Noted. Back to the mug."

The first try-it: the baseline page

- **Time:** about 30 minutes, in one sitting.
- **Materials:** a pencil, three pages of a sketchbook or three sheets of paper, a mug, your non-drawing hand, a corner of the room, a timer.
- **Safety:** nothing beyond a comfortable chair and good light.
- **The move:** Ten minutes each: the mug, your hand, and a corner of the room where two walls meet the floor or ceiling. Draw for the full ten minutes even if you think you've finished; look again and add what you missed. No erasing. If a line is wrong, draw the better line next to it and leave both. Write the date on each page. Then put the pages somewhere safe and leave them alone.

If you freeze: draw anything at all for the full ten minutes. The only way to "fail" a baseline page is to stop early.

Why it matters: nobody grades this page. It's your "before" photo. At week 6 and week 12 you'll draw the same three things again and lay the pages side by side (Chapter 9 shows how). Most people are glad they didn't skip it, especially the ones who least wanted to do it.

What the baseline page can tell you

Wait a day before you look at the baseline page again, and when you do, look the way a good teacher would: curious, not grading.

Notice the mug first. Is the opening a circle or an oval? Do the sides lean together slightly, or stand straight like a tin can? A circle and straight sides usually mean the symbol was doing the drawing, which is completely normal and exactly what the next few weeks work on.

Then the hand. Are the fingers all the same length and width? Real fingers aren't; a hand drawn from the file usually has five matching sausages. Is there a thumb that actually attaches where your thumb attaches?

Then the corner. Does the line where the walls meet stand upright, or does it tip? Does the floor seem to slope?

Write down one thing you noticed on each drawing, and nothing about whether it's "good." Those three notes are your starting targets. They'll also make the week-6 redraw far more interesting, because you'll know what to look for.

How to fade help, including help from a tool

This week the help you might reach for is a photo, an eraser, a tutorial or a chatbot. Here's the order to use them in, and how to let them go.

Start with the real object, not a photo of it. A photo has already flattened the mug onto a flat surface for you, and that flattening is the exact job your eye is learning. Keep the eraser in the drawer for the baseline page, and use it sparingly afterward; the wrong line left beside the right one shows you what you corrected. If you watch a tutorial, watch it after your own attempt, then try again with it switched off. If you use an AI tool, use it only once the baseline page is dated and put away, and only for the kinds of help listed in the Hour's AI box.

The order is always the same: your try, your step back, then help. As the weeks go on, reach for help later and less often.

When to stop fiddling

The timer decides. When ten minutes are up on a baseline drawing, you stop, even mid-line. A one-inch drawing is done when the square is full.

Fiddling usually means you've stopped looking at the subject and started staring at the page. If you catch yourself at it, look up at the object for a slow count of five. If there's something new to see, draw it. If there isn't, you're done.

Practice that actually builds it

These try-its come from this chapter's small bank.³² The baseline page above is the deeper sit; the rest fit a pocket, a lunch break or an evening. Pick what fits your week.

On the go: the why card

- **Time:** 10 minutes.
- **Materials:** an index card and a pen.
- **Safety:** none.
- **The move:** Write one line: why art, and why now. Then a second line: what a good month would look like. Make it concrete ("twenty dated pages," "one museum visit," "I drew the dog asleep and it looked like her"). Tape the card inside your sketchbook's front cover. Reread it when a week goes badly.

If you're stuck: finish the sentence "I'd like to be the kind of person who..."

Picture someone's card (an illustration, not a real person's): *"I used to draw every day and I miss how quiet my head got. A good month: the sketchbook comes to work with me, and I use it on three lunches a week."* That's a good why card. It's honest, it's specific, and nobody else has to like it.

On the go: the one-inch return

- **Time:** 5–10 minutes a day, for a week.
- **Materials:** a pen and a small book.
- **Safety:** none.
- **The move:** Each day, draw one small thing (a key, a spoon, a leaf, a bottle cap) inside a square one inch on each side. Draw the square first. Look at the object longer than you draw. Date each one.

If you're stuck: draw it twice in two squares side by side, once fast and once slow. Notice which one has more of the real object in it.

Why it works: a one-inch square is too small to be intimidating and just big enough to need real looking. Seven of them in a week is a genuine return.

Variations, once the week is done: keep the square but change the subject's difficulty (a crumpled receipt is harder than a coin), or keep the subject and draw it in one-inch squares at three different times of day, so the light changes. Some people keep the habit for months as a warm-up. It's a good one.

Desk sit: the old-sketchbook audit

- **Time:** 20 minutes.
- **Materials:** any old art you have (a school portfolio, a college sketchbook, a drawing on the back of an envelope), sticky notes and a pen.
- **Safety:** go gently. Old work can bring up old feelings, and it's fine to stop and come back another day.
- **The move:** Look through the old work as if it belonged to someone you like. Put a "keep" note on three things you still like, whether a line, a color or a way of framing something, and write what each one is. Put one "drop" note on a habit you'd like to leave behind, such as outlining everything in heavy black or always parking the subject in the dead center of the page.

If you have no old work: look at five pieces, online or in a library book, that you wish you'd made, and name one thing each one does that you'd like to learn.

Exit: three keeps and one drop, stuck inside the back cover of your new sketchbook.

A small warning, kindly meant: former art students sometimes find their old work better than they expected, and that can sting. It's useful information. It means the eye and hand were once trained, and trained things come back faster than new ones.

Talk-to-yourself box

Opening: “What did I make this week that I’d happily make again — and what made it worth the time?”

Use it at the end of your first week, with the baseline page, the one-inch drawings and any daily pages spread out on the table.

Follow-ups (choose three or four):

- **Meaning:** “When I say ‘worth the time,’ do I mean it looked good, it felt good to make, or I learned something? Which one?”
- **Representation:** “If I cover the parts I dislike, what does the rest of the page actually show?”
- **Alternative:** “What else made that session good: the time of day, the object, the pen, the place?”
- **Check:** “How will I know next week whether I’m doing more of what worked?”
- **Revise:** “I’m allowed to change my mind about why I’m doing this. Does my why card still say it?”

How to wait alone. Ask the question, then look at the pages, not your phone. Count a slow three. If nothing comes, turn the pages face down, make a cup of tea somewhere other than the art table, and turn them back over. You’ll usually see at least one page differently.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question felt too big (“worth the time” can quietly turn into “worth doing at all”). You’re hunting for a right answer. You’re judging before you’ve described. You’re tired. Or the old voice from school is louder than usual this week. Make the question smaller: “Which one drawing would I do again tomorrow?” Point to it. That’s your answer for today. The rest can wait.

What it can sound like. Here’s one person’s end-of-week talk, as an illustration. “*What would I happily make again? The bottle cap on Thursday. Why? Honestly, it felt good because I finished it on the train before my stop. Meaning: so ‘worth it’ meant ‘finished,’ not ‘pretty.’ Representation: if I cover the wobbly shadow, the ridges on the edge are actually right; I counted them. Check: next week, do I finish more than I abandon? Revise: my why card says I want to feel calm. Finishing small things is calm. Keep the one-inch squares.*” Nothing in that is a verdict on talent. It’s a person noticing what works and deciding what to do next, which is the whole job.

Blocked and mixed practice

For a new move, do it several times in a row the same way. This week that’s the one-inch return: seven days, same size square, same slow look. That’s called blocked practice, and it builds a habit and a move quickly.

Once the move feels familiar, mix it. Next week, alternate: a one-inch drawing on Monday, a full daily page on Tuesday, a slow contour on Wednesday, the mug again on Thursday. Mixed practice feels a bit harder and a bit less satisfying, because you have to decide each time which move a subject needs. That deciding is the skill you’ll actually use.

One incorrect example to diagnose

Picture two drawings of an eye, side by side. (An illustration, not anyone's real page.)

The first is an almond shape outlined in one firm line. In the middle sits a perfect circle with a dark dot inside it. A row of evenly spaced lashes sticks straight out along the top, like a picket fence. It's neat, and anyone would read it instantly as "eye."

The second was drawn by someone looking in a mirror. The upper lid is a thick, shadowed shelf that overhangs the eye. Only part of the iris shows, because the lid cuts off its top. A small, bright highlight sits off to one side. The white of the eye isn't white; it's a pale gray that darkens toward the corners. There are hardly any separate lashes, just a dark edge along the lid. The lower lid is barely a line at all, more a slight change in tone.

Ask: **what did the first drawer know, and what did the second drawer see?**

The first drawer knew that eyes are almond-shaped, that irises are circles, and that eyes have lashes. All true, and all drawn from the file rather than the face. The second drawer saw the lid as a form with thickness, saw the iris cut off by it, saw the white as a shade of gray rather than a color name, and saw lashes as a dark edge rather than a row of hairs. The second drawer's hand isn't more skilled. The eye did the work.

Your move: the next time you draw anything you have a strong idea about, whether an eye, a tree, a hand or a house, stop halfway and ask, "Is this what I see, or what I know?"

If it isn't clicking

Every page feels bad

The first weeks can feel like a string of disappointments.

Next move: make the goal showing up, not a good page. Do the one-inch return; a tiny square is easy to finish. Add a permission page, a page you declare in advance doesn't count, drawn with your other hand or a pen you dislike (Chapter 2 has the full try-it). Date every page, including the bad ones. In six weeks, the bad ones are your best evidence of progress.

There's no time

The week fills up before the sketchbook comes out.

Next move: for two weeks, do commute or lunch sessions only. A daily page or a one-inch drawing, nothing more. Put the kit where your day already goes: the work bag, the car, the coat pocket. Fifteen minutes on four days is an hour of drawing a week. That's a real practice.

The old judgment from school keeps replaying

Something a teacher, a parent or a classmate said, years ago, turns up every time you open the book.

Next move: reread the why card. It's your reason, not theirs. Read the "keep" notes from your old-sketchbook audit. And consider company: a drop-in class at a community center, library or art league puts you in a room of adults with rust of their own, which is surprisingly comforting. Chapter 10 describes how to find one that fits.

When to slow down, go on, or ask a human

Slow down if you've started dreading sessions. Make them shorter, not fewer.

Go on to Chapter 2 once you have a baseline page, a why card and a week of small drawings, however they look.

Ask a human (a class, a teacher, a sketch group, a librarian) whenever you'd like company, a demonstration or another pair of eyes. That isn't a failure. It's how most artists have always learned.

Nerves and perfectionism

Many adults find the first weeks bring up more worry than they expected. Short sessions help. So does an early win: a one-inch drawing is finished in five minutes. So does a permission page, which takes the pressure off by design.

This book isn't a therapy manual. If worry about drawing turns out to be part of something bigger, a person you trust is a better help than a chapter. For the ordinary nerves of starting something new, shrink the session, keep the date on the page, and come back tomorrow.

Tools, including AI

A few simple helpers earn their place this week.

- **A viewfinder card:** a small rectangle cut out of an index card. Hold it up to frame your subject, and it tells you what's in the picture and what's out.
- **A pencil for measuring:** hold it at arm's length, one eye closed, to compare the mug's height with its width. Chapter 3 teaches measuring properly.
- **Your phone's camera:** photograph the baseline page the day you draw it, so you have a copy even if the paper goes astray.

The full AI rules are in *The Art Refresh Hour*, and they apply here as everywhere. One use that fits this chapter: once your baseline page is dated and put away, you may ask a chatbot for an eight-week plan of short drawing sessions, telling it how much time you really have and where you'd like to be at the end, and then adjust the plan to your life. One this book rules out: asking a tool to generate "what my drawing should look like." A generated picture of a perfect mug tells your eye nothing about the mug on your table, and it quietly swaps your target for someone else's.

What “done enough” looks like

Before moving on to Chapter 2, check:

- ☐ A dated baseline page (mug, hand, corner), photographed and put away untouched.
- ☐ A why card taped inside your sketchbook cover.
- ☐ Seven one-inch drawings or seven daily pages, dated. Missed days are fine; seven pages across ten days count.
- ☐ One talk-to-yourself session with this chapter’s opening, and one line written down.
- ☐ Three “keep” notes and one “drop” note from the old-sketchbook audit, or its alternative.
- ☐ You can say the book’s focus line from memory (it heads *If You Only Remember Five Things*).

Placement by skill, not age. If your baseline page is already solid, you still do the why card and a week of small drawings. You’ll just move through them faster. A retired engineer who measures beautifully and an art-school graduate twelve years out use the same checklist. They finish it differently, and that’s the point.

Revisit next week. Reread your why card on Sunday. Next weekend, ask this chapter’s opening question again with the new week’s pages. The answer usually changes, and the change is worth noticing.

Chapter 2 — Sketchbook, home studio and tools



Why this matters

Practice needs a home. For an adult coming back to art, that home is two things: a sketchbook that actually gets used, and a corner where you can start in two minutes and stop safely.

The sketchbook is where practice lives. Not the finished pieces; those come later, and there are fewer of them. The sketchbook holds the daily page, the thumbnails before a bigger drawing, the

page that went sideways and taught you something, the spread of one stubborn object from six angles. Kept, dated and mostly private, it becomes the clearest record you'll ever have of how your seeing is changing. Flip back three months and the evidence is right there, in your own hand.

A studio doesn't have to be a room. For most adults it's the end of a kitchen table, a desk corner, a folding table by a window, or a rolling cart that tucks into a closet. What makes it a studio isn't square footage. It's that your things have a place, the light is good, the air moves the right way, food stays on the other side of a line, and the materials you use have had their labels read.

That last part, safety, sounds more serious than it is. For the materials most adults start with (pencil, pen, watercolor, gouache, acrylic), a safe studio comes down to a handful of habits you set up once this week and then stop thinking about. The heavier processes, like oil paint, sprays, darkroom chemistry and kilns, have their own rules and their own chapters.

Why the friction is worth it. On some days the daily page will feel pointless, and setting up a corner will feel like housework. Push through a few weeks of that and you get two things that run on their own: a habit that no longer needs a decision, and a corner where starting is easier than not starting. That's most of what an adult practice is.

Understand it yourself

The everyday picture: running shoes by the door

People who run most mornings rarely decide, each morning, to go for a run. The shoes are by the door, the route is familiar, and something that already happens (the alarm, the coffee, first light) sets the whole thing off. The real decision was made once, when they put the shoes there.

A sketchbook habit works the same way. You don't want to decide every day whether to draw. You want a small book and a pen sitting where your day already passes (beside the coffee maker, in the outside pocket of your work bag, on the passenger seat) so the cue does the deciding for you.

The studio is the same idea at a larger size. When every material has a place, starting costs almost nothing, and the few things that need care are always where they should be.

The precise picture: how a habit forms

Research on habits gives you three useful facts. In one well-known study, volunteers chose a small daily behavior around eating, drinking or activity, and did it in the same setting each day. It became automatic gradually, on a curve that rose quickly at first and then leveled off. For the typical person it took around two months to get close to fully automatic, and the spread was wide: some people got there in a few weeks, others took the better part of a year. And missing a single day didn't materially set anyone back.⁴

That study was about simple daily behaviors, not drawing, and your own curve will be your own. But the lessons carry straight over to the daily page:

- **Tie it to a cue you already have.** Coffee, the train, the end of lunch, the ten minutes after dinner.

- **Keep the action small enough to do on a bad day.** Ten minutes and one object.
- **Expect weeks to months, not a set number of days.** The first stretch is the hardest, and it's supposed to be.
- **Forgive the missed day.** Open the book tomorrow as if nothing happened, because, as far as the habit is concerned, nothing much did.

What goes in a working sketchbook

A working sketchbook holds several kinds of page. You won't do all of them every week, but over a month or two they all show up.

- **The daily page.** Ten to fifteen minutes, dated, one thing in front of you, one line of writing underneath.
- **Thumbnails.** Small compositions, a couple of inches across, drawn before any bigger piece. Nine to a page, each one changing one thing. ("Composition" just means how the picture is arranged: what's in it, where things sit, what's cut off by the edge.)
- **Permission pages.** Pages you declare in advance don't count: a tool you dislike, your other hand, the lights dimmed.
- **Pages of one subject.** The same object from six angles and two sizes, so you get to know it.
- **Line warm-ups.** Straight lines, circles and ellipses from the shoulder, before a longer session.
- **The monthly flip.** Not a page so much as a habit: once a month, you page back through and notice what's changed.

Three rules make it work. **Date every page**, so the book becomes a record. **Keep the bad pages**; a torn-out page is a missing piece of evidence, and bad pages usually teach the most. **Private by default**; a sketchbook you expect others to judge turns into a book of safe, careful pages, and the practice quietly stops. Show pages when you choose to, not because the book exists.

What a month of pages can look like

Here's an illustration, a composite rather than anyone's real book. Pages 1 to 4 are careful and stiff: a mug, a lemon, a stapler, all small and pressed into the middle of the page. Page 5 is blank except for the date and a note, *too tired, drew the lemon again tomorrow*, which is honest and counts. Page 7 is the first permission page, a ballpoint scribble of the cat, and it's livelier than anything before it. Page 11 is a thumbnail page before a weekend drawing of the window; two thumbnails are starred. Pages 14 to 19 have started to use the whole page. There's a smudge on 16 and a coffee ring on none of them, because the food line held. Page 22 is the page of one subject, a running shoe from six sides. The monthly flip note reads: *drawings got bigger; I stopped erasing so much*.

Nothing in that month is a masterpiece. All of it is practice, and the flip makes the change easy to see.

The kit

A starting kit is small: one pencil (a soft one, such as a 2B, is friendly), one pen that doesn't smear, and one cheap sketchbook. Cheap matters. Expensive paper makes every mark feel as though it has to earn its keep. If you plan to add watercolor or ink washes, choose a book of heavier mixed-media paper so it doesn't buckle when wet. At home, add a lamp that gives bright, even light and a board you can tilt.

Think of spending in four tiers, and start at the bottom:

- **\$0:** library technique books and artist monographs; museum passes that many libraries lend; free museum days; museums' free online collections of public-domain images; free drawing software; the pencil already in your kitchen drawer.
- **Low:** a small watercolor set, two or three brushes, heavier paper, a drawing board, a drop-in class.
- **Middle:** gouache or acrylics, painting panels, a tabletop easel, a multi-week class or a pass for open drawing sessions.
- **Venue:** membership at a community darkroom, clay studio or print shop.

Chapter 10 shows you how to find the free and low-cost options near you, by fit rather than by ranking.

The corner studio

Here's what a corner needs.

- **Light.** Daylight from a window if you can get it, plus a lamp you can aim. Bright, even light matters more every decade.
- **A washable surface** and a board to work on.
- **A shelf or rolling cart with a lid**, where materials live with their labels facing out.
- **A tray** for the day's materials, so setting up is one motion and putting away is another.
- **A water jar that looks nothing like your mug.** An old jam jar with a strip of colored tape, a plastic cup in a loud color. You want to be unable to mix them up while you're concentrating.
- **Paper towels and a lidded trash can.**
- **A way to move air:** a window that opens and, ideally, a fan that can sit in a window and blow air out.
- **Comfort.** A chair with support, a tilted board or tabletop easel to save your wrist and neck, and the option to stand.

If you rent or live small, a folding table, a closet bin and water-based materials make a perfectly good studio. The kitchen table works too, as long as the tray and bin come out and go back, and the food line holds.

Reading a label

Most art materials sold in the US carry two things worth understanding.

The first is a line saying the product conforms to **ASTM D-4236**. A federal law, the Labeling of Hazardous Art Materials Act, made this labelling standard mandatory for art materials.¹⁰ It means the product's label went through a toxicologist's review for any long-term hazards. It doesn't mean "non-toxic." It means: the label tells you what you need to know, so read it.

The second may be a seal from the Art & Creative Materials Institute, which runs a certification program for art materials. The **AP Seal** marks products for children in sixth grade or younger. If you make art with kids at a shared table, AP products are the ones to put out for everyone. The **CL Seal** marks products for adults and kids older than sixth grade, and the rule that comes with it is simple: read the product label in full before opening, and follow what it says.¹¹ A CL Seal isn't a warning sign; plenty of good adult materials carry one. It's an instruction to read.

For anything with no readable label, whether an unmarked jar or a hand-me-down set with the wrapper gone, keep it well away from food and kids, or replace it.

The food line, water first, and your nose

The federal art-safety guide is plain about everyday habits. No eating, drinking or smoking while you work. Choose water-based products over solvent-based ones. And you can't judge how toxic a material is by whether it smells.⁶

That last one catches people out. A strong smell isn't proof of danger, and no smell isn't proof of safety. So the food line is a physical line, not a feeling: the coffee on a different table, a water jar you can't mistake for your mug, and hands washed before the snack.

Fresh air in, dirty air out

"Ventilation" is the most misunderstood word in the home studio. The guide defines it well: adequate ventilation means clean air flowing toward you and contaminated air flowing away. Blowing air around with a fan, without a source of clean air, isn't adequate and can actually increase your exposure.⁶

In practice, you want a source of fresh air (an open window or door) and a way for used air to leave (a fan in another window, set to blow out, or an exhaust fan), arranged so the air crosses your work and exits. The water-based materials most people start with ask much less of you, which is one more reason to start with them. When a product's label asks for ventilation, set up the crossing flow before you open it. If you can't, choose a water-based material until you can.

Write your plan down in one line. For example: *"Window by the table open; box fan in the back-door screen blowing out; anything labelled 'use with adequate ventilation' only when both are going."*

Keep it apart

The guide also notes that family members can be exposed to fumes from a home studio with poor ventilation, even one tucked away in a basement, and it advises keeping studios separate from living areas and cleaning up before you go back into them.⁶

For most adults with a corner studio, that means materials in a lidded bin or closed cart, not on the kitchen counter; nothing within reach of small children or pets; and hands washed and the surface wiped at the end of each session.

Oil paint and its rag rule get full treatment in Chapter 4. Sprays, darkroom chemistry, kilns and presses are in Chapter 5. The whole safety spine, including the Poison Control number, is in *The Art Refresh Hour*.

Wrong turns you'll hear (including from yourself)

"I need good supplies before I start." Usually means: I'm hoping the materials will guarantee the result. They won't, and nice paper tends to make people freeze. The move: a cheap book and one pen now; good paper later, for pieces you've planned in thumbnails.

"Sketchbooks are for finished drawings." Usually means the sketchbook has quietly become a gallery. The move: a permission page this week, dates on everything, thumbnails before anything careful.

"I missed three days, so I've failed." Usually means the habit is being judged as a streak. Habits don't work that way, and a missed day doesn't reset you. The move: open the book today.

"That marker says non-toxic, so it's fine to use anywhere." Usually means a marketing word has been taken for a safety rating. The move: read the whole label, look for the seal, and keep the food line anyway.

A five-minute warm-up: lines from the shoulder

Cheap paper and a pen. Stand if you can.

Scatter a dozen dots across the page. Connect pairs of dots with straight lines, moving your whole arm from the shoulder rather than your wrist. Hover over the line once to aim, then make one confident stroke. Next, a row of circles, each in one motion. Then a row of ellipses (flattened circles), some fat, some thin.

Five minutes. They'll wobble; that's why it's called a warm-up. Do it before desk sits and deep sits for two weeks and notice the day your lines start landing where you aimed.

If you're stuck: stand up and use a bigger page. Small paper invites the wrist back in.

Exit: the warm-up done before every desk or deep sit for two weeks.

How to try it this week

The Hour this week, in three bands

Run the Hour as *The Art Refresh Hour* describes it. This week it looks like this.

Commute or lunch (about 15–20 minutes). The daily page, tied to the cue you choose. Look for a minute or two at one object; draw it for ten to thirteen; step back at arm's length for a minute; date it and add a line to your practice strip. Once this week, do a permission page instead.

Desk or shift (about 25–40 minutes). Two desk sits if you can manage them.

The first sets up your corner, and yes, it counts as an Hour. Look: stand in the space and notice where the light comes from and where air could come in and go out. Sketch: a quick floor plan of the corner in your sketchbook. Make: set it up (the studio corner, read the label, the food line, and fresh air in, dirty air out, all in the next section). Step back: sit in the chair and reach for things; what's awkward? File: write your one-line ventilation plan and date it.

The second is nine thumbnails before a drawing, with the line warm-up first.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes). The page of one subject: one object, six angles, two sizes, a full two-page spread. Warm up first; step back halfway through; run this chapter's talk-to-yourself box at the end.

Words to say to yourself

- To start: "Date it first." Writing the date gets the pen moving, and starting is the hard part.
- "This page is practice, not a performance."
- "Small enough to do on a bad day."
- Before opening anything new: "What does this label tell me, and what doesn't it?"
- When a page goes wrong: "Turn the page. Keep it. What did it teach me?"

The first try-it: the daily page

- **Time:** 10–15 minutes, most days.
- **Materials:** a sketchbook, a pen or pencil, one thing in front of you.
- **Safety:** keep the food line even here. If you draw at breakfast, the coffee sits on the far side of the book.
- **The move:** Write the date. Draw one thing that's in front of you: the pepper grinder, your keys, the parking lot through the windshield. Stop when the timer goes. Underneath, write one line about something you noticed: *the grinder's shadow is longer than the grinder.*

If you're stuck: keep a list of thirty ordinary objects inside the back cover. When you can't think what to draw, take the next one on the list.

Exit: twenty dated pages in a month. Missed days are fine.

How to fade help, including help from a tool

In the first weeks, lean on structure: the timer, the list of thirty objects, the cue. As the habit settles, drop the list and choose from whatever's in front of you. If you've been using a prompt list from a book, a website or a chatbot, keep it only until you've written your own; then retire it. Your own list is better because it's made of things you actually have.

With labels, outside help is welcome (a friend who knows materials, the maker's own website), but read the label yourself first. The habit you're building is reading, not asking.

When to stop fiddling

For the daily page, the timer ends it. For the corner, stop when you can set up for a daily page in two minutes and clean up in five. A studio can always be improved, and the improvements can wait until you know how you actually work. For thumbnails, stop at nine, star two, and move on. They're meant to be rough; a polished thumbnail is a small piece that forgot its job.

Practice that actually builds it

Every try-it here comes from this chapter's bank: seven sketchbook habits and the first four safety habits.³³ The daily page and the line warm-up are above. Everything that follows uses the shape from *The Art Refresh Hour*.

On the go: the cue and the kit

- **Time:** 15 minutes to set up, then seconds a day.
- **Materials:** a small pouch, a pencil, a pen, an eraser, a pocket sketchbook.
- **Safety:** none.
- **The move:** Pack the kit. Choose one daily cue you already have: the first coffee, sitting down on the train, the end of lunch, the ten minutes after dinner. Put the kit where that cue happens, and leave it there.

If you're stuck: shrink the kit to one pen and one book.

Exit: the kit is with you on five days out of seven.

On the go: the permission page

- **Time:** 10 minutes.
- **Materials:** your sketchbook and a tool you dislike or haven't tried (a brush pen, a ballpoint, a stick of charcoal, a twig dipped in ink), or simply your other hand.
- **Safety:** with charcoal or soft pastel, tap the dust off the page instead of blowing it, and wipe up with a damp cloth.⁶
- **The move:** Fill a page roughly, on purpose. Title it "permission." Underneath, write one line about something the tool did that you didn't expect.

If you're stuck: dim the lights, or half-close your eyes.

Exit: one permission page a week for a month.

Desk sit: nine thumbnails

- **Time:** 20 minutes.

- **Materials:** a sketchbook, a pencil, a subject (a small still life, a view from the window, a photo you took yourself).
- **Safety:** none.
- **The move:** Before any bigger piece, draw nine small rectangles, about two inches across, on one page. In each, draw the whole composition in a minute or two, changing one thing each time: how close you crop, your viewpoint, where the horizon sits, where the darkest shapes go. Write what changed beside each. Star two. Make the bigger piece from one of them.

If you're stuck: draw the first one nine times and move only the horizon line.

Exit: every finished piece has a thumbnail page behind it.

Deeper sit: the page of one subject

- **Time:** 30 minutes, or longer on a weekend.
- **Materials:** a sketchbook, a pencil or pen, one object with some character: a shoe, a kettle, a bell pepper, a pair of scissors.
- **Safety:** if it's scissors, keep them closed and pointing away from you.
- **The move:** Fill one two-page spread with the same object: six angles and two sizes, a couple large and several small. Turn the object between drawings. Watch what changes: the shape of the opening, how the handle overlaps the body, where the shadow falls. File it with the date and a short whose-mark card: title, date, "all mine."

If you're stuck: turn the object 45 degrees between drawings, like the hand of a clock.

Exit: a full spread.

Desk sit, once a month: the monthly flip

- **Time:** 15 minutes.
- **Materials:** the month's pages, three sticky tabs, your practice strip.
- **Safety:** be kind. This is a review, not a trial.
- **The move:** Page through the month. Tab three pages: the ones that taught you something, which aren't always the prettiest. Write one sentence on your practice strip about what changed: *my lines got slower, and my ellipses stopped being footballs.*

If you're stuck: compare only the first page and the last.

Exit: a monthly note on the strip.

Studio setup: read the label

- **Time:** about 5 minutes per product.
- **Materials:** the art supplies you already own.
- **Safety:** read before opening. Anything without a readable label goes on a separate shelf, away from food and kids.
- **The move:** For each product, find three things: an ASTM D-4236 line, an ACMI seal (AP or CL), and any warnings or directions. Sort into three groups. AP products: fine for the shared

family table. CL and other labelled products: read the whole label, follow its directions, adults' shelf. No readable label: keep away from food and kids, and consider replacing it.

Exit: a shelf where every product has a readable label, and you've read it.

Studio setup: the food line

- **Time:** 2 minutes, then a month of habit.
- **Materials:** a tray or board, and a water jar that looks nothing like your mug.
- **Safety:** this one is the safety.
- **The move:** Decide where the line is: the edge of the tray, the end of the table. Art on one side. Coffee, snacks and phone on the other. Wash your hands at the end of every session and before you eat.

If you're stuck: put the mug on a different table altogether.

Exit: the habit holds for a month.

Studio setup: fresh air in, dirty air out

- **Time:** 10 minutes.
- **Materials:** a window that opens; a window fan or exhaust fan if you have one.
- **Safety:** a fan on its own isn't ventilation. It needs a source of fresh air and a way out.
- **The move:** Stand where you work. Find where clean air can come in (a window, a door) and where used air can go out (another window with a fan blowing outward, an exhaust fan). Arrange things so the air crosses your work and leaves, instead of blowing into your face or just circling the room. Write your one-line ventilation plan and tape it inside a cupboard door.

If you're stuck: stay with water-based materials until you can set up the flow.

Exit: a written one-line plan.

Desk sit: the studio corner

- **Time:** 30 minutes.
- **Materials:** a corner, a shelf or rolling cart, a lidded bin, a lamp.
- **Safety:** materials out of the kitchen and out of reach of small children and pets.
- **The move:** Choose your corner. Put the materials in the lidded bin or cart, labels facing out. Aim the lamp. Set out the tray and the water jar. On the shelf, tape an index card with the Poison Control number (copy it from the safety spine in *The Art Refresh Hour*) and your one-line ventilation plan.

If you're stuck: a rolling cart you can close and park in a closet.

Exit: a corner a visitor could recognize as the studio.

Talk-to-yourself box

Opening: “Which page went wrong this week — and what did it teach my eye or my hand?”

Use it at the end of the week, or as part of the monthly flip. Find the page first, and put your finger on it.

Follow-ups (choose three or four):

- **Meaning:** “What do I mean by ‘wrong’? The proportions, a smudge, a dull subject, or did I stop looking halfway?”
- **Representation:** “What does the thumbnail page show that the bigger drawing lost?”
- **Alternative:** “Was it my eye, my hand, or my setup: the light, the chair, the pen?”
- **Check:** “If I drew this again tomorrow, what one thing would I watch, and how would I know it worked?”
- **Revise:** “I’m allowed to decide this page went right in a way I didn’t plan.”

How to wait alone. Keep your finger on the page and look at it, not at your phone. Count a slow three. If nothing comes, close the book, look at the actual object for a minute if it’s handy, then open the page again. What a bad page has to teach usually turns up on the second look. (The slow count is a teaching habit borrowed from classrooms, not a rule; the point is simply not to rescue yourself in the first second.)

A sample answer, so you can hear the shape. (An illustration.) “The pepper grinder on Thursday went wrong. What I mean by wrong: it leans, like it’s had a long week. The thumbnail I did first was straight, so I lost it in the big drawing. Eye or hand? Setup, mostly; I drew it from the side of the table, with the book flat, so everything drifted. Tomorrow I’ll tilt the board and check the vertical against the pencil held straight up. And honestly, the leaning one has more life in it than the thumbnail.” That’s enough. Two or three minutes, and next week’s page already has a plan.

What a stuck silence usually means. Sometimes every page feels wrong, so none stands out. Sometimes none does, because the sketchbook has turned into a gallery of safe pages. Both are useful information. The usual culprits apply too: the question is vague, you’re hunting for a right answer, you’re judging before describing, you’re tired, or worry has the floor. Pick the page you’d least like anyone to see, write one neutral fact about it (“the left side is darker than the right”), and stop there for today. Tomorrow, get one quick win first, such as a single thumbnail or a one-minute contour, then come back to the question.

Blocked and mixed practice

Blocked, for the new habit. For one week, do nine thumbnails before every piece bigger than a daily page, however small the piece. By the end of the week the thumbnails start happening without a decision.

Mixed, for choosing when. The next week, decide each time. A daily page gets no thumbnails. A desk sit gets three. A weekend piece gets nine. Judging how much planning a piece needs is its own skill, and you only build it by making the call.

One incorrect example to diagnose

Picture a sketchbook. (An illustration, not anyone's real one.) Twenty pages. Every page holds a careful drawing (a vase, a rose, a cat curled on a cushion, all copied from photos), each begun with care, shaded partway, and abandoned when it stopped looking nice. None is dated. There are no thumbnails, no notes, no second tries at the same thing, and no rough pages at all. Near the back, two ragged stubs show where pages were torn out.

Ask: **where's the practice?**

Look for it. No dates, so there's no record of time or progress. No thumbnails, so every decision was made on the "good" drawing, where mistakes are expensive. Every page aims to be nice, which usually means perfectionism is running the book, so drawings get dropped the moment they wobble instead of being pushed through. Everything came from photos, so the eye never had to flatten a real object by itself. And the torn pages are evidence removed.

Now rewrite the plan. Date every page from today. Do a permission page this week. Draw nine thumbnails before the next careful drawing. Make one daily page from life each day. Finish one abandoned drawing, badly and on purpose, and write one line about what you learned. Stop tearing; turn the page instead. In a month, the same book will look messier and hold far more.

If it isn't clicking

The book stays in the bag

You carry it everywhere and open it nowhere.

Next move: shrink the kit to one pen and one book, and move it to exactly where the cue happens. If your days differ (train days and home days, say), pick a second cue for the other kind of day. The sketchbook should be the easiest thing to reach, not the fourth thing down in the bag.

Blank-page dread

You open the book and nothing wants to happen.

Next move: a permission page first, before anything else, so the page is no longer blank. Then write your list of thirty objects tonight: things you can find without walking more than twenty steps from where you sit. The list removes "What should I draw?", which is often the real source of the dread.

No space

There's nowhere to leave things out.

Next move: a folding table, a closet bin, and water-based materials only. The kitchen table can be a studio for forty minutes if the tray and bin come out and go back. Wipe down afterward, and keep the food line even on a shared table.

When to slow down, go on, or ask a human

Slow down if the safety habits aren't holding yet, with the mug drifting onto the art tray or labels going unread. Stay with pencil and pen until they hold.

Go on when the daily page is fairly steady and the corner works. Chapter 3 needs nothing more than pencil and paper.

Ask a human when you'd like someone who knows materials: a teacher at a community class, a member of a local art league, or a librarian who can point you to good technique books. People who make art are usually glad to talk about their tools.

Perfectionism and the precious sketchbook

Some adults find a new sketchbook almost too nice to mark. If that's you, buy a second, deliberately cheap one (thin paper, plain cover) and make it the daily book. Short sessions, an early win (make the first page of any new book a permission page, so it's never pristine again) and a weekly permission page keep the stakes low. The preciousness is a habit, not a flaw in you, and it loosens with every dated page.

Tools, including AI

A few small helpers earn their keep here.

- **Your phone's camera:** photograph finished pages in daylight, flat and square to the lens. It's a backup, and it makes the monthly flip easy to do on the train.
- **A small clip-on light** for evening sessions away from your lamp.
- **Sticky tabs** for the monthly flip.
- **A rubber band or clip** to hold the book open on a windy bench or a moving train.

The full AI rules are in *The Art Refresh Hour*, and they apply here too. One use that fits this chapter: once you've written your own list of thirty objects, you may ask a chatbot to turn it into a month of daily prompts, mixing easy days and harder ones and varying the angle and the light, and then cross off anything that doesn't suit you. One this book rules out: asking a chatbot which of your pages are "good" before you've done your own monthly flip. The flip trains your eye to read your own work. Handing that job over first skips the lesson, and usually gets you polite praise that tells you nothing.

What "done enough" looks like

Before moving on to Chapter 3, check:

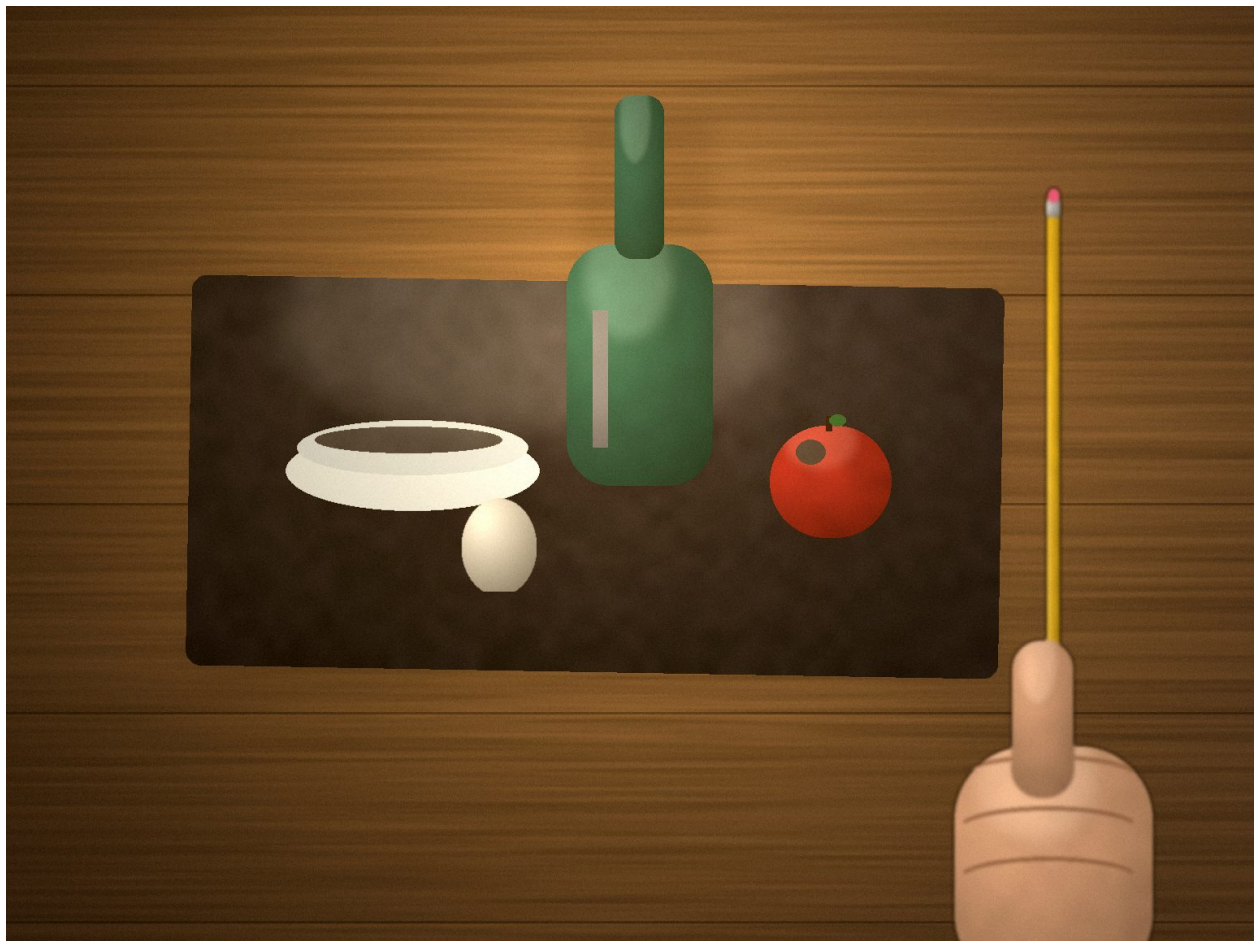
- ☐ Twenty dated pages in a month. Missed days are fine.
- ☐ A page of nine thumbnails behind any larger piece you made.
- ☐ A permission page each week.
- ☐ One full page of one subject.

- ☐ A monthly flip, with three pages tabbed and one sentence on your practice strip.
- ☐ A corner where every product's label has been read, with a food line, a one-line ventilation plan and the Poison Control number posted.
- ☐ You can set up for a daily page in two minutes and clean up in five.

Placement by skill, not age. If the daily page is steady but the corner isn't finished, go on to Chapter 3 anyway; pencil and paper are gentle. Finish the corner before paint arrives in Chapter 4. If the corner is perfect but the pages aren't happening, stay here another week and work on the cue.

Revisit next week. Add five objects to your list of thirty. At the end of the month, do the monthly flip even if the month felt thin; thin months often show the clearest change.

Chapter 3 — Drawing from observation and life



Why this matters

Put your phone face-up on the table in front of you and look at it from where you sit. You know it's a rectangle. You've held it a thousand times. But from your chair, the far edge is shorter than the near edge, and the sides lean in toward each other. What's actually landing in your eye is a squat, tilted shape that no store would sell. If you drew the rectangle you know, the phone would look as

if it were standing up on the table, staring at you.

That gap between the thing you know and the thing you see is what this chapter is about. Drawing from observation means drawing from the real thing in front of you (a mug, a chair, your own hand, a street corner, a person who has agreed to be drawn) rather than from memory or a rule. Drawing from life usually means drawing people that way: a model at an open session, your face in a mirror, a friend who said yes.

Chapter 1 gave you the most encouraging fact in the book. Researchers who studied why adults struggle to draw what they see found that the trouble was mostly in how we perceive the object, not in our hands.¹ This chapter is where that fact goes to work. If the problem is mostly seeing, then the fix is mostly seeing too: measuring, comparing, squinting, looking at the empty shapes between things. These are learnable moves. They're how trained draftsmen work, and they're how skilled drawers get so good at putting down a size as it lands in front of them rather than the size they know it to be.^{21,22} In one study, college students who took a single semester of observational drawing got clearly better at it, while their basic perception tests didn't change.² The skill was in the practice.

Everything else in the book leans on what you build here. A painting with a weak drawing underneath stays weak no matter how lovely the color. A photograph is a decision about the same shapes and lights you'll learn to see on paper. Even looking at art in a museum gets richer once you've tried to measure a head yourself and discovered how small it really is.

This chapter also brings people into the picture, which brings manners with it. You'll learn how to draw strangers at a café without bothering anyone, how to ask a friend to sit, and how an open figure session works, so you can walk in as a good guest. Consent here isn't paperwork. It's part of the craft, the same way sharpening a pencil is.

A word about pace. You don't need all of this at once. The sequence below is the order that follows the evidence and long studio habit, but you'll loop through it for years. The retired engineer who measures beautifully may spend a month loosening up with quick gesture. The former art student who hasn't drawn in twenty years may need three weeks of slow contour before measuring feels natural again. Both are doing this chapter.

What you can try today: a two-minute contour of your own hand, looking at the hand more than the page. What you can try this week: a measured drawing of two mugs, one near and one far, where the far one finally looks far.

Understand it yourself

The everyday picture. Hold your thumb up at arm's length on a clear night and it will cover the full moon. You know the moon is enormous. Your eye says it's the size of a thumbnail. Both are true, and drawing from observation means drawing the thumbnail moon: the size, angle and shape the thing makes from exactly where you sit, not the size you know it to be.

The precise picture. Your brain is very good at telling you what things really are. A plate is round. A door is a rectangle. A person's head is a big deal, so it feels big. Psychologists call this constancy:

the habit of seeing things as the size and shape you know they are, even when they land differently in your eye. It's wonderful for crossing the street and a nuisance for drawing. The moves in this chapter are ways of getting underneath it, in roughly this order: look, measure and compare, block in the big shapes, sort the values, choose the edges, and only then add detail.

Looking. A contour is a line that follows an edge. A slow contour means drawing that edge while you look at the object far more than at the page, letting your pencil crawl along as your eye crawls along. A blind contour is the same thing without looking at the page at all. It produces wonderful nonsense, and that's fine; it's a warm-up, not a product. What it trains is patience in the eye.

Measuring. Hold a pencil at arm's length with your elbow locked, close one eye, and line the tip up with the top of something. Slide your thumb down to mark the bottom. That length is now your unit. Everything else gets compared with it: "The mug is one unit tall and about three-quarters of a unit wide. The far mug is barely half a unit." The locked elbow is the whole trick; if your arm bends, the unit changes and the drawing drifts. You can check angles the same way. Hold the pencil perfectly upright or level and compare an edge against it, or read the angle like a clock hand ("that table edge runs at about two o'clock"). A plumb line is an imagined vertical dropped from one point, a chin or a doorframe, to see what lines up beneath it.

Negative space. Negative space means the shapes around and between things: the gaps between chair rungs, the sliver of wall between an elbow and a waist. Those shapes have no names, so your memory has nothing to hand you. You have to look. When the gaps come out right, the chair comes out right.

Upside-down copy. Copy a line drawing turned upside down, and the familiar subject turns into a set of lines and angles you can simply follow. Chapter 1 explained why this works without any brain story: it slows you down and makes you look at what's actually there. If you copy a master drawing this way, label your page "copy after ____." Chapter 6 says more about copies.

Value. Value means how light or dark something is, ignoring color. Squint at a lit object and the detail blurs away, leaving a few big patches of light and dark. Start with three values (light, middle, dark) as flat shapes, then refine to five. A small strip of five grays, from paper white to your darkest dark, is a handy ruler to hold up against the subject.

Edges. Some edges are hard and crisp, some soft, some lost entirely where a shadow melts into the background. Choosing which is which is one of the quiet ways a drawing starts to look real.

Perspective, the short version. Eye level (also called the horizon line) is an imaginary level line at the height of your eyes. Hold a pencil level at eye height and notice it: edges above eye level slope down toward it, edges below slope up toward it. In one-point perspective, as in looking straight down a hallway, lines running away from you meet at a single point on eye level. In two-point perspective, as in looking at the corner of a table or a building, the two sets of receding lines head for two points. Ellipses are circles seen at an angle: the top of a mug, a wheel, a plate. They have rounded ends, never pointed ones, and the farther below your eye level they sit, the rounder they look. That's why the base of a mug on the table is a fuller ellipse than its rim.

Gesture. Gesture means a fast drawing of a pose's movement and weight. You look for the line of action, the one curve that runs through the whole pose, and put that down before any outline.

Thirty seconds to two minutes is plenty. Gesture is how you learn to draw people who lean, reach and stand on the floor, instead of people who look pinned to a board.

Your eyes and hands, looked after

If close work blurs, you're in large company. Needing to hold things farther away to see them usually begins after 45; brighter light and reading glasses are the usual fixes.¹³ Try bright, even light first, from the side opposite your drawing hand so your hand doesn't shade the page. Then try reading glasses or a desk magnifier. Work bigger. A bigger page is easier on the eyes and on the hands.

Hands can learn new skills at any adult age. It may take a few more repetitions for fiddly work, and that's all right.²⁴ Set up the task so your hand isn't the bottleneck: a fatter pencil or a foam grip, a board tilted up on a couple of books to reduce wrist bend, soft media like charcoal or a brush pen that need less pressure, and drawing from the shoulder and elbow rather than just the fingers. Standing at a counter is a perfectly good studio. Arthritis is common, and none of this asks you to push through it.³⁴ If drawing hurts, stop and ask your clinician or an occupational therapist.

How an open figure session works

An open figure session is a scheduled time at an established studio, art league, college continuing-education program or community arts center where a professional model poses and a group draws. There's a facilitator or monitor who keeps time and speaks for the room. Many sessions run from short poses to long ones: a warm-up of quick gestures, then a few longer poses with breaks for the model. Some sessions have clothed models and some have nude models. Which kind you attend is your choice, and the venue sets its own age and conduct rules. Whatever the session, the book stays where it is: suitable for any reader, with nothing explicit.

A model is a professional doing skilled, tiring work, and the etiquette follows from that. Two published codes from long-running venues agree on the essentials:¹⁴

- Never touch the model.
- No photographs or recordings. (One of the two codes allows a photo only with the model's written permission arranged in advance. Assume no unless your venue says otherwise.)
- Stay off the model stand and out of the model's space.
- No comments about the model's body and no personal questions during the session.
- Pose requests go through the facilitator, not straight to the model.
- Keep the room warm, arrive on time, silence your phone, and thank the model at the end.

Policies vary from venue to venue, so read the code where you're going. Chapter 10 has help finding an established session near you.

Drawing people, with their okay

Quick gestures of people at a distance, in a café, a station or a park, are an old sketchbook tradition. Keep it quick and far away, and stop if anyone objects. A close study of someone's face is different: ask first. For portraits, agree on what you'll do with the drawing, and let the sitter stop anytime.

Children: only your own family, with their okay, and photos of them stay off shared computers and AI tools. Photographing strangers to draw from later deserves the same thought. When in doubt, draw from life and let the moment go.

Wrong turns you'll hear (including from yourself)

1. **"I'll get the eyes right first, then do the rest."** Detail before big shapes. You end up with a beautiful eye in the wrong place. Block in the whole head, find where the eyes sit by measuring, and let the eyelashes wait.
2. **"Measuring is cheating."** It's how trained draftsmen work. Nobody accuses a carpenter of cheating with a tape. Measuring doesn't replace looking; it checks it.
3. **"That head looks too small. I'll make it bigger."** That's constancy talking. Heads matter to us, so they feel big. Measure it against something else in the scene and trust the pencil.
4. **"I can't draw people."** You probably can't draw them yet the way you'd like, and neither could anyone else at first. People are shapes that move. Start with gesture: one line of action, a head oval, done.
5. **"I'll snap a photo of the model and finish at home."** Not at an open session. Venue codes rule it out unless the venue has its own written-permission route. Finish what you can in the room. Whatever's left unfinished is your homework for next week's pose.

A five-minute warm-up

Set a timer for two minutes. Draw your non-drawing hand as a blind contour, eyes on the hand the whole time, pencil moving as slowly as your eye. Then take three minutes for a half-blind contour of the same hand: glance at the page only to find your place, then look back. Compare the two. The blind one looks strange and alive. The second is starting to look like a hand. Neither needed a steady wrist. Both needed patience in the eye.

How to try it this week

This week runs on the Art Refresh Hour you already know (Look · Sketch · Make · Step back · File), scaled to where you are.

Commute/lunch (about 15–20 minutes). Look for a minute or two: pick one thing near you, your shoe, your bag, a hand on the pole, a paper cup. Sketch for ten to thirteen minutes: a slow contour of it, or quick gestures of people at a distance if you're somewhere that allows it. Step back for a minute: hold the page at arm's length and name one part that works and one change to try. File in a minute: date it and write one line ("the strap is thinner than I thought").

Desk-or-shift (about 25–40 minutes). Look for three minutes at a small still life and name one thing you'll watch for ("the far mug is smaller"). Sketch for five: a blind-contour warm-up or three tiny thumbnails of the setup. Make for fifteen to twenty-five: the measured still life below, your first try-it. Step back for three to five minutes with the talk-to-yourself box: turn the drawing upside down, take a grayscale phone photo, look, then put the phone away. File for two minutes: date it and add a line to your practice strip.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes). Look for five to ten minutes: find your eye level, notice where the light comes from, thumbnail the lights and darks. Sketch for ten: a three-value plan. Make for twenty-five to forty-five: perspective in your own room, a street corner, a mirror self-portrait, or, as an outing, an open figure session. Step back for five to eight minutes, across the room. File for three to five: a whose-mark card for anything you'd keep, with a consent line if a person is in it.

Sentences to say to yourself

- “Draw the size I see, not the size I know.”
- “Ticks before lines.” (A light tick mark is easy to move; a dark line argues back.)
- “Big shapes first. The eyelashes can wait.”
- “Squint. Where's the darkest dark?”
- “Which is bigger, that shape or the gap beside it?”

Your first try-it: two mugs, measured

Put two mugs on the table, one about an arm's length from you and one a couple of feet behind it, with a folded dish towel beside them. One lamp from the side. Sit where you won't move for twenty minutes.

Before you draw anything, measure. Arm straight, elbow locked, one eye closed. Take the height of the near mug as your unit. Now compare: how wide is it, in units? How tall is the far mug? (Probably much smaller than you'd guess.) Where does the far mug's base sit relative to the near one's? Put down light ticks for the tops, bottoms and sides of both mugs before any lines. Then draw the big shapes with straight, light lines, the envelope that each mug fits in. Then the ellipses, round-ended, with the base ellipse fuller than the rim. Then squint and block in the shadow shapes. Detail last, only if there's time.

When you finish, turn the drawing upside down next to the setup and look at both. If the far mug still looks too big, measure it once more and correct just that. That single correction is the lesson arriving.

How to fade the help

On day one, measure every point you put down. On day two, measure your unit and two checkpoints, and trust your eye for the rest. By day three, draw first and measure afterward, to check. You're moving the measuring from a crutch to a proofreader.

Tool help fades the same way. If a grid or a one-time tracing of a photo helps you see where the gaps fall, use it once as a labelled study, then go back to drawing from life. A grayscale phone photo is a check at the end, not a reference to draw from. A chatbot, if you use one at all, comes after the drawing and your own step back, never during.

When to stop fiddling

Stop when the big shapes, the three main values and one area of detail are in place. Stop when the timer ends, even mid-line; an unfinished drawing is still a whole practice session. And a house rule worth keeping: if you've erased the same spot three times, stop and draw a fresh small version of just that part beside it. Rubbing the paper thin doesn't count as looking.

Practice that actually builds it

These try-its are a menu, not a calendar. Pick what fits the week. Each one names the time, materials, safety and the move. Most need nothing more than a pencil and something to look at. For charcoal and soft pastel, keep the dust habits from the safety spine in *The Art Refresh Hour*: tap the drawing over a bin instead of blowing, and wet-wipe the table afterward.⁶

On the go

Slow contour. - **Time:** 10 minutes. - **Materials:** pen, pocket sketchbook, a plant, a shoe or a bag. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Draw the edge slowly while you look at the object far more than the page. Do it three times in a row, each one slower. If it's hard to keep your eyes up, do one blind contour first, then a half-blind one. Done when you have three contours of the same thing, and the last one is the slowest.

Café gesture. - **Time:** 15 minutes. - **Materials:** pocket book, pen. - **Safety:** people at a distance only; stop at once if anyone objects; no photos of strangers. - **The move:** Thirty-second to two-minute gestures of people who are waiting (queues and benches are best; they move less). Line of action first, then a head oval. When someone moves, leave that drawing and start another. If it's too much, draw only posture lines and head ovals. Done when you have a page of fifteen gestures and nobody was bothered.

Hands, yours. - **Time:** 15 minutes. - **Materials:** pen or pencil. - **Safety:** ordinary; rest your hand between poses. - **The move:** Your non-drawing hand in three poses: flat, loose fist, holding a cup. Block the palm as a box and the fingers as blocks before any curves. If the fingers turn to sausages, draw the hand as a mitten first, then split the fingers, or draw the gaps between them. Done when you have a page of hands you'd show a friend.

Desk-or-shift

Negative-space chair. - **Time:** 20 minutes. - **Materials:** a chair with rungs or slats, a dark marker, paper. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Draw and fill in only the empty shapes between the chair's parts, not the chair itself. If you can't see the gaps, photograph the chair and trace the gaps once on the screen to understand them, then go back to drawing from life. Done when the filled-in gaps read as a chair.

Upside-down copy. - **Time:** 30 minutes. - **Materials:** a line drawing from an open-access museum collection (Chapter 6 shows where to find them), paper. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Turn the reference upside down and copy it line by line, angle by angle. If it's overwhelming, cover

everything but a small section and work across. Turn both right way up at the end. Label it “copy after ____” with the artist, title and source. Done when you have a copy that surprises you.

Three values, then five. - **Time:** 30 minutes. - **Materials:** pencil, or three gray markers (light, middle, dark); an egg or a white mug; one lamp from the side. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Squint. Map the light, middle and dark as flat shapes with no outlines. Then refine to five values. If you can’t sort them, take a grayscale photo, look, and put the phone away. Done when you have a five-value study of an egg or a mug in side light, with the paper white kept for the lightest light.

Mirror self-portrait. - **Time:** 40 minutes. - **Materials:** a mirror fixed in place, a lamp from the side, pencil, paper on a board. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Measure your head from top to chin and mark halfway; on most adult heads the eyes sit about there, lower than people tend to draw them. Check your own face rather than trusting the rule. Block the light side and the shadow side as two big shapes before any features. If it starts to look like a mask, draw only the shadow shapes for ten minutes. Done when you have a dated self-portrait. Redo it every quarter; you’ll want the set.

Portrait with permission. - **Time:** 45 minutes. - **Materials:** a willing sitter, a chair, a clock the sitter can see, pencil. - **Safety:** ask first; agree on what you’ll do with the drawing; the sitter can stop anytime; children only your own family with their okay. - **The move:** Try saying, “May I draw you for half an hour? You can stop whenever you like, and I’ll show you before I share it anywhere.” Start with a profile silhouette if a full face feels like too much. Give breaks. Done when you have a portrait and a “yes” noted on the whose-mark card.

Weekend deep sit

Perspective in your own room. - **Time:** 45 minutes. - **Materials:** pencil, paper, a ruler if you want one. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Find your eye level with a level pencil held at eye height. Draw a doorway in one-point perspective, the corner of a table in two-point, and one mug’s ellipse. If eye level won’t stay put in your head, stick a strip of tape across a window at eye height and look through it. Done when the room corner sits instead of tipping.

One street corner. - **Time:** 60 minutes. - **Materials:** a small folding stool, sketchbook, pen, an optional small wash. - **Safety:** sit safely out of the flow of people and traffic; public places only; tell someone where you’ll be if you’re on your own. - **The move:** Big shapes first, eye level marked, then one or two figures for scale. If the whole view is too much, draw just the skyline and one doorway. Done when you have one on-location drawing, dated, with the place written on it.

Outing

The open figure session. - **Time:** 2–3 hours. - **Materials:** a newsprint pad, charcoal or a soft pencil, a board and clips. - **Safety:** an established studio, league or class with a professional model and a facilitator; clothed or nude is your choice; follow the venue’s code (no touching, no photos, no comments on the body, pose requests through the facilitator, thank the model); dust habits for charcoal. - **The move:** Arrive early, set up where you can see well without crowding the stand, and give the short poses your full attention. Line of action first every time. On your first visit, stick to

the short poses and let the long pose be a gesture study if you like. Done when you have a pad with gestures and one longer pose, and you know when the next session is.

The talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked): “Where did I look longest — and what did I find there that I would have drawn wrong from memory?”

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Meaning:** “When I say it looks ‘off,’ what exactly do I mean: a size, an angle, or a dark?”
2. **Representation:** “What does the drawing show me upside down, or in the grayscale photo?”
3. **Alternative:** “What else could make that far mug feel far: a smaller size, a softer edge, a lighter value?”
4. **Check:** “If I measure that head again, how will I know I’ve got it?”
5. **Revise:** “I’m allowed to change my mind about what this drawing is for.”

When you’re about to reach for the eraser, the Hour stem still works: “Before I fix, erase, or ask a tool: what do I actually see, what was I after, and what’s the one change I’ll try next?”

How to wait alone. After you ask yourself a question, look back at the subject, not at your phone. Count a slow three. That pause is a teaching habit from classrooms, not a rule anyone tested on drawing, and it helps anyway. If you’re stuck, cover your drawing and look only at the subject for a minute, or turn the drawing to the wall and come back. Answering yourself in one second is still rescuing yourself.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was too vague (“is it good?”). You’re hunting for the “right” answer instead of describing. You’re judging before you’ve looked. You’re tired. Or worry is eating the attention you need for the mug. The move is the same for all of them: shorten the session, get one win (one slow contour, one three-value thumbnail), and come back tomorrow.

Blocked, then mixed

When a move is new, repeat it on its own until it feels ordinary. A good blocked week: the same mug every day from a different spot in the room, measured, ticks before lines. By Friday your arm will lock without being told.

Once a move is familiar, mix it with others so you practise choosing. A good mixed session: ten minutes of one-minute gestures, then a twenty-five-minute still life, deciding as you go where measuring earns its time and where speed matters more. Study-habit research, done mostly with students, finds that spacing practice out and mixing it up tends to make it stick; that’s a reasonable guide for adults, not a promise.²⁵

One incorrect example to diagnose

This is an illustration, not anyone’s real drawing. Picture a still-life page: two mugs, one near and one far, drawn the same height. The tops are pointed footballs. The near mug’s base is a flat straight line, as if it were cut off by the table.

Before you read on, name what happened.

The far mug is the size the drawer knows a mug to be, not the size it made from the chair. That's constancy. The football tops are a symbol for "round thing seen at an angle," not an observed ellipse. And the flat base is the drawer remembering that the bottom of a mug is flat, which it is, but from above it's a curve. The repair takes ten minutes: measure the far mug against the near one and redraw it smaller; round off every ellipse; make the base ellipse fuller than the rim, because it sits farther below eye level. Keep both versions on the same page. The pair teaches more than a perfect drawing would.

If it isn't clicking

Proportions keep drifting. Heads come out too big, the far mug is always too tall, the chair seat is always a square. *Next move:* measure one relationship only, height against width, and check it twice. Then for a week, put down six to ten ticks before any line, and say the comparisons out loud ("the seat is a third of the back"). Speaking slows the eye down.

Drawings feel stiff. Every figure looks like a clothes-peg doll; every mug is careful and lifeless. *Next move:* thirty-second gestures before any longer drawing, a whole page of them, on cheap paper, standing up if you can, drawing from the shoulder. Stiffness usually means outlines came before movement. Let the line of action go down first for a week.

Figure-session nerves. You found a session, then didn't go. Or you went and froze. *Next move:* ask the venue whether you can come once to watch, or take a facilitated drawing class first, where an instructor walks you through the room's customs. Sit near the back. Stay with the short poses. Nobody is looking at your pad; they're all too busy with their own.

When to slow down, go on, or ask a human. Slow down if your measuring still feels like guesswork after two weeks; spend another week on the two mugs. Go on when you measure without being reminded, keep the paper white clean in a value study, and can find eye level in a room. Ask a human when you want more than a book can give: a drop-in drawing class, a local sketch group, an instructor at an open session, or a librarian who can put three good drawing books in your hands. Chapter 10 helps you find all of these.

If worry or perfectionism is louder than the mug. Make the sessions short, ten minutes, so there's less to lose. Start each one with an early win you can't miss, a slow contour of your own hand. And keep a permission page going from Chapter 2, where drawings are allowed to be bad on purpose. The goal this month isn't a good drawing. It's a lot of honest looking.

Tools, including AI

The physical tools are simple. A pencil or a knitting needle for measuring (a needle is straighter than most pencils). A viewfinder, which is just a card with a small rectangle cut in it, for framing a view. A proportional divider if you like gadgets. A kneaded eraser for lifting lights. A drawing board and clips, a mirror, and a lamp you can move. A grayscale photo on your phone is a good last check; take it, look, and put the phone away. If you want to protect a finished charcoal drawing,

brush on a clear acrylic medium, or take any spray fixative outdoors; aerosols never go indoors under this book's rules.⁶

The AI rules in The Art Refresh Hour hold here unchanged. For this chapter, one good use: after you've finished a drawing and done your own step back, photograph just the drawing, cropped to the paper with no faces, and ask, "Without telling me whether it's good, what should I measure again?" Then go back to the subject and check.

One firm no: never upload a photo of a model, a sitter or a family member to an AI tool, and don't keep such photos on a shared bot computer. If you use Grok Bot, the shared-computer caution in the Hour's AI box applies here too.⁷ And a drawing made from a generated "reference pose" isn't a drawing from life. Nobody held that pose.

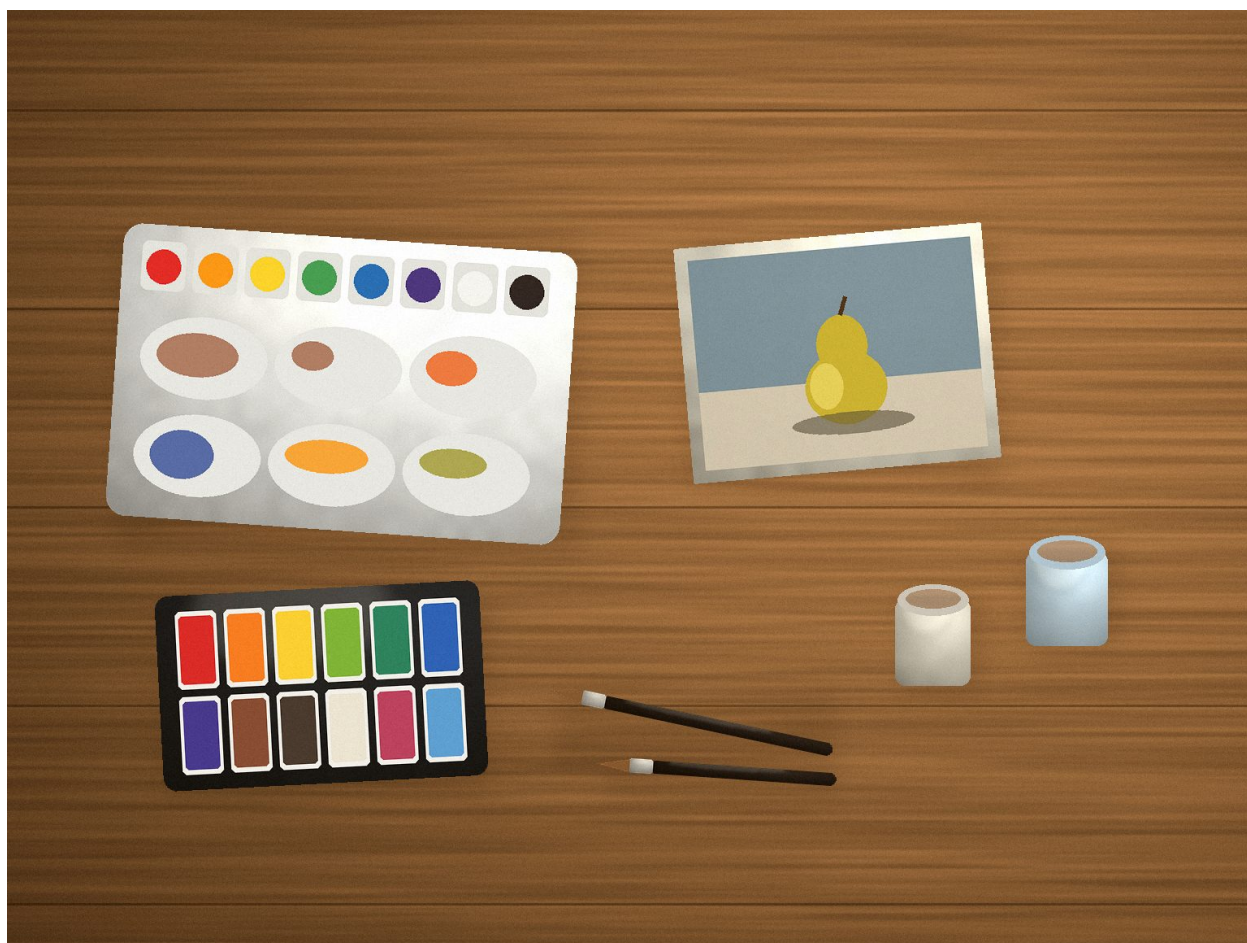
What "done enough" looks like

Before you move on (you'll keep coming back), check these.³⁵ They don't need to be flawless. They need to be honest.

- ☐ A measured still life where the main proportions check out.
- ☐ A negative-space drawing that reads as its object.
- ☐ A five-value study of an egg or mug in side light.
- ☐ A page of fifteen gestures, from a café, the mirror or a session.
- ☐ A dated mirror self-portrait.
- ☐ One on-location drawing with the place written on it.
- ☐ If you went: a figure-session pad with short poses, and you felt like a good guest.
- ☐ A whose-mark card on anything you'd keep, with consent noted for any person in it.
- ☐ You can answer "where did I look longest?" by pointing at the subject, not the drawing.

Place yourself by what you can do, not by age or how long you've been at it. Someone new to observation may live in this chapter for two months; someone returning with skills may move through in three weeks and keep one long observation drawing a month going. Next week, whatever chapter you're on, draw the two mugs once more and compare. That's the quickest honest progress check there is.

Chapter 4 — Painting



Why this matters

Ask adults what they'd like to make if nobody were watching, and a lot of them say the same thing: "I'd like to paint." Not draw. Paint. There's something about a loaded brush and a wet color going down that people carry around for decades as a quiet wish. If that's you, this is your chapter.

Here's the good news and the honest news in one breath. Painting adds two big things to drawing, color and wetness, and the thing that makes most paintings work is neither of them. It's value: how

light or dark each part is. A painting with the values right and slightly odd colors still reads from across the room. A painting with gorgeous colors and muddled values looks flat, no matter how much you love each patch. Most of what adults call “flat” or “muddy” is a value problem wearing a color costume. So this chapter puts value first, every time, and color second.

The second honest thing is that paint is a material, and every material has habits. Watercolor goes light to dark because you can’t paint white back in. Gouache can cover its mistakes. Acrylic dries fast. Oil stays wet for a long time and asks for a careful cleanup. None of this is talent. It’s knowledge, and you can pick it up in weeks by painting small, often, and on purpose.

The third thing is the room you paint in. A kitchen table is not a factory, and it doesn’t need to become one. This chapter climbs a ladder in order of ease and safety: watercolor and gouache first (a small kit, water cleanup), then acrylic (fast, still water cleanup), then oil, but only by the solvent-free method, with fresh air moving through the room and a lidded can for the rags. You can have a full painting life without ever reaching the top rung. Plenty of people do.

Picture someone who paints gouache at the kitchen table on Sunday afternoons, a small pad and six tubes, the pear from the fruit bowl as a model. Twenty minutes, three passes, a date in the corner. After a year there’s a stack of pears that tells a clear story: the early ones are timid and gray, the later ones have a real shadow and one bright edge. Nothing about that year required a studio, a big budget or a gift. It required a value plan and a habit.

What you can try today: a five-step value strip with one color and water. What you can try this week: a gouache pear in three passes, dark shape, shadow, light.

Understand it yourself

The everyday picture. Think of an old black-and-white film. Nobody in the audience missed the color. The sunlit street, the shadowy doorway, the face lit from one side: the lights and darks told the whole story. Now take a color photo of a painting that isn’t working and switch it to grayscale on your phone. Very often the problem jumps out at once. The sky and the field and the trees are all the same gray. The painting was never short of color. It was short of value.

The precise picture. Painters describe any color with a few plain questions.

- **Value:** how light or dark it is. This does most of the work.
- **Hue:** which color family it belongs to: red, yellow-green, blue-violet.
- **Saturation** (also called intensity or chroma): how vivid or muted it is. A tomato is an intense red; a brick is a muted one.
- **Temperature:** which way a color leans, toward the orange side (painters say “warm”) or the blue side (“cool”). It’s a painter’s word for direction, not a claim about mood.

Two practical ideas follow. First, a **limited palette**, meaning a small set of colors, often three primaries (a red, a yellow, a blue) plus white, teaches mixing faster than a big box, because you have to find each color instead of squeezing it out. Colors mixed from the same few tubes tend to sit together naturally, too. Second, light has temperature. Under a warm lamp, the shadows on a white object often look cool, and outdoors on a sunny day the reverse can happen. You don’t have

to believe it; you can paint it and see.

Why paint goes muddy. Mud usually has one of two causes. Either too many different pigments went into one mix, or wet paint got stirred around on the painting until the colors blended into gray-brown. The fix for both is the same habit: mix on the palette, lay the color down, and leave it. One pass per area.

Color and distance. Look out of a window at a long view and you'll notice that far hills tend to look lighter, cooler and softer-edged than the near ones. Painters use that on purpose: a lighter, cooler, softer passage seems to sit back; a darker, warmer, crisper one seems to come forward. It's one more reason value, temperature and edge travel together.

Edges. Some edges are hard, some soft, some lost. A painting with hard edges everywhere looks like a cut-paper collage. A painting with one hard edge where you want the eye to land, and softer edges elsewhere, looks as if it has air in it.

The ladder of media

Watercolor. Transparent paint thinned with water. The white of the paper is your lightest light, so you plan and protect the whites before you start, and work light to dark. Wet-in-wet means painting into paper that's already damp, which gives soft, bleeding edges, lovely for skies. Wet-on-dry means painting onto dry paper, which gives crisp edges. A small pan set, two brushes and a pad will carry you a long way.

The order of work, in short: Plan the whites first and leave them alone. Lay the biggest, palest washes next, often the sky or the background. Let them dry. Then the middle values, then the darks, and last, a few small crisp accents. Each layer waits for the one before it to dry, which is a built-in reason to step back.

Gouache. Opaque watercolor: flat, matte and able to cover what's underneath. It re-wets on the palette, so a dried-out puddle comes back with a drop of water. It can dry a little differently from how it looks wet, so test a swatch on scrap. It's a wonderful bridge between watercolor and the thicker paints, because you can work dark to light and fix things.

Acrylic. A water-based paint that dries fast into a flexible film. It works on paper, primed panels or canvas, and cleans up with water and soap while it's still wet. Wash brushes before the paint dries in them; dried acrylic in a brush is there to stay. As a house habit, let the rinse water settle and wipe out the sludge rather than pouring large amounts down the drain. This book leaves sanding dried acrylic and airbrushing out of the home corner; both make fine dust or mist.

Oil, solvent-free. Oil paint dries slowly, which is its gift: you can blend and push paint around for a long session. Traditional studios clean up with solvents. This book doesn't. The solvent-free method, as the paint maker Gamblin describes it in its own studio guidance, goes like this: wipe the brush on a rag, then work a little safflower oil into the brush and wipe again, then wash with soap and water.¹² Keep non-drying oils such as mineral oil or cooking oil out of the painting itself; they never dry. Painting alla prima, which means wet into wet in one sitting, suits this method well, because a small study can start and finish in one session. That's maker guidance, not a safety certification, so read the labels on whatever you buy too.

Soft pastel. Pure color in a stick, no drying time, no brushes. It makes dust, so it has its own habits: tap the drawing over a bin rather than blowing, wet-wipe the table afterward, and skip pastels made with lead chromate (chrome yellow). Oil pastels make far less dust and are a good alternative.⁶

Setting up to paint

A painting corner is a drawing corner with a few additions. Paper weight matters for water media: heavier watercolor paper buckles less, and taping it down on all four sides to a board keeps it flatter still and gives you a clean edge when you peel the tape. For acrylic and oil, a primed canvas panel or primed heavy paper is plenty; there's no need for a stretched canvas while you're learning. Small is better at first. A panel the size of a postcard lets you finish a whole painting in one sitting and make five in the time one large one would take.

Lay out your palette the same way every time, light colors at one end and darks at the other, with white on its own and a clear mixing space in the middle. Your hand learns where things are, and you stop hunting. Keep two water jars for water media, one for the first rinse and one clean, and change them before they turn the color of weak tea. A roll of paper towels and a rag finish the kit.

Brushes don't need to be many. One big flat brush, one medium round and one small round will do nearly everything in this chapter. The big one matters most, because it keeps you painting shapes instead of details. Wash brushes gently, reshape the tips, and store them bristles up or lying flat.

Life, photos and references

Paint from life whenever you can: the pear, the window, the street. Life gives you the real lights and shadows, and it keeps you honest about what you actually see. Your own photos are the next best thing, and handy for a view you can't sit in front of for an hour. Public-domain museum images are fine for studies, labelled as studies. Someone else's photo is theirs; work from it only with permission. Whatever you use, write the reference and its source on the whose-mark card. Future you will want to know.

Keeping the painting corner safe

The full safety spine lives in *The Art Refresh Hour*, and Chapter 2 set up your corner and your label habit. Painting adds a few habits of its own.

Fresh air in, dirty air out. Ventilation means clean air flowing toward you and used air flowing away and out of the room. The federal safety guide for art and craft materials puts it plainly: blowing air around with a fan, without a source of clean air, isn't adequate ventilation.⁶ A fan that just stirs the room isn't ventilation. A window open on one side and a fan in another window blowing outward is closer to the idea. With watercolor, gouache and acrylic this matters less; with oil, it matters every time.

The oily-rag rule. Rags soaked with linseed or other drying oils can heat up on their own and catch fire.^{6,12} So every oily rag and paper towel goes straight into a closed metal can, or into a jar of water with the lid on, and then out to the outdoor trash. Never a loose rag on the table, in a laundry pile or in the kitchen bin. Not once.

No sprays indoors. Varnish and fixative sprays go outdoors, or into a spray booth with a NIOSH-approved respirator.⁶ If you can't do either, choose a brush-on product or skip the spray.

Labels, food and brushes. The ASTM D-4236 statement on a label means the product's label went through a toxicologist's review; it isn't a "non-toxic" stamp. The ACMI AP Seal is meant for children in sixth grade or younger, good for a shared family table. The CL Seal is for adults and older kids, and you read the whole label before opening.^{10,11} Some pigments contain heavy metals, such as cadmium or cobalt compounds, so read the label and keep ordinary hygiene: no eating or drinking at the painting table, wash your hands after, and never point a brush with your lips.⁶ Keep a water jar that looks nothing like your coffee mug. Smell tells you nothing about safety. And if anything is ever swallowed or splashed where it shouldn't be, Poison Control is 1-800-222-1222, day or night, the same number posted in the Hour's safety spine.¹⁵

Color vision, and a habit for everyone

About 1 in 12 men see color differently from most people, most often with reds and greens.³⁶ If that's you, or you suspect it, painting is still wide open. Label every tube and pan by name. Mix by value first. Trust your value study; it carries the painting. That's also, as it happens, the best advice for everyone else.

Wrong turns you'll hear (including from yourself)

1. **"My painting looks flat."** Almost always value. The lights and darks are too close together. Make a three-value thumbnail and repaint one area to match it.
2. **"It's gone muddy."** Too many colors in one mix, or wet paint stirred on the painting. Go back to three colors plus white and one pass per area.
3. **"I need every color in the shop."** A limited palette teaches you more and costs less. You can add a color when you can name what it does that your three can't.
4. **"A little solvent at the kitchen table is fine."** The solvent-free cleanup gets the brush clean without it. Keep solvent jars out of the home studio.
5. **"The fan's on, so the air's fine."** A fan alone just moves the same air around. Fresh air in, dirty air out.

A five-minute warm-up

Take one dark color, any dark, and a strip of paper. Paint five small squares in a row: the first as dark as the paint will go, the last almost clear water, and three even steps between. Squint at it. If two neighbors look the same, repaint one. That little strip is your value ruler for the week. Tape it by the table.

How to try it this week

The Art Refresh Hour (Look · Sketch · Make · Step back · File) runs the same way here; painting just adds a brush and a rinse jar.

Commute/lunch (about 15–20 minutes). Look for a minute or two at one thing with a clear color: a sky, a piece of fruit, a painted wall. Sketch for ten to thirteen minutes: five-minute color notes in a pocket watercolor kit, three swatches each of the sky and two other things. Step back for a minute: which swatch is closest, and is it off in value or in color? File in a minute: date it and write where you were.

Desk-or-shift (about 25–40 minutes). Look for three minutes and name one thing you’ll watch for (“the shadow side of the pear is cool”). Sketch for five: a thumb-sized value thumbnail in pencil, three values only. Make for fifteen to twenty-five: the gouache pear below, your first try-it, or a swatch grid or mixing chart. Step back for three to five minutes with the talk-to-yourself box and a grayscale photo. File for two minutes: date and practice strip.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes). Look for five to ten minutes and thumbnail the light. Sketch for ten: two value thumbnails, pick one. Make for twenty-five to forty-five: an acrylic block-in, a one-hour landscape, or a solvent-free oil start with the window open and the rag can ready. Step back for five to eight minutes, across the room. File for three to five: whose-mark card, practice strip, and a photo if it’s finished.

Picture someone working rotating shifts as a nurse, who keeps a watercolor kit the size of a phone in a locker. On a break, five minutes: three color notes of whatever is outside the window, the sky over the parking lot, a red car, a brick wall. No painting, just matching colors. After a couple of months the notes have become a small diary of light at odd hours, and the weekend paintings have better skies, because the eye has been practising all week. That’s the micro band doing exactly what it’s for.

Sentences to say to yourself

- “Value first. Color second.”
- “Biggest brush for as long as I can.”
- “Mix it, lay it, leave it.”
- “Where’s my one hard edge?”
- “Is it wrong in value, edge or color?” (Almost always in that order.)

Your first try-it: a gouache pear in three passes

Put a pear on a plain surface with a lamp from one side. Squeeze out a red, a yellow, a blue and white. Make a pencil value thumbnail the size of a stamp: where’s the light side, the shadow side, the cast shadow on the table?

Pass one: mix a middle-value pear color, plenty of it, and paint the whole pear shape flat. Just the silhouette. Let it dry for a few minutes. Pass two: mix a darker, slightly cooler version and paint only the shadow shapes, the shadow side and the cast shadow, as flat patches. Pass three: mix a lighter, warmer version and paint only the lit area, with one small brighter spot where the light hits hardest. Stop.

It will look simple. It should. Hold it next to your value thumbnail. If the three passes read as light, middle and dark from across the room, you’ve painted your first value-planned painting, and the

next hundred will build on it.

How to fade the help

In week one, tape the value thumbnail right beside the painting and check it after every pass. In week two, make the thumbnail, look at it, then turn it face down while you paint. By week three, squint at the subject and hold the plan in your head, checking only at the end. Tool help fades the same way: the grayscale photo moves from a check after each pass to a single check at the end, then to an occasional one when something feels off.

When to stop fiddling

Paint rewards stopping. Stop when every area has had its pass. Stop the moment you notice you're going back into the same wet patch a third time; that's how mud is made. Let it dry and look tomorrow. If something still bothers you, repaint just that passage on a fresh scrap, three ways (the repaint try-it below), instead of scrubbing into the original. A painting stopped a little early usually looks fresher than one finished a little late.

Practice that actually builds it

Here's the menu. Every try-it names time, materials, safety and the move. For water media, the safety line is short: food line, labels read, a jar that isn't your mug. The oil try-it has more, on purpose.

On the go

Five-minute color notes. - **Time:** 5 minutes. - **Materials:** a small watercolor kit, a water brush or a tiny jar, a pocket pad. - **Safety:** food line applies even on a bench; rinse the brush in its own water, not your drink. - **The move:** Three swatches of three things: a sky, a fruit, a wall. Don't paint the thing; just match the color in a thumbnail-sized patch, and write what it is. If three is too many, one swatch is a whole session. Done when you have a week of notes.

Desk-or-shift

Value before color. - **Time:** 20 minutes. - **Materials:** pencil or gray markers. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Before any color piece, a value thumbnail in three values. If you can't see the values in the subject, photograph it in grayscale and work from that for the thumbnail only. Done when every color piece you make has a thumbnail behind it.

The watercolor swatch grid. - **Time:** 30 minutes. - **Materials:** watercolor set, heavier paper, a pencil for labels. - **Safety:** labels read; food line. - **The move:** Paint each color in your set as a strip from full strength to pale, and write its name beside it. If the set is big, do three colors only. Done when you have a labelled chart taped near your table.

Wet-in-wet and wet-on-dry. - **Time:** 30 minutes. - **Materials:** watercolor, two brushes, paper taped to a board. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Paint two small skies side by side, one on paper you've dampened first, one on dry paper. Compare the edges. If the wet one floods, tilt the board and use less water. Done when you have one of each, labelled.

Limited palette mixing chart. - **Time:** 40 minutes. - **Materials:** three primaries plus white, in any water medium or acrylic. - **Safety:** labels read. - **The move:** Mix a grid: each primary with each other, in a few steps, plus tints with white. Label every mix with what went into it, and label your tubes or pans too. If the grid is too much, mix just two colors in five steps. Done when you have a labelled chart you'll actually look at.

Warm and cool light. - **Time:** 30 minutes. - **Materials:** a lamp with a warm bulb, a white cup or egg, gouache or watercolor. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Paint the white object under the warm lamp and look hard at its shadow. It's probably not gray. If you can't see a difference, paint two swatches, lit side and shadow side, next to each other. Done when you have a small study labelled "warm light / cool shadow" (or the reverse, if that's what you saw).

Color from a master. - **Time:** 30 minutes. - **Materials:** an open-access painting image (Chapter 6 shows where to find them), your paints. - **Safety:** labels read. - **The move:** Pick six colors from the painting and mix each one as a swatch. If six is too many, match only the darkest dark and the lightest light. Done when you have a six-swatch chart labelled with the artwork, the artist and the source.

Repaint one passage. - **Time:** 30 minutes. - **Materials:** a finished painting and scrap paper or a small panel. - **Safety:** as for the medium. - **The move:** Pick the weakest passage and repaint it separately, three ways. If you can't decide what to change, change value only. Done when one passage is better and you've written one line about why.

Weekend deep sit

Acrylic block-in. - **Time:** 60 minutes. - **Materials:** acrylics, a canvas panel, your biggest brush, a rag, a rinse jar. - **Safety:** labels read; brushes washed before they dry; rinse sludge settled and wiped, not poured. - **The move:** Tone the panel with a thin middle color. Then block in the darks, the middles and the lights with the biggest brush you own, and stop before any detail. Set a twenty-minute timer for the block-in if you tend to fuss. Done when the block-in reads from across the room.

The one-hour landscape. - **Time:** 60 minutes. - **Materials:** a portable kit, a small board, water, a stool. - **Safety:** a safe, public spot; sun and weather sense. - **The move:** A thumbnail, then three values, then paint the sky, then the land, then a few accents. If going out isn't possible, paint the view from a window. Done when you have a dated study made from the real place.

Solvent-free oil start. - **Time:** 75 minutes, including setup and cleanup. - **Materials:** a few oil colors, a small panel, safflower oil, rags or paper towels, a closed metal can or a lidded jar of water, soap. - **Safety:** fresh air in and dirty air out before you open a tube (a fan alone isn't enough); no solvents in the room; no sprays; rags straight into the can or jar, then outdoor trash; food line; kids and pets out of reach. - **The move:** Paint a simple still life, a cup and a lemon, alla prima, from a value thumbnail. Clean each brush by wiping it on a rag, working in a little safflower oil and

wiping again, then washing with soap and water. Every rag goes into the can as you use it, not at the end. If the corner, the air or the can isn't ready, paint this one in acrylic and try oil next month. Done when you have one small oil painting and a clean, safe cleanup with no loose rags anywhere.

The oily-rag rule, as a practice. - **Time:** 5 minutes. - **Materials:** a lidded metal can, or a jar you can fill with water and seal. - **Safety:** this is the safety. - **The move:** Set the can beside the palette before you squeeze out any paint. Use it for every oily rag and paper towel, and empty it into the outdoor trash when you're done. If you don't have a can yet, use paper towels and dispose of them the same day the same way: soaked, sealed, outside. Done when "no loose oily rags, ever" is simply how your corner works.

The talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked): "If I repainted one passage tomorrow, which would it be — and what exactly would I change: value, edge, or color?"

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Meaning:** "When I say it's 'muddy,' do I mean dull color, blurred edges, or values all the same?"
2. **Representation:** "What does the grayscale photo show? Do sky, field and trees separate?"
3. **Alternative:** "What else could make that corner recede: a cooler color, a softer edge, a lighter value?"
4. **Check:** "If I repaint it, how will I know the change worked from across the room?"
5. **Revise:** "I'm allowed to change my mind about what this painting was after."

When your brush is already heading back in, the Hour stem helps: "Before I fix, erase, or ask a tool: what do I actually see, what was I after, and what's the one change I'll try next?"

How to wait alone. Put the brush down in the jar. Look at the subject or across the room at the painting, not at your phone. Count a slow three, a classroom habit rather than a rule, and useful anyway. Turn the painting to the wall for a few minutes, or cover your reference and look only at the painting. An answer in one second is usually just the urge to keep painting.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague ("why doesn't it work?"). You're looking for the right answer instead of naming what you see. You've jumped to a verdict. You're tired; painting is surprisingly tiring. Or worry is taking the attention the painting needs. Shorten the session, get one small win (one clean swatch, one value strip), and come back tomorrow.

Blocked, then mixed

When a move is new, do it on its own, several days in a row: a week of gouache pears, three passes each, same lamp. Or a week of mixing charts. Repetition turns the move into something your hands know.

Once it's familiar, mix it. A mixed session might be ten minutes of color notes, then a small painting where you choose the value plan, the palette and the one hard edge yourself. Mixing is where you practise deciding, which is most of painting.

A painting week, one way to do it

Here's one possible week, as an illustration, not a schedule. Monday on the train: color notes of the morning sky. Tuesday at the table after dinner: a value thumbnail and a swatch grid. Wednesday: nothing, and that's fine. Thursday: a gouache pear in three passes. Friday at lunch: color notes again. Saturday: an acrylic block-in of the same pear, bigger, with the Thursday painting propped beside it. Sunday: five minutes with both paintings and the talk-to-yourself box, a line in the practice strip, a whose-mark card for the one you'd keep. Two paintings, a pile of notes, and a clear idea of what to try next week. If the week goes sideways, the color notes alone still count.

One incorrect example to diagnose

This is an illustration, not anyone's real painting. Picture a small landscape: a blue sky, a line of green trees, a yellow-green field. Every part of it is a middle value. Every edge, where sky meets trees, trees meet field, is equally crisp. The colors are pleasant. The painting looks like a flag.

Before you read on, name what happened.

There was no value plan. Sky, trees and field sit at nearly the same gray, so nothing comes forward and nothing falls back. And there's no edge hierarchy: every boundary is equally hard, so the eye has nowhere to land. The repair starts with a three-value thumbnail: say, the sky as the light, the field as the middle, the trees as the dark. Then pick one hard edge, perhaps where the darkest tree meets the lightest sky, and soften the rest. Repaint it small, beside the first, and put both in grayscale. The difference is usually startling, and it didn't need a single new color.

If it isn't clicking

Everything turns muddy. *Next move:* three colors plus white, nothing else, for two weeks. Mix on the palette, not on the painting. One pass per area, then leave it. If a patch is wrong, let it dry and paint over it once, or repaint that passage on scrap.

Everything looks overworked. The painting was lively at minute ten and tired by minute forty. *Next move:* a timer for the block-in, twenty minutes, then a rule of one pass per area. Stop when the timer ends, even if you'd like to keep going. Make three small paintings in the time you'd have spent on one.

Oils make you nervous. Good. That means you're taking the setup seriously. *Next move:* stay with acrylic until your corner, your air and your rag can are all ready. Walk through the oil cleanup once with no paint at all, just the rag, the safflower oil and the soap, so it's familiar before it matters. There's no deadline for oils, and no rule that you ever need them.

When to slow down, go on, or ask a human. Slow down if your values still bunch in the middle after a few weeks; spend another week on value thumbnails and three-pass gouache. Go on when a grayscale photo of your painting reads clearly and your cleanup is automatic. Ask a human when you want to watch someone's hands: a drop-in painting class, a watercolor group at the library, an art-league demonstration. Seeing a teacher load a brush can save you a month. Chapter 10 has help finding them.

If perfectionism is holding the brush. Paint small, on cheap paper, where nothing is precious. Start each session with an early win, a value strip or one color note. And let a permission page from Chapter 2 take the paint too: one ugly page a week, painted with your least favorite brush, on purpose.

Tools, including AI

Useful helpers, none required: a gray scale card or your own value strip to hold up against the subject; a grayscale setting on your phone for a quick check, then put the phone away; a simple color wheel; a palette with a lid so paint keeps between sessions; masking tape and a board; a tabletop easel if bending over the table hurts. Keep your tubes and pans labelled, especially if you see color differently.

The AI rules in The Art Refresh Hour hold here unchanged. One good use for this chapter: after you’ve painted and done your own step back, photograph the painting, cropped to the painting, and ask for three questions about value and edges, not a verdict. Compare them with your own notes.

One firm no: running an “enhance” or color-fix filter over a photo of your painting and filing that image as the painting. The painting is the thing on the table. If you photograph it, photograph it plainly in daylight, and if any tool changed the photo, say so on the whose-mark card.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on, check:³⁷

- ☐ A labelled swatch grid and a limited palette mixing chart, taped where you paint.
- ☐ A value thumbnail behind every color piece this month.
- ☐ A week of five-minute color notes.
- ☐ A gouache pear (or similar) in three passes that reads as light, middle and dark.
- ☐ One painting in at least two media, say gouache and acrylic.
- ☐ One repainted passage with a line about what changed.
- ☐ If you painted in oil: a solvent-free cleanup, fresh air moving, and no loose rags, ever.
- ☐ A whose-mark card on anything you’d keep, noting any reference and its source.
- ☐ You can answer “value, edge, or color?” about your own painting without guessing.

Place yourself by what you can do. Someone new to paint may spend two months on water media and be exactly on track; someone returning to oils may move through the ladder in three weeks and keep a weekly value thumbnail going. Next week, paint one more pear with the same lamp and put it beside the first. That pair is your progress report.

Chapter 5 — Photography, digital and design



Why this matters

There's a good chance the most capable art tool you own is in your pocket right now. It takes photographs, it can hold a drawing app, it can lay out a birthday card. Many adults use it every day and never think of it as an art tool at all. This chapter asks you to, and to use it on purpose.

Photography, digital drawing and design are real media, with their own skills and their own history. A strong photograph is a set of decisions: where you stood, what you left out, what the light was doing, which half-second you chose. A digital painting still needs a value plan and a drawing underneath. A good poster for the library book sale uses the same thumbnail habit you learned in Chapter 2. None of this is a lesser kind of art. It's art you can make on a lunch break.

These media also carry a question the whole book cares about, and they carry it more sharply than any other chapter: which choices were yours? The phone will happily choose for you. It brightens the shadows, sharpens the edges, warms the skin, and, with some tools, invents a sky that was never there. Some of that help is useful. The skill is noticing it, keeping what serves the picture, and being honest about the rest. A photograph you framed and edited by hand is yours. A picture a tool generated from a typed request isn't your mark, however good it looks.

This chapter also takes you into printmaking at the kitchen table, a soft block, a small carving tool, water-based ink and a spoon, and it draws a clear line around the processes that belong elsewhere. Darkroom chemistry, kilns, presses and etching acids go to community studios, with proper ventilation and staff who know the equipment. That's not a limit on your practice. It's an invitation to a room full of people who love the same thing.

Picture someone who has taken thousands of phone photos of their garden and never kept one on purpose. For a month they photograph the same corner of it every morning, same spot, same time, no filters. By the end they have thirty frames that show the light moving across the season, and for the first time, a set of photographs they'd hang. The phone didn't change. The choosing did.

What you can try today: twenty photographs of one ordinary object, then star your two best. What you can try this week: one photo edited by hand, with a note of what you chose and what the tool changed.

Understand it yourself

The everyday picture. Think of autocorrect. It's genuinely helpful: it catches typos and finishes words. And every so often it puts a word in your mouth you never meant. Your camera's automatic settings, filters and AI tools work the same way. They're helpful, and sometimes they make choices you'd never have made. The move isn't to switch them all off. It's to know when they're typing for you.

The precise picture. In each of these media, some choices belong to you and some can be handed to a tool. Here's where they live.

Photography

Frame. What's in, what's out, and where the edges fall. Stepping closer usually does more than zooming. A small shift left or right can take a pole out of someone's head or line up a doorway with the edge of the picture.

Light. Where it comes from, how hard or soft it is, and what the shadows are doing. Side light shows texture; light from behind can outline a shape; the hour before sunset makes almost anything

look considered. You'll learn more about light from a week of noticing it than from any setting.

Point of view. The height and angle you shoot from. Most of us take photos from standing eye height, which is one reason so many phone photos look alike. Kneel. Stand on a step. Shoot from the height of a cat.

Moment. The instant you choose. A person turning, a cloud arriving, a shadow reaching the edge of a step.

Editing. Editing is a set of decisions, not a rescue. Cropping chooses the frame again. Exposure makes the whole picture lighter or darker. Contrast pushes the lights and darks apart. These are your choices when you make them by hand. Auto-enhance, filters and AI fill are the tool's choices, even when you pressed the button.

The contact sheet. In film days, a contact sheet was one page showing every frame from a roll, small, so you could compare them and choose. On a phone, the grid view of an album does the same job. Taking twenty frames and choosing two is the habit that turns snapshots into photographs.

The phone as a sketchbook. Your camera is also the best reference-gatherer you'll ever own. When you see a view you'd like to paint, take a few frames of it: one wide, one close, one exposed for the shadows so you can see into them. Your own photos are your own references, free and clear, and they make the paintings in Chapter 4 easier to plan. Note on the whose-mark card when a drawing or painting was made from your own photo rather than from life. It's a small line that keeps your records honest.

Photographing people. Ask first. That's the whole rule, and it's the same one you'd use for drawing someone. A person in the far distance of a street scene is part of the street; a person who is the subject of the picture gets asked. Tell them what the photo is for, and if they'd rather not, thank them and turn the camera back to the light. Children: only your own family, with their okay, and those photos stay on your own device, off shared computers and out of AI tools. Posting photographs of people is a bigger step again, and Chapter 8 walks through it.

Digital drawing and painting

A drawing app is a medium like any other. You'll meet a few new ideas:

- **Layers** are like sheets of clear film stacked over your drawing. You can sketch on one, paint values on another and add color on a third, and change any one without disturbing the rest. Saving your layers is also a lovely record of your process.
- **Brushes** are settings that imitate pencils, inks and paint. One or two good ones are plenty. Having three hundred is the digital version of buying every tube in the shop.
- **Undo** is wonderful and dangerous. Used sparingly, it saves a slip. Used constantly, it stops you committing to any mark at all.

You don't need expensive hardware. A tablet and stylus help; a phone and a finger will do to start. For free software, Krita is one example: a free and open-source painting program.³⁸ It's named here because it's free, not because it's the only good option; pick whatever fits your device and your budget.

Design

Design is art with a job to do: a card, a flyer, a recipe page, a zine. The core ideas are few.

- **Grid:** an invisible framework, often three columns by three rows, that gives things a place to line up.
- **Hierarchy:** what the eye reads first, second and third. Usually one big thing, one middle thing, and small text.
- **Two fonts:** one for headings, one for text, is plenty. Many good designs use one font in two weights.
- **Color with a job:** one color that marks what matters, rather than every color because they were available.

And yes, thumbnails first. Three rough layouts in pencil before you open any software.

You already do more design than you think. Every time you arrange a birthday card, label a jar, write a sign for a yard sale or choose where the photos go on a fridge, you're making hierarchy and layout decisions. This chapter just asks you to make them on purpose, and to look at the result from across the room before you call it done.

Printmaking at the kitchen table

Relief printing means carving away the parts of a block you don't want to print, inking the raised surface that's left, and pressing paper onto it. At home, use a soft-cut block, which carves like firm cheese, and water-based ink. A bench hook, a small board with a lip that holds the block steady against the table edge, keeps the block from sliding. Always carve away from your body and away from the hand holding the block.⁶ Roll the ink out thin with a brayer (a small rubber roller), lay the paper on, and rub the back with a wooden spoon. The image comes out reversed, so draw it backwards on the block, especially any lettering. A set of matching prints is called an edition; number them in pencil, 1/5, 2/5 and so on.

What belongs at a community studio

Some processes are wonderful and belong in a room built for them. The safety spine in The Art Refresh Hour lists them; here's why, in brief.⁶

- **Darkroom work.** Film developing and printing use chemicals that need strong ventilation, lots of fresh air in and contaminated air out, at a rate of at least ten room air changes an hour. A bathroom with the door shut isn't that.
- **Kilns.** Indoor kilns for clay or glass need mechanical ventilation to the outdoors, and proper installation. Air-dry clay at home is fine; firing goes to a studio.
- **Etching and presses.** Etching uses acids, and some printmaking inks and cleanups use solvents. Presses are heavy machines with their own training.
- **Sprays and airbrushing.** Aerosols go outdoors or into a spray booth with a NIOSH-approved respirator. Airbrushing belongs with sprays: at a venue with a booth, not at home.

Community darkrooms, clay studios and print shops usually offer an intro class and a safety orientation. Chapter 10 helps you find one. Write two short lists for your own practice: what you'll do at home, and what you'll do at a venue. It takes five minutes and settles a lot of questions in advance.

For the home work, the label habits from Chapter 2 carry over. Look for water-based inks, and for the ACMI seals: AP products are meant for children in sixth grade or younger, good at a shared family table; CL products are for adults and older kids, with the label read in full first. An ASTM D-4236 statement means the label went through a toxicologist's review, not that the product is "non-toxic."^{10,11} Keep carving tools capped and out of children's reach. And the Poison Control number from the Hour's safety spine, 1-800-222-1222, belongs on the shelf beside your inks as much as your paints.¹⁵

Screens and bodies

Screen work is still handwork, with its own strains. The federal art-safety guide's advice for computer work is plain and sensible: position the screen so you're not bending your neck, keep your wrists straight and relaxed, vary your movements, take short breaks often, and look away now and then at something far off, blinking, so your eyes don't dry out.⁶ Good task light helps. If close screen work blurs, reading glasses or a larger display help, and working bigger helps here too. If your hand, wrist or neck starts to hurt, stop, and if it keeps happening, ask a clinician.

Who chose this: you or the tool

Here's the question to carry through every photograph and file: what did I choose, and what did the tool choose for me?

You chose the frame, the light, the moment and the edits you made by hand. The tool may have chosen the brightness, the sharpening, the color, the smoothing of skin, and, with generative features, whole parts of the picture: a filled-in sky, an extended background, a removed stranger who's been replaced by invented pavement.

Using tools isn't cheating. Noticing them is the skill. Write what they did on the whose-mark card, in plain words: "auto-enhance on," "sky replaced by AI fill," "background extended by the app." That line is honest, and it's also useful. It tells future you which parts of the picture you actually made.

And the bigger version of the question has a clear answer. The US Copyright Office said in 2025 that typing prompts doesn't make you the author of a generated image; what counts is what a person actually determined, such as their own work visible in the result, or their creative arrangement or changes to it.⁵ A federal appeals court agreed the same year that copyright needs a human author.¹⁷ This isn't legal advice, and the book's own rule is simpler than the law anyway: sign only what you made. A generated image isn't your mark.

Wrong turns you'll hear (including from yourself)

1. **"The phone takes the picture."** The phone records it. You chose where to stand, what to leave out, what the light was doing and when to press. Those are the picture.
2. **"Filters make it art."** A filter is a set of choices someone else made in advance. Use one if it helps, and write down that you did. Then try the same photo edited by hand and compare.
3. **"Digital isn't real art."** It's a medium with its own skills: layers, brushes, restraint with undo. The value plan and the drawing still decide whether it works.
4. **"I'll set up a darkroom in the bathroom."** Darkroom chemistry needs ventilation a bathroom can't give. A community darkroom has the air, the equipment and people who'll show you how.
5. **"If I prompt it carefully enough, it's my picture."** Careful prompts are instructions, and the Copyright Office says instructions alone don't make you the author. What you draw, shoot, arrange or meaningfully change is yours.

A five-minute warm-up

Pick one object on your desk: a mug, a stapler, a pair of glasses. Take three photographs of it from three heights, one from above, one level with it, one from below. No editing. Look at all three together. Which height made it look like something? That's a decision you made, and you'll make it on every photograph from now on.

How to try it this week

The Art Refresh Hour (Look · Sketch · Make · Step back · File) runs here too, with a camera, a screen or a block standing in for the pencil some days.

Commute/lunch (about 15–20 minutes). Look for a minute or two: what's the light doing right now, and where's it coming from? Sketch for ten to thirteen minutes: twenty frames of one thing, a light walk, or a digital daily page. Step back for a minute: scroll the grid and star two. File in a minute: put the two stars in an album with the date.

Desk-or-shift (about 25–40 minutes). Look for three minutes and name one thing you'll watch for ("the shadow on the left is too dark to read"). Sketch for five: three quick layout thumbnails, or a pencil value sketch for a digital piece. Make for fifteen to twenty-five: edit a photo with a note, lay out a card, or scan and clean a sketchbook page. Step back for three to five minutes with the talk-to-yourself box, comparing before and after. File for two minutes: date, practice strip, and a line about any tool that changed the picture.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes). Look for five to ten minutes: plan the theme or the image. Sketch for ten: thumbnails, reversed if it's a print. Make for twenty-five to forty-five: an eight-page zine, a block print, or a layered digital piece. Step back for five to eight minutes. File for three to five: a whose-mark card with the tools line filled in, and a photo of the finished piece. As an outing, book an intro session at a community darkroom or print shop.

Sentences to say to yourself

- “What am I pointing at, and what’s the light doing?”
- “Step closer.”
- “Crop before I filter.”
- “What did the tool change?”
- “Can I say what this edit is for?”

Your first try-it: twenty frames of one thing

Choose something ordinary and unmoving: a mug, a bicycle, a pair of boots by the door, a tree on your street. Photograph it twenty different ways in fifteen minutes. Near and far. Low and high. With the light behind it, beside it, in front of it. Tight on one part; wide with its surroundings. Tilted, then straight. Keep going past the point where you think you’ve run out of ideas; the best frames often come after number twelve.

Then open the grid view and look at all twenty at once. Star two. For each, write one line: why this one? (“The shadow of the handle makes a second mug.”) You’ve just made your first contact sheet and done your first edit, and you haven’t touched a slider.

Tomorrow, take one of the starred frames and edit it by hand: crop, then exposure, then contrast, in that order. Write down what you changed. If you try auto-enhance too, note that, and compare the two versions side by side.

How to fade the help

On day one, edit with crop only. On day two, crop and exposure. On day three, crop, exposure and contrast. Auto tools come in only as a comparison, and when you keep what they did, you write it down. Over a few weeks, you’ll notice you reach for them less, because you know what you want before you open the editor. Help from a chatbot fades the same way: if you used one to explain what contrast does, the next time you try explaining it to yourself first.

When to stop fiddling

Editing has no natural end, which is exactly why you need one. Stop when you catch yourself sliding the same slider back and forth. Stop when you can’t say what the next change is for. And every so often, flip back to the original. If the unedited photo looks better, that’s a good lesson and a good day.

Practice that actually builds it

Here’s the menu. Each try-it names time, materials, safety and the move. Screen try-its carry the eyes-and-hands habits above. Venue try-its carry the venue’s own rules, which come first.

On the go

Twenty frames of one thing. - **Time:** 15 minutes. - **Materials:** a phone. - **Safety:** photograph things and places, not strangers; stay out of traffic. - **The move:** One object, twenty ways: near, far, low, high, backlit. Star two. If you run dry, change only your height, frame by frame. Done when you have a contact sheet with two stars.

Light walk. - **Time:** 20 minutes. - **Materials:** a phone. - **Safety:** public places; people only at a distance and incidental, never the subject without their okay. - **The move:** On your usual route, photograph only light and shadow: a stripe across a wall, a window reflection, a shadow on steps. If the light is flat, go out an hour before sunset. Done when you have five frames that are about light.

Digital daily page. - **Time:** 10 minutes. - **Materials:** a phone or tablet, a stylus if you have one. - **Safety:** a short session; look up and away when you finish. - **The move:** The daily page, on a screen: one thing in front of you, one layer, no undo, a date. If it feels slippery, use a single brush. Done when you have a week of dated files.

Desk-or-shift

Edit with a note. - **Time:** 20 minutes. - **Materials:** a phone photo editor. - **Safety:** keep photos of family members, and especially children, out of AI editing features. - **The move:** Edit one image by hand: crop, exposure, contrast. Then write two lines, what you chose, and what any auto or AI tool changed. If it's too much, crop only. Done when you have a before and after with a whose-mark line.

Eyes, hands, screens: the setup. - **Time:** 5 minutes to set up, then a 40-minute test session. - **Materials:** a lamp, a timer, a chair and table you already have, books to raise a screen, a fat grip for a stylus if you like one. - **Safety:** pain means stop; if it keeps coming back, ask a clinician. - **The move:** Raise the screen so you look at it without bending your neck. Put the light where it falls on your work, not in your eyes or bouncing off the screen. Feet on the floor, wrists straight. Set a timer to remind you to look up and away. If something still aches, work bigger or switch to paper for the second half. Done when you can work for forty minutes without strain.

Screen-time sandwich. - **Time:** 40 minutes. - **Materials:** a timer, your digital project, paper. - **Safety:** this is the safety. - **The move:** Twenty minutes on the screen, five minutes on paper or with your eyes off the screen and on something far away, then fifteen more on screen. Stand for the break if you can. Done when you've finished a session without sore eyes or a stiff neck.

Scan and clean. - **Time:** 20 minutes. - **Materials:** a phone scanning app or a scanner, a sketchbook page. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Scan a page, adjust the levels so the paper reads white and the lines read dark, and keep the original page. If the scan is poor, photograph the page flat in daylight instead. Done when you have one clean digital copy of a drawing.

Layers as process. - **Time:** 40 minutes. - **Materials:** a drawing app (a free one is fine). - **Safety:** screen habits. - **The move:** Sketch, value and color, each on its own layer. Save a copy at each stage. If layers multiply out of control, keep to three. Done when you have four saved stages that show how the piece was built.

Card layout. - **Time:** 30 minutes. - **Materials:** paper and pencil. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Three layouts for a card with an image, a headline and a little text. Pick one and make it. If the elements won't settle, draw a three-by-three grid and snap everything to it. Done when you have a finished card.

Two-font rule. - **Time:** 20 minutes. - **Materials:** any layout tool, or paper. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** A poster with one heading font, one text font and three sizes. If two fonts fight, use one font in two weights. Done when you can read the poster from across the room and know what to read first.

Weekend deep sit

Digital master study. - **Time:** 60 minutes. - **Materials:** an open-access image (Chapter 6), a drawing app. - **Safety:** screen habits. - **The move:** Paint a study beside the original on screen, and label it as a study with the artist, title and source. If the whole thing is too much, do the value structure only. Done when you have a labelled study, filed as a copy.

The zine. - **Time:** 75 minutes. - **Materials:** one sheet of paper, scissors, a pen. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Fold one sheet into an eight-page zine (a small folded booklet) and fill it with drawings on one theme. If you can't choose a theme, use "my street." Done when you have a zine you'd hand to a friend.

Block print at the table. - **Time:** 75 minutes. - **Materials:** a soft-cut block, a carving tool, a bench hook, water-based ink, a brayer, paper, a wooden spoon. - **Safety:** carve away from your body and your holding hand; the block against the bench hook; tools capped when not in use and out of children's reach; labels read; food line. - **The move:** Draw the design, reverse it onto the block, carve away what shouldn't print, ink thinly, print by rubbing with the spoon. If the design is too fussy to carve, carve a simple silhouette. Done when you have an edition of five, numbered.

One-subject month. - **Time:** 5 minutes a day. - **Materials:** a phone. - **Safety:** the same public or private spot, safely reachable every day. - **The move:** The same tree, window or street, photographed daily from the same place. If the results feel random, shoot at the same time each day. Done when you have a thirty-frame sequence.

Outings

Community darkroom day. - **Time:** about 3 hours. - **Materials:** film, the venue's fees. - **Safety:** the venue's ventilation, staff and rules. - **The move:** Develop and print at a community darkroom with staff on hand. If you've never done it, take the venue's intro class first. Done when you have one print you made.

Venue-only processes, as a plan. - **Time:** 15 minutes to write the lists. - **Materials:** a page in your sketchbook. - **Safety:** this is the safety. - **The move:** Two columns: "home" (photography, digital, design, soft-block printing with water-based ink, air-dry clay) and "venue" (darkroom, kiln, press, etching, sprays). If you're not sure where something goes, it goes in the venue column until you know. Done when both lists are written and you know where your nearest community studio is.

The talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked): “What did I choose here — the frame, the light, the crop, the edit — and what did the tool choose for me?”

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Meaning:** “When I say it looks ‘better,’ what changed: brighter, sharper, warmer, or just more?”
2. **Representation:** “What does the original show that the edit hides, or the other way round?”
3. **Alternative:** “What else could have made that corner feel empty: a tighter crop, a lower angle, waiting for the light?”
4. **Check:** “If I turned every automatic feature off, what would be left, and would I still keep it?”
5. **Revise:** “I’m allowed to change my mind about which frame is the one.”

The Hour stem fits here too: “Before I fix, erase, or ask a tool: what do I actually see, what was I after, and what’s the one change I’ll try next?”

How to wait alone. After you ask, look at the photograph or the screen, not at another app. Count a slow three, a habit borrowed from classrooms, not a rule. Then look away from the screen at something far off for a minute, or cover the edited version and look only at the original. Deciding in one second usually means the tool decided.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague (“is it good?”). You’re hunting for the right answer. You’re judging before you’ve described what’s in the frame. You’re tired, and screens make that worse. Or worry is crowding out your attention. Shorten the session, get one win (one starred frame, one clean crop), and come back tomorrow.

Blocked, then mixed

When a move is new, repeat it alone: a week of twenty-frame sessions, a different object each day. Or a week of crop-only edits. Blocked practice builds the habit until you do it without thinking.

Then mix. A mixed session might be a light walk, choosing two frames, editing one by hand, and laying it out on a card with a line of text. Now you’re deciding which skill each moment needs.

A week in this chapter, one way to do it

An illustration, not a timetable. Monday at lunch: twenty frames of the mug on your desk. Tuesday on the walk to the bus: a light walk. Wednesday evening: edit Monday’s best frame by hand, with a note. Thursday: skip it; life happened. Friday: a ten-minute digital daily page on the train. Saturday: an eight-page zine about your street, using two of the week’s photos as reference for the drawings. Sunday: five minutes with the zine and the talk-to-yourself box, whose-mark card filled in, tools line and all. Picture a retired schoolteacher doing exactly this week and handing the zine to a grandchild, who asks for a copy of their own. That’s a good week.

One incorrect example to diagnose

This is an illustration, not anyone's real work. Picture a phone photograph of a harbor at dusk. Auto-enhance has pushed the colors hard; the water glows an impossible turquoise. The original sky was flat and gray, so an AI feature has filled in a dramatic sunset. The picture is filed with a whose-mark card that says "all mine."

Before you read on, name what happened.

The frame and the moment were the maker's, and that's real. But the card is wrong. The color was the tool's choice, and the sky isn't the maker's mark at all; it was generated. The repair is honest and quick: rewrite the card ("frame and timing mine; auto-enhance on; sky generated by AI fill"). Better still, go back to the original, edit it by hand, crop, exposure, contrast, and file that version, gray sky and all. Many photographers would tell you a quiet gray harbor is the more interesting picture anyway.

If it isn't clicking

Your photos feel like snapshots. Pleasant, forgettable, like everyone else's. *Next move:* one subject for a month. Same spot, same time, every day. Constraint does what freedom can't: it makes you look harder at one thing until you start seeing it.

Digital feels slippery. Every line wobbles, undo is always under your thumb, and nothing feels like yours. *Next move:* one brush, no undo, ten minutes, every day for a week. You'll hate day one and be surprised by day five. Commitment to the mark is the skill; the screen just makes it optional.

Your designs feel cluttered. Everything is shouting. *Next move:* a three-by-three grid and one font, in two weights. Put one thing big, one thing middle-sized and the rest small. Take something out. Then take one more thing out.

When to slow down, go on, or ask a human. Slow down if you're editing more than you're shooting; spend a week on twenty-frame sessions with no editing at all. Go on when you can star two frames and say why, edit by hand with a note, and your home and venue lists are written. Ask a human when a room full of equipment calls you: a community darkroom's intro class, a print shop's orientation, a design or photography class through a community college's continuing education, or a librarian who can show you the library's free software and scanning. Chapter 10 has more.

If perfectionism is running the editor. Set a two-edit limit per photo for a week. Start each session with an easy win, twenty frames of the mug on your desk. And let a permission page happen here too: one deliberately bad photo a day, badly lit, crookedly framed, kept.

Tools, including AI

Useful helpers: a phone and its built-in editor, a free drawing app, a scanner or scanning app, a stylus if you enjoy one, a small tripod or a stack of books to hold the phone still, a three-by-three grid overlay in the camera settings, a soft-cut block and a bench hook. Keep your originals. They're your process record, and if authorship ever matters, they're good evidence of what you made.

The AI rules in The Art Refresh Hour apply here in full, and this is the chapter where they matter most. One good use: after you've starred your two best frames, ask a chatbot for a checklist of composition questions to ask yourself about them. Questions, not a verdict, and not an edited version.

One firm no: generative fill, generated images or AI-extended scenes filed, signed or shown as your work. And keep photos of family, and above all of children, out of AI editing tools and off any shared bot computer. Many AI services keep a broad licence to what you upload, and some have people who review what's shared.¹⁹ If you use Grok Bot, remember that all of your bots share one computer, with its files, browser sessions and logins, so family photos don't belong there.⁷ Grok, the chatbot, and Grok Bot, the agent service, are different things; the caution is about the shared computer.

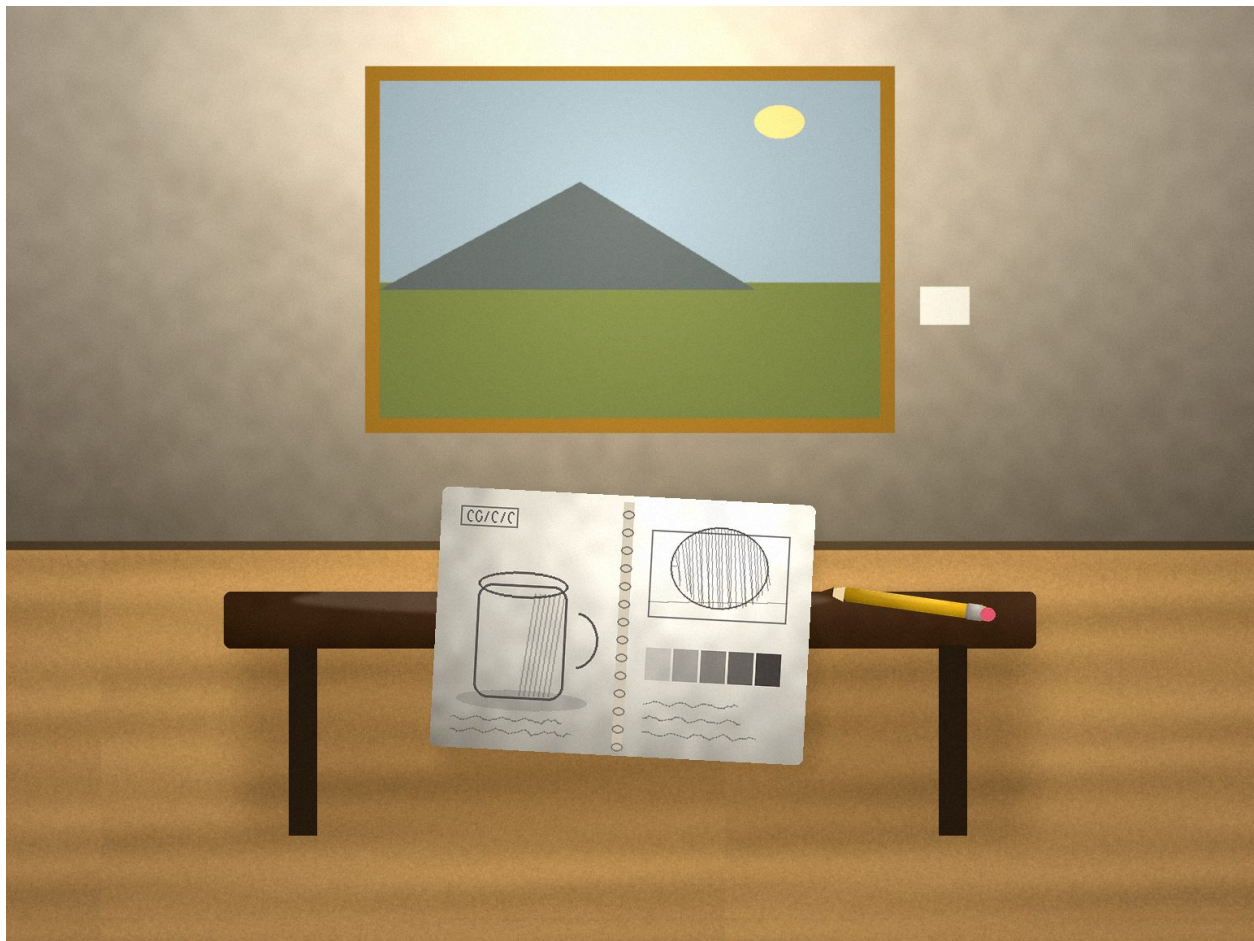
What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on, check:³⁹

- ☐ A contact sheet of twenty frames with two stars and a line about each.
- ☐ Five frames from a light walk.
- ☐ A thirty-frame one-subject sequence, or one well under way.
- ☐ A photo edited by hand, with a note of what you chose and what any tool changed.
- ☐ A layered digital piece with its stages saved.
- ☐ A finished card or poster that reads from across the room.
- ☐ A zine, or an edition of five block prints, numbered.
- ☐ Your home list and venue list, written, and your nearest community studio found.
- ☐ A whose-mark card with the tools line honestly filled on everything you'd keep.

Place yourself by what you can do. A lifelong photographer may breeze through the camera try-its and spend a month on block printing; someone who's never opened a drawing app may live happily in the digital daily page for weeks. Both are on track. Next week, photograph the same object you started with, twenty frames again, and put the two contact sheets side by side.

Chapter 6 — Looking at art: history and museums



Why this matters

Walk into a big museum on a Saturday and watch how people move. Many drift from frame to frame at a steady pace, a few seconds each, reading the label, glancing up, moving on, the way you might walk past shop windows. Then there's the person on the bench in front of one painting, who has been there for twenty minutes with a small sketchbook open on their knee. They aren't an

expert, necessarily. They've just decided to stay.

This chapter is about being the person on the bench. Looking at art is a skill, like drawing, and like drawing it grows with practice. It feeds your own work directly: every painting on a museum wall is a record of hundreds of decisions about crop, value, edge and color, and you can learn to read those decisions and borrow the good ones. It's also a pleasure of its own, one that asks nothing of you but time, and often very little money.

Plenty of adults feel shut out of museums. Maybe you had one art history class that felt like memorizing dates. Maybe you've stood in front of a famous painting feeling you were supposed to have a particular reaction and didn't. Maybe a modern gallery once left you wondering whether you were missing a joke. All of that is common, and none of it means you can't look well. You don't need a degree to look. You need a few good questions and the patience to let a picture answer them.

The first clause of the book's focus line lives most literally here: look long before you judge. In a museum, the verdict ("I like it," "I don't get it") usually arrives in about two seconds. This chapter teaches you to set the verdict aside for ten minutes and describe first. What comes after minute five is often the part worth the trip. The research here is modest and honest: looking closely at art is practice in looking closely.²⁹ That's the benefit, and it's a good one for anyone who draws.

You'll also learn to follow a thread through history rather than trying to swallow it whole, to make master copies the way artists always have (labelled as copies), to find the free and open-access collections that put thousands of great works on your phone, and to visit a museum as a relaxed, welcome guest.

Picture someone who used to visit museums once a year and leave after an hour with sore feet and a vague sense of having seen a lot. Now they go for one room. They sit. They sketch two works, write three questions, and leave while they still want to stay. They go more often, and they remember more.

What you can try today: three open questions about one artwork on your phone. What you can try this week: a ten-minute slow look, in person or on screen, and a list of what you noticed only after minute five.

Understand it yourself

The everyday picture. Think of how you listen to a good friend telling a long story. You don't interrupt at the first sentence with your opinion. You let them finish, you notice the details, you ask what happened next, and only then do you decide what you think. Looking at a painting well is that kind of listening.

The precise picture. Good looking has an order: describe first, then interpret, then, if you like, judge. Describing means naming what's actually there: a woman at a window, light coming from the left, a blue jug, a dark doorway behind her. Interpreting means asking what those things might add up to. Judging, whether you like it, comes last, and it's much more interesting after the first two.

Three open questions

A method called Visual Thinking Strategies, developed by Abigail Housen and Philip Yenawine for open-ended group discussions of art, uses three questions.⁴⁰ Adapted for one person with a sketchbook, they go like this:

1. **What's going on here?**
2. **What do I see that makes me say that?**
3. **What more can I find?**

The first invites a story. The second sends you back to the evidence in the picture. The third keeps you looking after you think you're done. That's the whole method, and it works on a Renaissance altarpiece, a photograph, a quilt or a painting made last year. It's simply a good way to slow down and notice.

A worked look

Here's the method in action, on an imaginary painting rather than a real one, so you can try it yourself on something real afterward. Picture a small painting of a woman standing at a table by a window, holding a letter.

What's going on here? She's reading a letter, and it seems to matter to her.

What do I see that makes me say that? She's holding it close with both hands. Her head is bent. The light from the window falls right on the paper and her face, and the rest of the room is darker. There's a chair pushed back, as if she stood up suddenly.

What more can I find? A map on the back wall. A second sheet of paper on the floor, half in shadow. Her reflection, faint, in the window glass. The table cover is rumpled on one side.

Notice what happened. The first answer was a guess. The second turned the guess into evidence you could point to. The third found things the first two walked past, and some of them (the dropped page, the pushed-back chair) change the story. You haven't needed a single date or name yet. When you do read the label, you'll read it as someone who has already looked.

Slow looking

Slow looking means staying with one work for longer than feels natural, say ten minutes. The first two or three minutes are usually the obvious things: the subject, the main colors. Somewhere around minute five, things you walked straight past begin to appear: a second figure in the shadows, a reflection in a spoon, a brushstroke that's just one flick. Writing down what you noticed after minute five is a small, reliable way to prove to yourself that the time was worth it.

Three distances, and other kinds of art

Most works reward being seen from more than one place. Look from across the room first, where only the big shapes and the value pattern survive; that's where you see the composition. Then from a middle distance, where you can read what's going on. Then as close as the museum allows,

where the brushstrokes, the pencil marks or the grain of the print show you how it was made. Many paintings that look highly detailed from across the room turn out, up close, to be a handful of quick, confident strokes. That's worth seeing for yourself, because it's a permission slip for your own painting.

The same questions work on every kind of art, with small adjustments. A sculpture asks you to walk around it; it changes from every side, and the back is often as interesting as the front. A print rewards a close look at the marks, and a moment to think about how it was made in reverse. A photograph asks where the photographer stood and what they left out. A quilt, a pot or a piece of furniture asks what it was for and how its maker balanced use and beauty. Chapter 5's question, "what did the maker choose?", travels everywhere.

Master copies

Artists have long learned by copying the work of other artists, in museums and from prints, to understand how a picture was made. A copy slows you down even more than slow looking; you can't copy a decision you haven't noticed. Copying from a free open-access image is simplest. In a gallery, check the museum's sketching rules first; pencil is the usual allowance.

Copies get labelled as copies. Write "copy after" and the artist, title and source on the page, and file it that way. A copy is a study, not your original, so it's never signed or sold as yours. Chapter 8 goes into the wider questions about using other people's work.

History by thread

The surest way to feel lost in art history is to try to take in all of it. The surest way to enjoy it is to follow one thread. Pick a theme and trace it across centuries: hands; windows; how painters show light; the still life; the portrait; landscape; the print. Five works across five centuries, each sketched as a thumbnail, will teach you more about how art changes, and what stays the same, than a hundred slides you half remember. Then pick another thread. Over a year, the threads start to cross, and without meaning to, you've built a history of your own.

A thread, sketched out. Say you choose windows. Search one open-access collection for "window" and scroll. You might find a page from a medieval manuscript with a tiny arched window behind a saint, a Dutch interior where a window is the only source of light, a nineteenth-century painting of someone gazing out at the sea, an early photograph of a shopfront, and a twentieth-century print where the window is just a flat rectangle of color. Sketch each as a thumbnail in date order. Under each, one line: what is the window *for* in this picture? Light, escape, a frame, a pattern? By the fifth thumbnail you'll have noticed something no textbook told you, and you'll own it.

Free first

Looking at art can cost nothing at all. Start here:

- **Your library.** Many libraries lend museum passes, and nearly all have art books and a librarian who can help you find more.

- **Free days and always-free museums.** Many museums have free days or evenings; some, like the National Gallery of Art, are free every day.
- **Museums for All.** If you receive SNAP food benefits, Museums for All offers free or reduced admission at more than 1,600 museums across the United States when you show your EBT card and a photo ID.⁴¹
- **Open-access collections.** Several major museums let anyone download images of public-domain works in their collections, free. The National Gallery of Art offers tens of thousands of free images.⁴² Smithsonian Open Access has released millions of items under CC0, which means free to use without asking permission.⁴³ The Cleveland Museum of Art and the Art Institute of Chicago release their public-domain images under CC0 too.^{44,45} The Metropolitan Museum of Art also runs an open-access program for public-domain works; check its site for what's currently included.⁴⁶

Save the credit line with every image you download: artist, title, date, museum. You'll want it for labelling copies, and it makes your folder a small personal collection instead of a pile of files.

Public domain, in one paragraph

A public-domain work is one no longer under copyright, free for anyone to use. In the United States, works published in 1930 entered the public domain on 1 January 2026, and each new year adds another year's worth.⁴⁷ For paintings and drawings, though, whether and when a work was "published" can be murky. So rather than work it out yourself, rely on the museum's own label. If a collection marks an image as public domain or CC0, you're on solid ground for study. This is US law only, and it isn't legal advice.

Museum manners

Museums want you there, sketchbook and all. A few habits make you a welcome guest. Check the sketching rules before you go; pencil in a small book is the usual allowance, and pens, paint or large pads may not be. Sit when you can; many galleries have benches. Leave room for others to see, and step aside when a group arrives. Keep a respectful distance from the work, and never touch it. If you're not sure about anything, ask a guard or someone at the front desk. In a small gallery or an art-league show, the person at the desk may be the artist, and they're usually glad of a good question.

Sketching in a museum

A museum sketch isn't a copy. It's a note. Use a small book and a pencil, sit if you can, and draw the big shapes and the pattern of lights and darks, not the details. Five minutes is plenty for one sketch. Squint at the painting the way you'd squint at a still life; you'll see its value plan at once. Write the artist and title under the sketch before you forget, and one line about what you noticed. Two or three sketches like that tell you more about a painting than twenty photos on your phone, because drawing makes you decide what matters. If you're bringing children, Chapter 8 has a way to visit at two paces, theirs and yours.

Museum pages you'll want to reread

Date the page. Write the museum or the collection. Put the credit line at the top. Then the three questions, or the slow-look list, or the sketch and its caption. Keep museum notes in the same sketchbook as your drawings rather than a separate book; months later, you'll like finding a page of questions about a painting next to the drawing where you borrowed its crop.

Bringing it home

Looking pays off most when some of it comes back to your own table. Keep a "borrowed" page at the back of your sketchbook, a running list of decisions you've taken from other artists, with the artist's name beside each: a crop, a palette, a way of leaving the edges loose, a habit of painting the shadows first. When a daily page feels stale, pick one from the list and try it. Over a year, that page becomes a record of your teachers, most of whom you've never met.

Contemporary art and living artists

Art isn't only in the past. Living artists are making work right now in your town, and many of them talk about it generously. Museum video channels, public-television art series and library databases carry artist interviews and studio visits. Local galleries and art-league shows let you see new work up close and sometimes meet the maker. Contemporary art can feel puzzling at first. The three open questions work on it just as well, and one more helps: what did the artist have to decide to make this?

Wrong turns you'll hear (including from yourself)

1. **"I don't know enough history to have an opinion."** You don't need history to describe what you see, and describing comes first anyway. The history can come later, one thread at a time.
2. **"Modern art is just..."** However that sentence ends, it's a verdict before a description. Ask what the artist had to decide: the size, the color, the material, what to leave out. It usually gets more interesting from there.
3. **"Copying is cheating."** Copying is a study, one of the oldest ways artists learn. It becomes a problem only if a copy is passed off as an original. Label it and it's honest work.
4. **"Museums are expensive."** Some are; many have free days, library passes or Museums for All, and open-access collections cost nothing. Free first.
5. **"The label will tell me what to think."** Labels are useful, and reading them is fine. Look first, then read, then look again. You'll notice whether the label changed what you see.

A five-minute warm-up

Open any image from an open-access collection on your phone. Set a five-minute timer. List ten things you can see in it, plain nouns and adjectives only, no interpreting: "a red curtain," "a dog's back leg," "light on a brass handle." If you reach ten early, keep going. Notice how many of your items you'd have missed in a quick glance.

How to try it this week

The Art Refresh Hour (Look · Sketch · Make · Step back · File) fits looking at art with barely a change. Here, the Look step is longer, and the Make step is often a sketch or a page of notes.

Commute/lunch (about 15–20 minutes). Look for a minute or two at one artwork on your phone, from an open-access collection. Sketch for ten to thirteen minutes: the three open questions in writing, or a thumbnail of the composition. Step back for a minute: what did I notice that I’d have missed? File in a minute: date the page and write the credit line.

Desk-or-shift (about 25–40 minutes). Look for three minutes at one work and name one thing you’ll watch for (“where the light comes from”). Sketch for five: a quick thumbnail of the big shapes. Make for fifteen to twenty-five: a ten-minute slow look with notes, then start an open-access folder or draw the decision you’d borrow. Step back for three to five minutes with the talk-to-yourself box. File for two minutes: date, practice strip, credit line.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes). Look for five to ten minutes. Sketch for ten: thumbnails of the works you’ll study. Make for twenty-five to forty-five: a labelled master copy, a five-work thread, or, as an outing, a one-room museum visit or a gallery walk. Step back for five to eight minutes, somewhere you can sit. File for three to five: whose-mark card for any copy (with “copy after” written on it), practice strip, credit lines.

Sentences to say to yourself

- “What’s going on here? What do I see that makes me say that? What more can I find?”
- “Describe before I decide.”
- “What did the artist have to decide?”
- “Sit down. Stay longer than feels natural.”
- “One room is a whole visit.”

Your first try-it: three open questions

Open an open-access collection on your phone and pick one work that catches you, a painting, a print, a photograph. Don’t read the label yet. In your sketchbook, write the first question, “What’s going on here?”, and answer it in a sentence or two. Then write “What do I see that makes me say that?” and list the evidence: the posture, the light, the objects. Then “What more can I find?”, and look again for two full minutes before writing anything.

Now read the label. Did it confirm something you saw? Add something you missed? Change your mind? Write one line about that. You’ve just done, alone and in ten minutes, what a good museum guide does with a group.

How to fade the help

Start with the three questions written on a card tucked inside your sketchbook. After a week, write them from memory at the top of each page. After a month, you’ll find yourself asking them silently in front of anything: a poster in the station, a quilt at a fair. Other help fades the same way. The

audio guide, the label, the museum's website and any chatbot context all come after your own look, not before, and over time you'll reach for them later and later.

When to stop

In a museum, stop before you're tired; museum fatigue is real, and the last half hour of a long visit is usually a blur. Leave while you still want to stay. At home, stop a look when you've found one decision you'd borrow; that's a complete session. For a master copy, stop when you've learned what you came for, even if the copy isn't finished. A half-copied painting with three decisions written beside it is a good day's work.

Practice that actually builds it

These try-its are a menu. Each names time, materials, safety and the move. Safety is light in this chapter: the museum's rules come first, pencils only unless the gallery says otherwise, and nothing touches the art. When a master copy moves to paint at home, the safety spine in *The Art Refresh Hour* and the painting habits in Chapter 4 come with it.

On the go

Three open questions. - **Time:** 10 minutes. - **Materials:** one artwork, in person or open access; a pocket book. - **Safety:** in a museum, pencil only unless posted otherwise. - **The move:** Write the three questions and answer them in order. If you stall, list ten things you see with no interpreting, then try again. Done when you have a page of notes.

The decision you'd borrow. - **Time:** 10 minutes, plus tomorrow's daily page. - **Materials:** one artwork. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Name one decision the artist made (a tight crop, a limited palette, one hard edge among soft ones) and try it in tomorrow's daily page. If nothing jumps out, borrow the crop. Done when you have a page labelled "after an idea from" and the artist's name.

Desk-or-shift

The ten-minute slow look. - **Time:** 10 minutes, plus a few for notes. - **Materials:** a timer, one artwork. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Look for ten full minutes. Write down only what you noticed after minute five. If ten minutes feels impossible, sketch while you look; the pencil keeps the eye there. Done when you have three late-noticed details.

Free first. - **Time:** 20 minutes. - **Materials:** a computer or phone; your library card. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Find your nearby museums' free days, your library's museum passes, Museums for All participants if you're eligible, and two open-access collections you like. If searching gets tangled, ask a librarian; this is exactly the kind of question they enjoy. Done when you have a list of three free visits.

Open-access folder. - **Time:** 30 minutes. - **Materials:** a computer or phone. - **Safety:** download only images marked public domain or CC0. - **The move:** Download ten public-domain images

for study from collections such as the National Gallery of Art, Smithsonian, Cleveland or Chicago, and save the credit line with each. If ten is too many choices, search one subject, say “window” or “hands.” Done when you have a labelled folder.

Living artist hour. - **Time:** 30 minutes. - **Materials:** an artist interview from a museum channel, a public-television art series or a library database. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Watch or read, and note one habit of process: how they start, what they keep on the wall, how they know when to stop. Try that habit this week. If the whole interview is long, watch only the studio-visit part. Done when you’ve tried one habit.

Weekend deep sit

Master copy, labelled. - **Time:** 60 minutes. - **Materials:** an open-access image or a work in a gallery that allows sketching; pencil or your usual medium. - **Safety:** the museum’s sketching rules; pencil in galleries unless told otherwise. - **The move:** Copy a drawing or painting, and write three decisions the artist made as you go. Label it “copy after” with the artist, title and source; it’s a study, never signed or sold as yours. If the whole work is too much, copy one detail: a hand, a window, a fold of cloth. Done when you have a labelled copy and three noted decisions.

Follow a thread. - **Time:** 45 minutes. - **Materials:** an open-access collection search. - **Safety:** ordinary. - **The move:** Pick one theme (hands, windows, light) and find five works across several centuries. Sketch a thumbnail of each in date order and write one line under each. If the search sprawls, use one museum’s collection only. Done when you have a five-thumbnail timeline.

Outings

The one-room visit. - **Time:** about 60 minutes. - **Materials:** a pencil and a small sketchbook. - **Safety:** check the museum’s sketching rules before you go; usually pencil only. - **The move:** Choose one room. Walk it once, slowly. Pick two works, sit down near them, and sketch each one. Write a caption under each: artist, title, one line about what you noticed. If the room is crowded or nothing speaks to you, sketch the room itself, benches, doorways, people at a distance. Done when you have two captioned sketches and you left before you were tired.

Gallery walk. - **Time:** about 60 minutes. - **Materials:** a notebook. - **Safety:** ordinary; many small galleries and art-league shows welcome walk-ins, but check hours. - **The move:** Visit a local gallery or art-league show. Find one piece you’d like to ask the artist about, and write the question. If you’re not sure where to begin, read the labels first, then look. If the artist or a volunteer is there, you might even ask. Done when you have one question written.

The talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked): “What do I notice first, what keeps me looking, and what decision did the artist make that I could borrow?”

Follow-ups (pick three or four):

1. **Meaning:** “When I say it’s ‘powerful’ or ‘boring,’ what exactly in the picture am I responding to?”
2. **Representation:** “What does my thumbnail of it show? Where are the big lights and darks?”
3. **Alternative:** “What else could that dark doorway be doing: balancing the window, hiding something, pulling me in?”
4. **Check:** “If I read the label now, will it support what I saw, or surprise me?”
5. **Revise:** “I’m allowed to change my mind about this work, including about whether I like it.”

The Hour stem works in front of your master copy: “Before I fix, erase, or ask a tool: what do I actually see, what was I after, and what’s the one change I’ll try next?”

How to wait alone. After you ask yourself a question, look back at the artwork, not at your phone or the label. Count a slow three, a teaching habit from classrooms, not a rule. If nothing comes, cover the label with your hand, or look away at the floor for a minute and then look back fresh. Answering in one second is usually the verdict talking.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague (“what does it mean?”). You’re hunting for the right answer, the one the label or the expert would give. You’re judging before describing. You’re tired; museums are tiring. Or worry, that you’re not the sort of person who gets art, is taking your attention. Shorten the visit, get one small win (ten things listed, one thumbnail), and come back another day.

Blocked, then mixed

When the questions are new, use only them for a week: three open questions on a different work every day, same order, written down. That’s blocked practice, and it makes the questions automatic.

Then mix. A mixed session might be a ten-minute slow look, then a thumbnail, then choosing whether this work is best for a master copy, a borrowed decision, or a place on your thread. You’re practising which kind of looking each work rewards.

A looking week, one way to do it

An illustration, not a timetable. Monday on the train: three open questions about an open-access painting. Tuesday at lunch: the decision you’d borrow from the same painting, tried on your daily page. Wednesday evening: start the open-access folder, five images on the theme of hands. Thursday: nothing. Friday: five more images for the folder. Saturday morning: the one-room visit, two sketches, home by lunch. Sunday: a master copy of one hand from your folder, labelled, with a whose-mark card that says “copy after” and the credit line. By Sunday night you’ve looked harder at more art than in the last five years of quick visits, and you’ve barely left the house.

One incorrect example to diagnose

This is an illustration, not anyone’s real notes. Picture a page from a museum visit. At the top, a painting’s title. Underneath: “Don’t like it. Too dark. Looks unfinished. Why is this famous?” That’s all.

Before you read on, name what happened.

Every line is a verdict, and none is a description. “Too dark” might be true, but dark where? Doing what? “Looks unfinished” might be the most interesting thing about the painting, if you asked what the artist chose to leave rough. The repair is to go back, or pull up the open-access image at home, and run the three questions. List ten things you see. Then write the verdict again, if you still want to. It may not change. But it will be your verdict about the painting, not about the two seconds you spent in front of it.

If it isn’t clicking

Museums feel overwhelming. Too many rooms, too many people, sore feet by the second hour. *Next move:* one room, two works, and sit down. Go early or late when it’s quieter. Plan to leave after an hour. A short visit you enjoy beats a long one you endure, and it makes the next visit more likely.

History feels like a textbook. Names and dates, and none of it sticks. *Next move:* follow one thread. Choose something you already care about (dogs, kitchens, the sea) and find five works across time. The history attaches itself to the thread, and threads are easy to remember.

“I just don’t get it.” A work leaves you blank, or faintly irritated. *Next move:* describe ten things before any meaning. Then ask what the artist had to decide. Not getting a work is allowed; so is not liking it after a good look. What changes is that your reaction becomes information rather than a closed door.

When to slow down, go on, or ask a human. Slow down if your notes keep jumping to verdicts; spend another week on the three questions alone. Go on when you can stay ten minutes with a work, describe before judging, and have a labelled copy and a thread to show. Ask a human when you want company or context: a docent-led tour, a museum’s adult programs or sketching events, a librarian who can point you to good books on one artist, or a friend who’ll do the three questions with you in front of the same painting. Chapter 10 has more.

Picture a sixty-something who hadn’t been inside an art museum since a school trip, and who went back with a plan: one room, one bench, the three questions on a card. The first visit lasted forty minutes. The fourth lasted two hours and included a conversation with a stranger about a painting of a dog. Nothing about their knowledge changed first. Their habit did, and the knowledge followed.

If you feel out of place, or worry about doing it wrong. That feeling is common, and programs like Museums for All exist because museums want more people through the door. Go with a small, specific plan so you have a job to do: one room, two sketches. Keep visits short. Start with an early win you can’t miss, ten things listed about the first work you see. Let one museum sketch a visit be a permission page, scrappy on purpose. Sit where you’re comfortable. You belong there as much as anyone on the bench.

Tools, including AI

Useful helpers: a museum’s online collection search, often better for study than the galleries themselves; the museum’s own label and collection page; your library’s art databases and books; a folding stool if the museum allows one; a small pencil kit; your open-access folder, with credit lines.

The AI rules in The Art Refresh Hour apply here unchanged. One good use for this chapter: after you’ve written your own notes on a work, ask a chatbot for historical context about it, then check each claim against the museum’s own page before you keep it. Chatbots sometimes invent sources and details that sound perfectly confident.⁴⁸ The museum page is your check.

One firm no: asking a chatbot “what does this painting mean?” before you’ve looked. That hands your looking to a machine and trains the very habit this chapter is undoing. And a reminder from the Hour’s rules: no generating images “in the style of” a living artist to post or sell. Borrowing a decision, labelled, is study. Generating imitations isn’t.

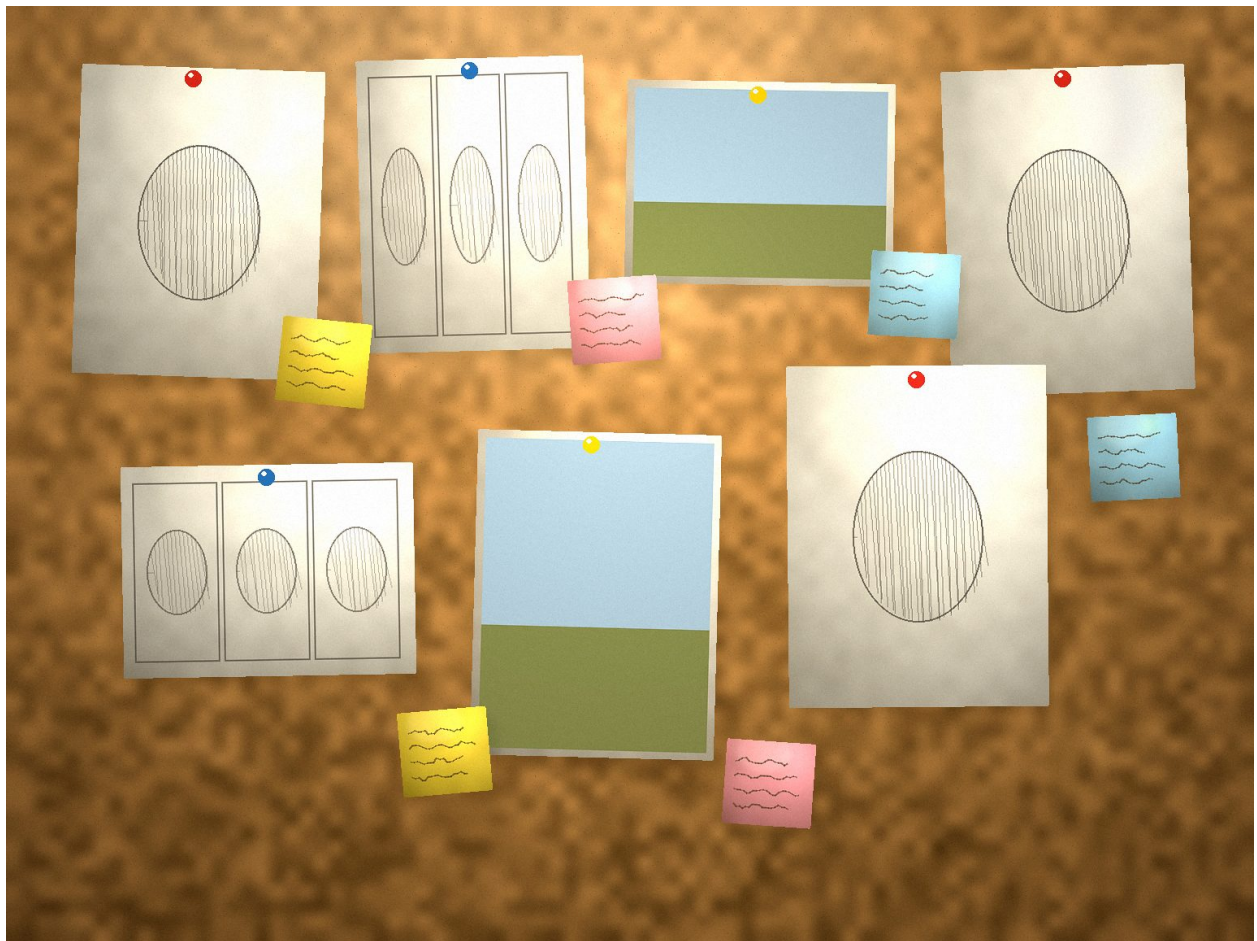
What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on, check:⁴⁹

- ☐ Three pages of open-question notes, on three different works.
- ☐ A ten-minute slow look with three details you noticed after minute five.
- ☐ One labelled master copy (“copy after” with artist, title and source), filed as a copy.
- ☐ A five-work thread across time, in thumbnails.
- ☐ A folder of ten open-access images, each with its credit line.
- ☐ One borrowed decision tried on a daily page.
- ☐ One museum, gallery or art-league visit, even a short one.
- ☐ You can describe a work for a full minute before you say whether you like it.

Place yourself by what you can do. Someone who’s never been comfortable in museums may spend a month on open-access images at home and one short visit, and that’s exactly right. Someone who’s visited museums all their life may find the master copy is the new part. Next week, go back to the first work you studied, on your phone or in person, and run the three questions again. See what you notice now.

Chapter 7 — Critique, feedback and your own statement



Why this matters

Sooner or later a piece is finished, or finished enough, and a question arrives. Is it any good? You might ask it alone at the kitchen table at ten at night. A friend might ask it for you, kindly, with “Oh, that’s nice.” A teacher in a Saturday class might ask it out loud in front of eight people you’ve just met. However it comes, the question can feel like a verdict waiting to happen.

This chapter turns that question into a skill. Feedback is how practice stops being repetition and starts being practice that builds something. Researchers who pooled many studies of deliberate practice found that focused work matters: a slightly hard target, a way to see how you did, and another go. They also found it isn't the whole story, and nobody needs to count hours.²³ Of the three parts, "a way to see how you did" is the one a solo adult most often skips. You make the drawing, you feel something about it, and you turn the page. Critique is the missing middle.

Many adults carry an old story about critique. Maybe it was a high-school art room where the teacher held up your drawing and said what was wrong with it. Maybe it was a relative who laughed at a painting on the fridge. Maybe it was nothing dramatic, just years of hearing "That's lovely, dear," which tells you nothing. If critique makes your shoulders rise, that's a common, sensible response to feedback that was badly shaped. It says nothing about your talent. The fix is a better shape.

That shape exists. You'll learn a four-step way of responding to art that puts the maker in charge, and you'll use it three ways: alone with a day-old piece, with one trusted partner, and in a group. You'll learn how to take a note without flinching or arguing, and how to sort what you hear into what to try and what to set aside. You'll also learn to write about your own work in plain words: a one-line caption, and a 100-word statement a friend could read and understand.

The focus line holds all of it. *Look long before you judge* applies to your own work as much as a painting in a museum. You describe what's on the paper before you call it good or bad. *Sketch before you polish* applies to words, too. A statement starts as notes and a spoken answer, not a finished paragraph. *Sign only what you made* means every word of your statement is yours. No chatbot writes it. A clumsy sentence you mean is worth more than a smooth one you'd never say.

Here's what this chapter unlocks. On the train tomorrow, you can look at yesterday's page for one minute and write one honest line: one thing that works, one change to try. At the table this week, you can run the four steps on your own piece in twenty minutes. This weekend, you can sit with a friend and ask them the question you actually want answered, instead of waiting to hear whether they "like it." And by the end of the chapter you'll have a short statement that sounds like you on a good day.

Understand it yourself

The everyday picture: a good tailor. Think of a good tailor at a fitting. They don't start by telling you the jacket is wrong. They ask what it's for: a wedding, a job, every day. They look at you in the mirror for a long moment. They pin one sleeve, step back, and look again. Only then do they say, "I'd take this in a little here. Want me to?" You can say yes or no, because it's your jacket. That's the whole of good critique: find out what the maker was after, look carefully, ask before you offer an opinion, and leave the decision with the maker.

The precise picture: step back, then four steps. Critique in this book has two layers. The first is the **step back**, the fourth step of every Art Refresh Hour. The second is a longer **response process** for a piece you care about.

The step back is literal. Painters step back from the easel because distance shows what closeness

hides. You can get that distance several ways:

- hold the piece at arm's length;
- prop it across the room and look from the doorway;
- turn it upside down, so your eye stops reading “face” or “tree” and sees shapes;
- look at it in a mirror, which makes it strange enough to see fresh;
- take a phone photo and switch it to grayscale, which shows value (how light or dark each part is) without color getting in the way.

Then name one part that works and one change to try. That's all. The step back takes one to five minutes and it happens every session.

The response process is for the pieces that matter to you. This book uses Liz Lerman's Critical Response Process, which she devised in 1990 as a way of giving and getting feedback on creative work in progress. Her own description says it's meant to leave the maker eager to get back to work, which is a fine goal for any critique.⁵⁰ It has three roles: the **artist** (you), the **responders** (whoever is looking), and a **facilitator** who keeps the steps in order. It has four steps, always in this order.

1. **Statements of meaning.** Responders say what struck them, stayed with them, or felt meaningful. No fixes yet. “The light on the kettle made me want to touch it.” “The empty chair feels like someone just left.”
2. **The artist asks questions.** You ask what you want to know. “Does the background read as a window or a wall?” “Where does your eye go first?” Responders answer the question you asked and stay on it. This is the step that changes everything. You're asking for help instead of waiting for judgment.
3. **Responders ask neutral questions.** These are questions without an opinion tucked inside. More on these below.
4. **Opinions, with permission.** A responder names the topic and asks first: “I have an opinion about the edges on the left. Would you like to hear it?” You can say yes, or “Not today,” and both are fine.

After step four, you can say out loud what you'll try next. That's optional, and it's a satisfying way to end.

What a neutral question is. A neutral question leaves the verdict with the maker. Compare these two:

- “Why did you make the border so heavy?”
- “What were you thinking about when you chose the dark border?”

The first one sounds like a question, but it carries a judgment (too heavy). The maker hears criticism and starts defending. The second one asks about a decision without grading it. The maker gets to explain, and often discovers something while explaining. Most of us were raised on the first kind. The second kind takes practice, and the practice is worth it, because you'll start asking yourself neutral questions too.

Why opinions come last. The order isn't politeness for its own sake. When you ask your own question first, you hear the answer as help. When a verdict lands first, most people stop listening, and some stop showing their work at all. Opinions still arrive. They just arrive after the maker has

said what they wanted and asked what they needed.

A vocabulary for what you’re getting better at. A research team that studied high-school art classes closely described eight “studio habits of mind” that good art teaching builds: develop craft, engage and persist, envision, express, observe, reflect, stretch and explore, and understand art worlds.⁵¹ You don’t need to score yourself on these. They’re useful words when you’re trying to name what changed. “I observed longer this month.” “I stretched into a medium I’d been avoiding.” “I persisted through a painting that was ugly for three sessions.” That last one counts. It may be the most useful habit of all.

A diagnosis order for a piece that isn’t working. When something feels off and you can’t say what, check in this order: **value, proportion, edges, composition, color.** Value first, because most “flat” or “muddy” work is a light-and-dark problem, and a grayscale photo shows it in seconds. Proportion next, because a nose that’s too long or a chair leg that’s too short pulls the eye every time. Then edges: are they all equally hard? Then composition: where does the eye go, and does it get stuck? Color comes last, not because it matters least, but because it’s easiest to fix once the others are right. This order follows the book’s main idea: most drawing trouble is seeing trouble, so the checks are all ways of seeing again.¹

How to receive feedback. Here’s the move, and it’s simple enough to fit on an index card. Write down what you hear, word for word if you can. Say “thank you.” Hold your answer for later. Then, sort every note into one of three piles:

- **Try:** you want to test it on this piece or the next one.
- **Not for this piece:** it may be true, but it’s not what you were after here.
- **Ask more:** you don’t understand it yet, and you’d like to.

The sorting is yours. A note in the “not for this piece” pile isn’t a rejection of the person who gave it. It’s a decision about your work, which you’re allowed to make.

Captions, statements and a short talk. Writing about your work comes in three sizes. A **one-line caption** is title, medium, date and one line of why: “Kettle at 7 a.m. Graphite, 12 October 2026. I wanted to see if I could draw steel without drawing a single outline.” A **100-word statement** answers three questions in plain words: what you make, how you make it, and what you’re exploring right now. A **two-minute talk** is the same thing said out loud to friends, in the voice you’d use at dinner.

Wrong turns you’ll hear (including from yourself)

“Critique means tearing it apart.” What it usually means: past feedback came as a list of faults, so that’s what the word means to you. The move: start with meaning. The first step of the process is what works and what stays with you. Nothing gets torn.

“If they don’t like it, it’s bad.” What it usually means: you’ve handed your judgment to whoever spoke last. The move: sort the feedback. One person’s taste goes in “not for this piece” as easily as anywhere else. Ask yourself what you were after, and judge the piece against that.

“A statement needs art words.” What it usually means: you’ve read gallery statements full of words like “liminal” and “interrogates,” and assumed that’s the standard. The move: plain words.

If you can't point to the place in the drawing where a sentence happens, the sentence goes.

“The chatbot said it's great.” What it usually means: you asked a tool for a verdict, and tools are fluent and often flattering. The move: ask for questions, not verdicts, and only after your own step back. Fluent praise isn't a check.

“I'll just say it isn't finished.” What it usually means: you're protecting the piece before anyone can say anything. The move: show it anyway, and say what stage it's at. Work in progress is exactly what this process was built for.

Five-minute warm-up

Find yesterday's page, or any page from this week. Hold it at arm's length for one minute. Turn it upside down for one minute. Then write one line under it: “Works: . **Next:** .” Keep it short and specific. “Works: the shadow under the cup. Next: lighten the background so the rim shows.” That line is the seed of everything else in this chapter.

How to try it this week

This week the Art Refresh Hour leans hard on its fourth step. You still look, sketch and make, but the step back gets more time, and filing now includes a caption. Here's how it fits each context.

Commute/lunch (about 15–20 minutes). *Look* (1–2 minutes): open the book to yesterday's page and look before you judge. *Sketch* (10–13 minutes): today's daily page, as usual. *Step back* (1–2 minutes): arm's length, then upside down. One line: works / next. *File* (1 minute): date the page and add a one-line caption to one piece from this week. On a crowded train, the phone's grayscale photo is your across-the-room view.

Desk-or-shift (about 25–40 minutes). *Look* (3 minutes): choose a piece that's at least a day old. Distance in time works like distance in space. *Sketch* (5 minutes): jot notes, not drawings, on a blank page. *Make* (15–25 minutes): run the solo response process on that piece, or draft your 100-word statement. *Step back* (3–5 minutes): the talk-to-yourself box below, opening plus one follow-up. *File* (2 minutes): a line in your practice strip; staple the notes behind the piece.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes). *Look* (5–10 minutes): choose one piece and one question you really want answered. *Sketch* (10 minutes): write your question and three things you already think about the piece, then fold that paper away. *Make* (25–45 minutes): the partner response process with a friend or family member, or a group crit at a class or sketch group. *Step back* (5–8 minutes): the full talk-to-yourself box on what you heard. *File* (3–5 minutes): sort your notes into try / not for this piece / ask more, and fill the whose-mark card if the piece is a keeper.

An outing, if you like. Bring one piece and one question to a class, an art league or a sketch group. You don't have to present. You can listen the first time and bring work the second. Chapter 10 lists the kinds of places that run these.

Exact words you can say to yourself

When you finish a piece and feel the verdict coming, say this, out loud if you're alone:

“What was I after — where does the piece get there, and where doesn't it yet?”

Then look at the piece, not at your phone. Wait for a slow three before you answer. Other lines that help:

- “Describe first. Judge later.”
- “What's one part that works? What's one change I'd try?”
- “Is this a value problem? Let me check in grayscale before I touch anything.”
- “Thank you. I'll write that down.”
- “Would I like my own opinion on this today, or is it too soon?”

The first try-it

One piece, four steps, alone (20 minutes, at the table). Pick a drawing or painting from two or three days ago. Prop it up where you can see it from your chair. On a sheet of paper, write four headings: *What stays with me*, *What I want to know*, *Neutral questions*, *My opinions*. Fill them in that order. Write at least three lines under the first heading before you let yourself touch the others. The full version of this try-it is in the next section; this is enough to start.

How to fade help

In the first week, keep a card with the four steps written on it and follow it line by line. In the second week, run the steps from memory and check the card at the end. By the third or fourth week, the order should feel ordinary: meaning, your questions, neutral questions, then opinions if you want them.

The same goes for help from a tool. If you've been asking a chatbot what to look at again, try a week without it. Do your own step back, write your own line, and notice whether you miss the tool or not. The Art Refresh Hour's AI box explains the “try first” rule; here it simply means your own look comes first, every time.

When to stop fiddling

Here's a sign you've gone from critique into fiddling: you've changed the same passage three times in one session and each change undoes the last. Stop. Write down what you were after in one line. Turn the piece to the wall until tomorrow. A tired eye can't judge anything. Another sign: you're reading your notes for the fourth time hoping they'll say something new. They won't. Pick one “try” note and do it on the next piece instead.

Practice that actually builds it

Every try-it names time, materials, safety and the move. Pick one or two at a time; nobody needs all of them this week.⁵² Critique is mostly paper and attention, so the safety lines are short. They're about people, and about the ordinary studio habits from the Art Refresh Hour's safety spine if you're painting while you critique.⁶

On the go (commute/lunch)

The step back - *Time*: 3–5 minutes, at the end of any session. - *Materials*: today's work; a phone with a grayscale setting, or a small mirror. - *Safety*: on a train or bus, keep your bag in your lap and stay aware of your stop. - *The move*: arm's length, across the room (or the length of the carriage), upside down, then grayscale. Name one part that works and one next change. Write it on the page. If you can't see anything, try the mirror; it often shows a tilt or a lean you'd stopped noticing.

The one-line caption - *Time*: 5 minutes. - *Materials*: your sketchbook or the back of a piece. - *Safety*: none beyond keeping names of other people out of captions you'll post. - *The move*: title, medium, date, one line of why. If the why won't come, start with "I wanted to see..." and finish the sentence. Do five captions this week, one a day on the commute.

The process note - *Time*: 10 minutes. - *Materials*: your sketchbook. - *Safety*: none. - *The move*: after a session, three lines. What I tried. What happened. What's next. On a tired day, one line is enough. A week of process notes becomes a map of what you're learning, and it makes your statement much easier to write later.

Desk-or-shift

The solo response process - *Time*: 20 minutes. - *Materials*: a piece at least a day old; paper; the four-step card. - *Safety*: if the piece is wet oil, keep your rags in their lidded can while you work. - *The move*: write the four steps for yourself, in order. First, statements of meaning: what stays with you, as if you were a friendly stranger seeing it for the first time. Second, your questions as the artist: what you'd want a good teacher to tell you. Third, neutral questions a curious stranger might ask, and your answers. Fourth, your own opinions, but only after you've asked yourself, "Do I want to hear this today?" If step four feels too harsh, stop after step one. Step one alone is a real session.

The 100-word statement - *Time*: 30 minutes. - *Materials*: paper; your process notes if you have them. - *Safety*: none. - *The move*: answer three questions, each on its own, in plain words. What do I make? How do I make it? What am I exploring right now? Say each answer out loud before you write it. Then join them into one paragraph and count. Cut every word you can't point to in the work. A statement is done enough when a friend who doesn't draw can read it and tell you back what you're up to.

Here's an illustration of the shape, written for a composite reader, not a real person:

I draw the kitchen, mostly in the early morning before anyone else is up. I use graphite and a small sketchbook, and lately a few gray markers for value. I'm exploring how

little line I need. For a month I've tried to draw metal things — the kettle, a spoon, the tap — using only light and dark shapes, no outlines. Some of them look like puddles. A few look like steel. I've learned that the shine is mostly about the darkest dark sitting right next to the lightest light. Next month I want to try glass.

That's about 100 words. Nothing in it is fancy. Every sentence points at something on the page.

Look-and-write - *Time*: 20 minutes. - *Materials*: one artwork, in a museum or from an open-access collection (Chapter 6 shows where to find them). - *Safety*: in a gallery, follow the museum's rules on sketching and photography. - *The move*: write about 150 words. Describe first: only what's there. Then write what the work made you notice. Writing about someone else's art is the easiest way to practice writing about your own, because nothing of yours is at stake.

Diagnose a wrong one - *Time*: 20 minutes. - *Materials*: an old piece that didn't work; a phone for a grayscale photo. - *Safety*: none. - *The move*: check value, proportion, edges and composition, in that order. Stop at the first real problem. Name it in one sentence ("The whole thing is middle gray; there's no dark dark") and write a redo plan in one more. If that's too much, check value only. Most of the time value is the answer anyway.

The talk for friends - *Time*: 20 minutes. - *Materials*: three pieces; a phone to record yourself, if you like. - *Safety*: if you record, keep the file on your own device. - *The move*: talk out loud for two minutes about the three pieces, as if a friend had just asked, "So what are these?" Then listen back once. If two minutes feels long, talk about the why of just one piece. The spoken version usually sounds more like you than anything you'd write first, and it's a fine place to steal sentences from.

Weekend deep sit

The partner response process - *Time*: 30 minutes. - *Materials*: one piece; one friend or family member; the four-step card, one copy each. - *Safety*: choose someone you trust for the first round. People safety counts, too. - *The move*: explain the four steps before you show the piece. You can act as your own facilitator the first time. Your partner starts with what stays with them. Then you ask your questions. Then they ask neutral questions (show them the dark-border example if they're new to it). Then they ask permission before any opinion, and you choose. Write everything down. End with three "try next" notes. If the full process is too much, run only steps one and two. Those two alone will change how you see your piece.

The group crit - *Time*: about 60 minutes, at a class or sketch group. - *Materials*: one piece; one written question; a notebook. - *Safety*: follow the group's own ground rules; if there's a facilitator, requests go through them. - *The move*: bring one piece and one question. When it's your turn, say what stage the piece is at and ask your question. Then listen and write. Save your explanations unless someone asks you directly. Afterward, sort your notes into try / not for this piece / ask more. If this feels like too much for a first visit, go and listen. Bringing work the second time is a perfectly good plan.

The talk-to-yourself box

This box sits inside every step back this week. Ask the opening, then one or more follow-ups.

Opening: “What was I after — where does the piece get there, and where doesn’t it yet?”

Follow-ups: - *Meaning:* “When I say the sky feels ‘off,’ what exactly do I mean? Too dark, too busy, the wrong temperature?” - *Representation:* “What does the grayscale photo show about that corner? What does the thumbnail I made before I started show?” - *Alternative:* “What else could make the left side feel heavy, besides adding more dark?” - *Check:* “If I change the edge on the jug, how will I know it worked? What will I see from across the room?” - *Revise:* “I’m allowed to change my mind about what I was after. Maybe this piece is about the shadow, not the jug.”

How to wait alone. After you ask yourself the question, look back at the piece, not at your phone. Count a slow three. That pause is a teaching convention borrowed from classrooms, not a rule, but it helps. If you still have nothing, cover the reference, or turn the piece to the wall for a minute, then look again. Rescue at one second is still rescue, even when you’re the one doing the rescuing.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question may have been too vague; try a smaller one (“Which corner?”). You may be hunting for a “right” answer that doesn’t exist. You may be judging before describing; go back and list three things you can see. You may be tired. Or worry may be eating your attention. Any of those is ordinary. Shorten the session, get one small win (a single “works” line, one grayscale check), and come back tomorrow.

Blocked practice, then mixed

When a move is new, practice it on its own for a few days. That’s blocked practice. For the first week, run the solo response process on a different day-old piece each time, and write captions on every page, until the four steps and the caption shape feel routine.

Then mix. In the second week, don’t decide in advance which tool you’ll use. At the end of each session, choose: is this a quick step back, a caption, a process note, or a full solo process? Choosing is the real skill. Study-habit research, mostly with students, suggests mixing tasks and spreading practice across days helps things stick; it’s a reasonable bet for adult art practice, too.²⁵

An incorrect example to diagnose

Here’s a composite illustration. Picture two friends at a kitchen table. One has painted a watercolor of her grandmother’s hands folded on a tablecloth, from memory and a few sketches. She props it up. Her friend leans in and says:

“The hands are wrong. The fingers are too long, and the thumb’s on backwards. Also I’d make the tablecloth more interesting. Maybe a pattern?”

The painter says, “I know, I’m not good at hands,” and puts the painting away.

What went wrong? Nothing in the friend’s words is cruel, and some of it may even be accurate. But the order is upside down. The first thing said was an opinion, and it arrived without permission.

Nobody asked what the painter was after. Nobody said what worked. The painter never got to ask her own question. So she heard a verdict, agreed with it, and filed the painting under failure.

Now run it again in four steps.

Statements of meaning. The friend says: “The hands look tired in a gentle way. The light on the knuckles made me think of someone resting after a long day.”

The artist asks. The painter says: “I was trying to get how still she used to sit. Does it feel still to you? And do the fingers read as fingers, or do they get lost?”

Neutral questions. The friend asks: “What were you thinking about when you left the tablecloth plain?” The painter answers: “I wanted nothing to compete with the hands.” That’s a decision, now stated out loud, and it was a good one.

Permissioned opinion. The friend says: “I have an opinion about the thumb. Would you like to hear it?” The painter says yes. “It seems to bend the wrong way at the second joint. Might be worth checking your own hand in the same pose.”

Same painting. Same friend. This time the painter leaves with a clear “try” note (check the thumb against her own hand), a “not for this piece” note (the tablecloth pattern), and something just as valuable: she knows the stillness landed. The painting goes on the shelf instead of in the drawer.

If it isn’t clicking

Here are three common snags and the next move for each.

1. Feedback stings, even when it’s gentle. You know the note is fair, but your face goes hot and you want to put the work away. *Next move:* do the solo process for two weeks before you show anyone. You’ll get used to hearing notes in your own handwriting first, where nothing is at stake. Then choose one trusted partner, run only steps one and two, and stop there. Add steps three and four when steps one and two feel easy.

2. Your statement feels fake. Every sentence you write sounds like a museum wall label, or like someone else. *Next move:* answer the three questions separately, on three different days. Say each answer out loud to an empty room, or record it on your phone, and write down exactly what you said. Your spoken sentences are usually truer than your written ones. Join them only at the end.

3. Group crits feel intimidating. You’d rather not have eight strangers looking at your work. *Next move:* go once and bring nothing. Listen to how the group talks. Notice that most people’s work is somewhere between rough and pretty good, just like yours. The second time, bring one small piece and one question. You’re allowed to pick a piece you care about only a little.

When to slow down. If every session turns into an hour of notes and no new drawing, you’ve tipped too far toward critique. Go back to the daily page for a week and keep the step back to one line.

When to go on. When you can run the solo process without the card, take a note without arguing, and write a caption in five minutes, you’re ready for Chapter 8, where critique turns into choosing

which pieces belong together.

When to ask a human. A class, a teacher, an art league’s critique night, a sketch group, or a librarian who knows what’s on locally can all help. You don’t need permission to ask. If you notice that one person’s feedback always leaves you feeling small, that’s useful information too. Look for a different room.

Anxiety and perfectionism. If showing work, or even looking at your own, fills you with dread, make the sessions shorter. Five minutes of step back is plenty. Get an early win: write one “works” line and stop. Make a permission page, a deliberately rough page you don’t critique at all, and keep it in the front of your sketchbook as a reminder that not every page is up for review. This book is a practice manual, not therapy. If worry is getting in the way of more than your art, a clinician is the right person to talk to.

Tools, including AI

A few helpers make the step back easier: a small hand mirror, a phone set to grayscale, a viewfinder card to crop the piece in different ways, a voice memo app for your two-minute talk, and a pad of sticky notes for sorting feedback into three piles.

The Art Refresh Hour’s AI box covers the general rules: try first, and a tool is a tutor, never the hand. For this chapter, that means two things.

One allowed use. After your own step back, and after you’ve written your own notes, you may ask a chatbot for questions about a photo of your work. Crop the photo to the work itself, with no faces and nothing identifying. Ask for questions, not verdicts: “Without telling me whether it’s good, what three things should I look at again about value and edges?” Then compare its questions with your own notes. Keep one you agree with and one you don’t, and say why. If you use art-history facts or quotes in a statement, check each one against the museum’s own page. Chatbots can invent sources that sound entirely real.⁴⁸

One no. A chatbot doesn’t write your statement, your caption or your talk, and it doesn’t “polish” them into something you wouldn’t say. This is the book’s rule, and it matches the spirit of some AI services’ own terms, which ask users not to present machine output as human-written.¹⁸ While we’re here, skip the AI detectors that claim to tell whether writing “sounds human.” Detectors often flag writing that people wrote themselves, especially from writers whose first language isn’t English.⁵³ Your statement sounds like you because you wrote it. That’s the only check it needs.

What “done enough” looks like

You’re ready to move on when you can honestly check most of these:

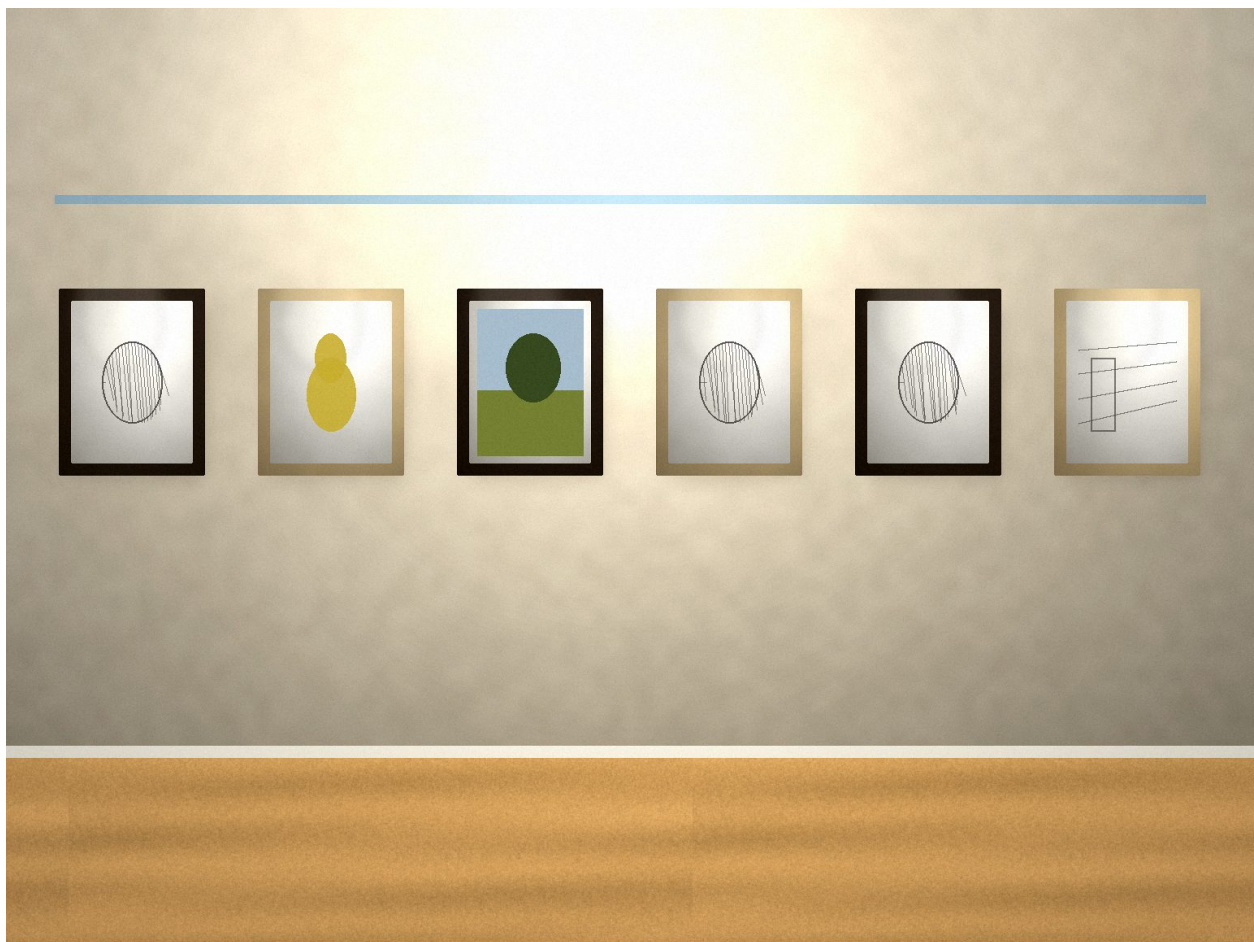
- ☐ A week of daily pages each has a step-back line: one thing that works, one change to try.
- ☐ I ran the solo response process on at least one piece and kept the notes.
- ☐ I ran the partner process once, or went to one group crit, even just to listen.
- ☐ I sorted feedback into try / not for this piece / ask more, and tried at least one “try” note.

- ☐ Five pieces have one-line captions.
- ☐ I have a 100-word statement a friend understood when they read it.
- ☐ I can say my statement out loud in about two minutes without reading it.
- ☐ Every word of the statement and captions is mine.

Place yourself by what you can do, not by how long you've been drawing. Someone who has painted for decades may need a month on the partner process because they've always worked alone. Someone three months into their return may take to it in a week. Both are doing the book.

Revisit next week. Pull out your statement and read it again. If a sentence no longer sounds true, change it. Statements are supposed to move as you do.

Chapter 8 — Keeping going: projects, a body of work, showing or sharing



Why this matters

Something often happens a few months into coming back to art. The daily pages are going well. You've drawn the mug from six angles, painted the pear in three passes, sat through a museum room with a pencil. You're better than you were, and you can see it. And then, one ordinary week, the sketchbook stays in the bag. Nothing went wrong. You just aren't sure what the exercises are

for anymore.

That stall is common, and it isn't a sign you've run out of interest. It usually means you've finished the part of practice that runs on novelty and reached the part that needs a direction. Exercises build skill. Projects give skill somewhere to go. A project has a subject, a shape and an end: ten drawings of the same tree, a sketchbook that covers one trip, a small painting every week for a year. You know when you've started, and you know when you're done.

There's a second thing that keeps adults going, and it's simpler than it sounds: someone to show. Not a gallery. Not a jury. A friend on the sofa looking at six pieces taped to your hallway wall. A child next to you at the kitchen table, drawing the same apple. A small group online that you chose on purpose. Art made for a drawer tends to stay small. Art that expects to be seen, even by three people, tends to get finished.

This chapter covers both. You'll learn series thinking: how to choose one subject or problem and make ten of it, how constraints make that easier rather than harder, and how the wall test shows you what you've actually been making. You'll learn to share at home and on community walls, to post online with care, and, if you'd like, to price a piece simply and keep honest records. Because many readers come to art alongside a child or grandchild, you'll also learn to make art *next to* kids without turning the table into a lesson.

A popular picture of the artist is someone struck by inspiration who works in a fever until dawn. Adult practices that last tend to look different. They're built on routine: small daily pages, projects with limits, a regular time and place. That's good news. Routine is something you can set up this week. Inspiration isn't.

Here's what this chapter unlocks. Tomorrow, on the commute, you can make one small piece for a box that will hold a year of them. At the table this week, you can tape ten pieces to a wall and find out what you've been circling without knowing it. This weekend, you can invite two friends over for tea and a very small show. And if you make art with kids, you can sit side by side on Sunday afternoon, each with your own page, and let neither page be a lesson.

Understand it yourself

The everyday picture: a gardener's notebook. Think of someone who has kept a vegetable garden for years. They don't plant a different random thing every week. They grow tomatoes, and they grow them again next year, a little differently. Different spacing, different variety, earlier start. After five summers they know tomatoes in a way no single summer could teach. Their notebook isn't a collection of unrelated successes. It's one long question, asked over and over. A series is that notebook in art.

The precise picture: a body of work. A *body of work* is a group of pieces that belong together because they share a subject, a problem, a medium or a way of working. It doesn't need to be large. Ten to twenty pieces is plenty. What makes it a body rather than a pile is that each piece answers the last one a little. "The shadow was too dark in the third one, so in the fourth I tried it lighter." That chain of small decisions is where growth happens, and it's also what makes a group of pieces interesting to someone else.

Series thinking: ten of one thing. The simplest project in art is to choose one subject or one problem and make ten. Ten mugs. Ten views of the same window. Ten small paintings of the sky at six p.m. Ten drawings of your own hands. A subject is a *thing* (the tree across the road). A problem is a *question* (how dark can a shadow get before it stops looking like daylight?). Either works. The only rule is that you keep coming back.

Constraints free you. It sounds backwards, but limits make projects easier. When you can paint anything, the blank page is enormous. When you can use only one color, or only a four-inch square, or only one hour, the choices shrink to a size you can handle. Good constraints for adults include one medium, one size, one color plus black and white, one time limit, one location, or one hour a week. Pick one constraint and make six pieces inside it. You'll usually find the constraint stops feeling like a fence and starts feeling like a frame.

Projects with an end. A few project shapes suit adult lives especially well:

- a **trip or season sketchbook**, one book for one journey or one season, with start and end dates on the cover;
- a **year of small pieces**, one index card or small panel a day or a week, kept in a box, with a dated list;
- a **zine** or a small family book of drawings, like recipes with pictures or a neighborhood walk;
- **ten of one thing**, over two to four weeks.

Each has a clear finish line. Finishing is its own reward, and it builds the trust in yourself that makes the next project easier to start.

The wall test. Every so often, take the pieces off the table and out of the sketchbook and put them up where you can see them all at once. Tape ten to twenty to a wall. Step back. Move them around. Sort them by subject, then by color, then by how much you like them. Before long, a group of six to ten will seem to hang together, often not the group you expected. That's your body of work telling you what it's about. Then write the next piece's brief: one line saying what the next piece will try. "Next: the same window, but at night." "Next: the kettle again, with only two values."

Showing, at the scale that suits you. Sharing starts small. A **home show** is six to ten pieces on a wall or shelf, with short captions, for a few friends and a pot of coffee. **Community walls** come next: many public libraries, cafés and community centers hang local work, and art leagues often hold members' shows. **Craft fairs** are another route if you make things people might buy. If a café or shop offers to sell your work on **consignment** (they hang it and take a share when it sells), read the agreement before you sign. Know what percentage they keep, and who's responsible if a piece is damaged or stolen.

Posting with care. Posting online is a kind of showing, and it has its own habits:

- Post a good photo at a modest size, not the full-resolution file.
- Before you post on any service, read its terms about the licence you grant to what you upload and whether it uses uploads to train AI. Many services take a broad licence to anything you upload, and some let people review what's shared.¹⁹ Terms change, so check the current page.
- Tools exist that may help protect posted images. One university research tool adds changes meant to disrupt style copying; its makers say plainly that it is "not a permanent solution."⁵⁴

Content Credentials, an open standard, record where a file came from and how it was edited, like a nutrition label for an image.⁵⁵ Treat both as options, not guarantees.

- Keep your originals and a few dated process photos. They're lovely to have, and they're also good evidence that the work is yours.
- No photos of children who haven't agreed. That includes your own. Older kids get asked first; younger ones are simply kept out of public posts. If the child has another parent, that parent gets a say too.
- Photos of children and family members stay off AI tools and off any shared bot computer. More on that in "Tools, including AI."

Pricing simply. If someone wants to buy a piece, here's a plain starting rule: **materials plus time plus a look at comparable local work.** Add up what the materials cost. Put a modest hourly figure on your time. Then walk through two or three local shows or fairs and see what similar pieces by people at a similar stage are priced at. Land somewhere sensible, and keep your prices consistent from one venue to the next. Keep a simple sales log: date, piece, buyer (first name is fine), price, where.

Hobby or business? The IRS treats a hobby as an activity you pursue without the intention of making a profit. It looks at a number of factors together, including whether you run it in a businesslike way and keep records, how much time you put in, whether you depend on the income, whether you've changed methods to improve profits, and your history of profit or loss. No single factor decides it. Hobby income is still reported, on Schedule 1 of Form 1040.⁵⁶ Selling at craft fairs may also involve sales tax, which varies by state; your state's revenue department can tell you what applies. This isn't tax advice. If sales grow, talk to a tax professional.

Copyright, the basics. In the US, copyright exists automatically the moment you fix an original work in a tangible form, such as paper, canvas or a saved file. You don't have to register anything for your drawing to be yours. Copyright protects the expression, not the idea: anyone may paint a bowl of lemons, but nobody may copy *your* painting of a bowl of lemons. Registration is optional, but it matters before you could ever sue over a copy, and Chapter 9 covers it for anyone who wants to.⁵⁷ Two rules follow for sharing and selling. Label copies as copies ("copy after ____") and never sell or sign one as an original. And if you work from someone else's photograph, get their permission or use your own reference. Whether a use is "fair" depends on a legal balancing test with several factors, and it's rarely the simple case people hope it is.⁵⁸ This isn't legal advice; for anything beyond the basics, ask a lawyer.

Making art alongside kids. If you share your table with children or grandchildren, here's the move: **side by side, separate pages.** Same subject, same materials, two pieces. You make your own drawing of the apple. They make theirs. You don't correct their page, and they don't correct yours. When you talk about the work, you use a small version of the four-step process from Chapter 7: everyone says what they notice first, the maker asks one question, and opinions come only if they're invited. At a shared table, use materials that carry the ACMI AP Seal, which is labelled for kids in sixth grade or younger, and keep adult-only materials (solvents, products carrying the CL Seal meant for adults and older kids, sharp blades) stored out of reach.^{11,6} At a museum, go at two paces: one room, one work each, sketch, then swap. At home, a **fridge show** gives everyone a spot: one piece per person, rotated weekly, with a caption. Chapter 10 points you to the three earlier books in this series if you'd like to teach children art more fully.

Wrong turns you'll hear (including from yourself)

“I need a gallery before I count as an artist.” What it usually means: you've taken the most visible version of an art life as the only one. The move: sharing starts at home. A home show for three friends is a real show. Most art in the world is seen by a handful of people who care.

“I need a big idea before I can start a series.” What it usually means: the blank page feels enormous. The move: ten of one thing, starting with whatever you've drawn most often. The idea tends to show up around piece six.

“I'll post everything everywhere.” What it usually means: posting feels like the way to be seen, and reading terms feels like homework. The move: read the terms first, post at modest size, and choose one or two places on purpose rather than every place by default.

“If I sell one piece, it's a business.” What it usually means: you've heard that selling changes your tax situation, and it's unclear how. The move: the IRS weighs several factors together, and one sale doesn't decide it. Keep a sales log either way, and talk to a tax professional if sales grow. (Not tax advice.)

“I'll just fix my kid's drawing so it looks right.” What it usually means: you love them and you can see how to make the horse look more like a horse. The move: make your own page next to theirs. They'll look at yours if they want to. Their page stays theirs.

Five-minute warm-up

Gather your last ten pieces, whatever they are: daily pages, studies, a painting or two. Tape or prop them up in a row. Look for five minutes without judging any single one. Then write one line: “The thing I keep coming back to is ____.” You'll use that line all chapter.

How to try it this week

This week the Art Refresh Hour points toward a project. Look and sketch still come first. Make now serves a series. Step back now happens across several pieces at once, not just one. File grows to include captions and, if you sell, a record.

Commute/lunch (about 15–20 minutes). *Look* (1–2 minutes): pick the subject of your series and find it, or something like it, around you. *Sketch* (10–13 minutes): one small piece for a year-of-small-pieces box, an index card or a four-inch square. *Step back* (1–2 minutes): lay it next to yesterday's card; one thing that changed. *File* (1 minute): date the back and drop it in the box.

Desk-or-shift (about 25–40 minutes). *Look* (3 minutes): gather ten to twenty recent pieces. *Sketch* (5 minutes): thumbnail the wall. Where will the pieces go? *Make* (15–25 minutes): the wall test. Tape them up, move them, find the group that hangs together. *Step back* (3–5 minutes): the talk-to-yourself box below. *File* (2 minutes): write the next piece's brief in one line and tape it inside your sketchbook cover.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes, or an afternoon). *Look* (5–10 minutes): walk the house for a spot with good light and a clear wall or shelf. *Sketch* (10 minutes): plan which six to ten pieces

go where. *Make* (25–45 minutes): hang a home show, write short captions, and add one sentence from your statement. *Step back* (5–8 minutes): look at the show from the doorway, then from a chair. *File* (3–5 minutes): photograph the wall, update the whose-mark cards, and send two friends an invitation.

With kids, if you make art alongside them. A desk-or-shift session at the kitchen table: one subject, separate pages, AP-seal materials, no correcting. Fifteen minutes of drawing and five minutes of “what do you notice?” is a complete session.

Exact words you can say to yourself

When you look at a group of your pieces together, ask:

“Looking at these pieces side by side, what am I clearly circling — and what will the next one try?”

Then look at the wall, not the phone. Wait for a slow three. Other lines that help:

- “Which three would I keep if I could only keep three? What do they share?”
- “What’s the constraint for the next six?”
- “Who are the three people I’d like to show this to?”
- “Have I read this site’s terms before I post?”
- “Is this my page or theirs?” (Useful at the family table.)

The first try-it

Ten pieces, one wall (20 minutes, at home). Take the warm-up a step further. Put ten to twenty pieces on a wall with painter’s tape. Move them until a group of six to ten seems to belong together. Take down the rest. Look at the group from across the room and write one line: “Next: ____.” That line is the brief for piece one of your first series.

How to fade help

For the first series, let this chapter set the structure: ten of one thing, one constraint, a wall test at the end. For the second, choose your own number and your own constraint. By the third, you may find you plan series without thinking of them as series at all. You’ll just notice you’re on the fourth window and wondering what the fifth will be.

If you’ve been using a tool to suggest project ideas, fade that too. The Art Refresh Hour’s AI box explains why your own attempt comes first; here, that means your own wall test comes before anyone else’s suggestion.

When to stop fiddling

A series is done when it’s done, not when it’s perfect. If you’ve reached ten and the last three feel repetitive, you’ve learned what that subject had to teach you for now. Stop, do a wall test, and write

the next brief. If you're rehang the home show for the fourth time on the morning your friends are coming, stop. Anything straight enough to look at is straight enough.

Practice that actually builds it

Every try-it names time, materials, safety and the move. These are menus, not a calendar; pick what fits your week.⁵⁹ The Art Refresh Hour's safety spine still applies to whatever medium you're using; the safety lines here add what's specific to projects, showing and family tables.

On the go (commute/lunch)

The year of small pieces - *Time*: about 10 minutes a day, or once a week. - *Materials*: index cards or small panels; a box; a pen or small kit. - *Safety*: if you paint on the go, keep the water jar clearly different from your coffee cup. - *The move*: one small piece a day, or a week, for a year. Date the back. Keep a list inside the box lid. If daily feels like too much, switch to weekly without guilt. A box of fifty-two cards at the end of a year is a body of work.

The next piece - *Time*: 10 minutes. - *Materials*: your notes from the latest wall test. - *Safety*: none. - *The move*: write a one-line brief for the next piece. What will it try? If nothing comes, borrow from the strongest piece on the wall: its color, its crop, its subject. "Next: same crop as the blue one, but a different window."

Trip or season sketchbook - *Time*: ongoing; a page a day is plenty. - *Materials*: one sketchbook; a pen; a small kit if you like. - *Safety*: when you draw outdoors or in a new place, sit somewhere safe and out of the way; ask before you draw anyone up close. - *The move*: choose one book for one trip or one season. Write the start and end dates on the cover. One page a day, or a few pages on the days you can. When the season ends, the book is done, full or not.

Desk-or-shift

Ten of one thing - *Time*: spread over two to four weeks. - *Materials*: whatever medium you're using now. - *Safety*: the Art Refresh Hour's usual rules for that medium. - *The move*: ten pieces on one subject or one problem. If you stall, change one constraint each time: a different size, a different time of day, a different medium. Line them up at the end. The change from the first to the tenth is the point.

The constraint project - *Time*: one session a week, for six weeks. - *Materials*: depends on the constraint. - *Safety*: the usual rules for the medium. - *The move*: choose one constraint (one color plus black and white, one five-inch square, one hour) and make six pieces inside it. If choosing a constraint feels hard, start with size. It's the gentlest.

The wall test - *Time*: 20 minutes. - *Materials*: painter's tape or clips; a clear wall; 10–20 pieces. - *Safety*: use tape that won't take paint off the wall, and a step stool, not a chair, for anything high. - *The move*: pin them up, step back, move them around. Sort by subject, then by color, then by feeling. Find the six to ten that belong together. If you can't see a group, sort by color alone; it often reveals one.

Price it simply - *Time:* 30 minutes. - *Materials:* a notebook; your material receipts, roughly. - *Safety:* keep buyers' contact details private. - *The move:* for each piece you'd sell, write materials plus time plus a comparable local price. Settle on a number and keep it consistent everywhere. Start a sales log page. If you're unsure, visit three local shows and note prices for similar work before you set yours. (Not tax advice.)

Posting with care - *Time:* 20 minutes. - *Materials:* a phone; daylight; one piece. - *Safety:* no children who haven't agreed; no family photos on AI tools or shared bot computers. - *The move:* photograph the piece square to the camera in daylight. Save a modest-size copy for posting and keep the original. Read the service's terms on licences and AI training before you post. Write a one-line caption. If posting publicly feels like too much, share with a small private group first.

Weekend deep sit

The home show - *Time:* an afternoon. - *Materials:* 6–10 pieces; tape or clips; captions on cards; one sentence from your statement. - *Safety:* keep the show away from the kitchen if any piece is unvarnished pastel or charcoal, and clear walkways for guests. - *The move:* hang a small show and invite two or three friends. Put a one-line caption beside each piece and your statement sentence by the door. If a wall feels like too much, three pieces on a shelf is a show.

Community walls - *Time:* an outing, plus a follow-up conversation. - *Materials:* a portfolio (photos are fine); a few captions. - *Safety:* read any agreement before you leave work anywhere; note who insures it. - *The move:* visit a library, café, community center or art league that hangs local work. Ask how their process works: who chooses, how long work hangs, whether they sell. You don't have to apply today. One conversation is a good week. If a public wall feels too big, join a league first and show in a members' show.

With kids and family

Side by side - *Time:* 30 minutes. - *Materials:* AP-seal materials; two pages; one subject. - *Safety:* adult-only materials stay stored out of reach; wash hands after. - *The move:* same subject, separate pages. You make your own piece. You don't touch theirs. If it drifts into a lesson, switch to drawing each other's shoes. It's hard to be bossy about a shoe.

The family critique - *Time:* 15 minutes. - *Materials:* the day's pieces. - *Safety:* everyone may pass. - *The move:* everyone says what they notice first in each piece. The maker asks one question. Opinions come only if the maker invites them. If that's too much structure, just go round once with "What do you notice?"

Museum with kids, adult pace too - *Time:* about 60 minutes. - *Materials:* two sketchbooks; pencils (check the museum's sketching rules). - *Safety:* follow the museum's photo rules; no photos of other people's children. - *The move:* one room. Each person picks one work. Sketch for ten minutes, then swap sketchbooks and look at each other's choice. If attention runs short, sketch from a bench and call it a win.

The fridge show - *Time:* 10 minutes a week. - *Materials:* magnets; small caption cards. - *Safety:* photos of the fridge stay off shared computers and AI tools, since they'll show children's names

and work. - *The move*: one piece per person on the fridge, rotated weekly, each with a caption. If weekly is too often, rotate monthly. The adult gets a spot too.

The talk-to-yourself box

Use this box at every wall test, and whenever you look at more than one piece at a time.

Opening: “Looking at these pieces side by side, what am I clearly circling — and what will the next one try?”

Follow-ups: - *Meaning*: “When I say these feel ‘the same,’ do I mean the subject, the colors, the mood or the way I made them?” - *Representation*: “What does a phone photo of the whole wall, in grayscale, show about which pieces belong together?” - *Alternative*: “What else could hold this group together if it isn’t the subject? A time of day? A color?” - *Check*: “How will I know the next piece moved the series forward? What will be different on the wall?” - *Revise*: “I’m allowed to change my mind about what this series is. Maybe it’s about light, not windows.”

How to wait alone. After you ask, look back at the wall, not at your phone. Count a slow three. That pause is a classroom-borrowed convention, not a rule. If nothing comes, take two pieces down and look at the group again, or turn one to face the wall for a minute.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question may be too big; ask about just two pieces. You may be looking for the “right” series, as if there were one. You may be judging pieces before describing what’s on the wall. You may be tired. Or you may be worried that what you’ve been circling isn’t impressive enough. Circling is circling. Shorten the session, get one win (a single “Next:” line), and come back tomorrow.

Blocked practice, then mixed

At first, practice one project shape on its own. Do one series of ten, with no year-of-small-pieces box and no home show yet. Get the feel of sticking with a subject.

Then mix. Once a series is underway, let the small daily card, the weekly series piece and the monthly wall test run alongside each other. Deciding which one today’s twenty minutes belongs to is part of the skill. So is noticing when a daily card belongs in the series after all.

An incorrect example to diagnose

Here’s a composite illustration. Picture someone who has been painting for about a year. Scrolling one evening, they find a beautiful photo a stranger posted of a lighthouse at dusk. They paint it carefully over two weekends, copying the composition and the colors closely. It’s the best painting they’ve done. They post it for sale at a local online market, tagged “original painting,” and a neighbor offers to buy it.

What went wrong? The painting may be honest work with the brush, but three things are off.

First, **permission**. The composition, the light and the moment were chosen by the photographer. Painting from their photo and selling the result without asking uses their work. A lighthouse is an

idea anyone may paint; that particular photograph is someone's expression.

Second, **labelling**. "Original painting" suggests the whole image was the painter's own. It's more accurately a painted copy of someone else's photograph.

Third, **the whose-mark card**. Had the painter filled one in, the "references" line would have read "photo by a stranger online, no source saved," and the problem would have been visible before the sale, not after.

Here's the fix. Take the listing down. If the painter can find the photographer, they can ask permission to sell, and credit them if the answer is yes. If not, the painting stays as a study, labelled "painted from a photograph by another photographer; not for sale." For the next lighthouse, the painter goes and takes their own photos, or sketches on location, or uses a public-domain image with its credit line saved. Then they paint a series of five from those, fill a whose-mark card for each, and sell the one they like best, as an original, honestly.

If it isn't clicking

Here are three common snags and the next move for each.

1. You can't think of a project. Every idea feels either too small or too grand. *Next move:* ten of one thing, and make the subject whatever you've drawn most often in the last month. Flip back through your sketchbook and count. It's usually the mug, the view from a window, a pet or your own hand. That's your subject. You've already chosen it; you just hadn't noticed.

2. You're afraid to show anyone. Even the thought of a home show makes you want to put everything away. *Next move:* a home show for three friends you trust, three pieces on a shelf, no speeches. Tell them it's a practice show. Offer tea. When they arrive, point to one piece and say one sentence about it. That's all. The second show will be easier than the first.

3. The family table keeps turning into a lesson. You meant to draw side by side, and twenty minutes later you're explaining perspective to a seven-year-old who's stopped listening. *Next move:* separate pages, no corrections, and one question only: "What do you notice?" Draw something where nobody can be "right," like each other's shoes or the view with your eyes half closed. Keep your own page going. They'll watch what you do more than they'll hear what you say.

When to slow down. If you've started three series at once and finished none, pick one and put the others in a folder marked "later."

When to go on. When you've finished one series, done a wall test and shown the work to at least one person, you've done what this chapter is about. Chapter 9 helps you keep records of it all.

When to ask a human. An art league, a class, a sketch group or a friendly café owner can all help with showing. A librarian can help you find local exhibition opportunities. For selling beyond a few pieces, a tax professional is worth a conversation. For copyright questions beyond the basics, a lawyer.

Anxiety and perfectionism. If a project feels too big, shrink it. Ten pieces can be ten three-inch squares. If you can't bear to show a piece, show a page you care about only a little, and notice

that nothing terrible happens. Keep a permission page nearby for days when the series piece won't come; a rough page still counts as practice. This is a practice manual, not therapy. If worry is affecting more than your art, a clinician is the right person to talk to.

Tools, including AI

Useful helpers for this chapter: painter's tape and clips for wall tests; a box for small pieces; a phone for photographing the wall in grayscale; a spreadsheet or notebook for your sales log and dated list; a simple frame or two for a home show.

The Art Refresh Hour's AI box covers the general rules. For this chapter, one allowed use and one no.

One allowed use. After your own wall test, and after you've written your own brief, you may ask a chatbot for questions that could sharpen the brief. "Here's the one-line brief for the next piece in my window series. Ask me five questions that might make it more specific." Keep the questions that help. Throw out the rest.

One no. No generated "pieces" to fill out a series or a show. A generated image isn't your mark. The US Copyright Office has said that prompts alone don't make someone the author of an image; what you draw, paint, arrange or meaningfully change is yours.⁵ By this book's rule, a generated image is never filed, signed, shown or sold as your work, and a series is made of pieces you made.

The Grok Bot caution. If you use Grok Bot, remember that all of your bots share one computer, including its files, browser sessions and logins.⁷ So photos of children and family members, fridge-show snapshots included, stay off it. The same goes for any AI tool you don't control.

What "done enough" looks like

You're ready to move on when you can honestly check most of these:

- ☐ I made a series of ten, or six inside a constraint.
- ☐ I did a wall test and found a group that hangs together.
- ☐ I wrote a one-line brief for the next piece.
- ☐ I showed work to at least one person: a home show, a shelf, a community-wall conversation or a small group I chose.
- ☐ If I posted, I read the terms first and posted at modest size.
- ☐ If I sell, I have a price list and a sales log page.
- ☐ Any copy I've made is labelled as a copy, and every filed piece has a whose-mark card.
- ☐ If I make art with kids, we had at least one side-by-side session, separate pages, no corrections.

Place yourself by what you can do, not by how long it took. Someone might finish a series of ten in three weeks; someone else might take three months. A retiree might hold a home show every season; a parent of toddlers might manage one fridge show and a box of forty small cards in a year. Both are keeping going, and keeping going is the whole point.

Revisit next week, and the week after. Put the next piece up beside the last ten and ask the opening question again.

That's where this book's teaching chapters end, and it's a good place to stop and look back. You came in rusty, or brand new, or somewhere in between. You've trained your eye before your hand. You've made pages small and often. You've learned to step back before you fix, to ask for the feedback you need, and to say in plain words what you're after. Now you have a body of work growing and a few people to show it to.

The last two chapters are practical: how to keep honest records, and where to find classes, open sessions, studios and free collections near you. The practice itself is already yours. Carry the focus line with you. It works on the train, at the kitchen table, in the museum and on the wall:

Look long before you judge; sketch before you polish; sign only what you made.

Then turn to a fresh page, write tomorrow's date at the top, and leave it there waiting.

Chapter 9 — Records



Somewhere in your house there's probably a drawer of old things you made: a school painting, a few pages from a sketchbook you abandoned, a clay pot with a thumbprint in it. You can't remember when you made most of them, what you were trying to do, or whether someone helped. They're precious anyway. They'd be more useful if they came with a note.

This chapter is about the note. Records in this book are small and plain: a card that travels with each piece, a strip of dated lines for each month, a few redraws of the same page, and a portfolio of your best twenty. None of it is paperwork for its own sake. Records serve you in three ways. They show your progress when you can't feel it. They remind you what worked, so you can do it again. And if it ever matters, they show which marks are yours.

Records are also where honesty lives. This book isn't a course. It doesn't award credit, and it never issues a certificate. What it offers instead is a way of keeping a record so clear that a stranger could pick it up and understand what you did. That's worth more than any certificate a book could print.

This week you can do two things: start a practice strip on the inside cover of your sketchbook, and fill a whose-mark card for the best piece you've made this month. Everything else in this chapter builds from those.

What you're keeping

Here's the whole list. Five kinds of record, each small:

- **The whose-mark card**, one per piece you'd keep: what you made, how, and what help or tools you used.
- **The practice strip**, one line per session: date, minutes, band, what, one note.
- **Progress redraws**: your baseline page, redrawn at week 6, week 12, and then every few months.
- **A portfolio of twenty**: your best ten to twenty pieces, photographed well, with a simple list.
- **Class records**, only as the provider issued them: course name, provider, dates, hours, and continuing education units if the provider gave them.

You don't need a binder, a filing cabinet or special software. A box, an envelope, a folder on your computer and the back pages of your sketchbook will do. The best record system is the one you'll actually keep up on a Tuesday night.

A word on how much. A line after each session and a card for each keeper is plenty. You're not writing a diary, and you're not building a case. If a week goes by with no records, write one line saying so and carry on. A record with gaps is still an honest record.

Here's what a year of this can look like, as an illustration. Picture someone who came back to drawing last autumn after twenty years away. Their sketchbooks sit on one shelf, dated on the spines. Inside each front cover is a practice strip, most lines under twenty minutes, a few long Saturday lines, and some honest blanks in December. An envelope in the back of each book holds whose-mark cards for the pieces they kept. A thin folder holds the baseline page and four redraws, in order. Another folder holds twenty photographs and a one-page list, and a third holds a completion letter from a community-college evening class. It took perhaps two minutes a day to keep. Anyone who picked it up would understand exactly what they'd done.

The whose-mark card

You met the whose-mark card in the Art Refresh Hour, as part of filing. You've been filling short versions of it since Chapter 2. Here's the full version, field by field, and why each one is there.⁶⁰

Title. Anything that helps you find it later. "Kettle, no outlines #4" beats "Untitled." If the piece is a copy of someone else's work, the title says so: "Copy after a Dutch still life, National Gallery of Art open access."

Medium. What it’s made of and on: “graphite and gray markers on sketchbook paper,” “gouache on 140 lb watercolor paper,” “phone photo, edited.” Add the size if it’s a physical piece.

Date and hours. The date you finished, and roughly how long it took. “About 1¼ hours over two sessions” is fine. Hours help you see, months later, how much patience your better pieces took.

My marks. What you did with your own hand and eye. For most pieces, this is “all drawing and painting.” For a collage, a photo or a mixed piece, spell it out: “composition, all drawing; background paper from a magazine.”

Tools. Anything that did part of the looking or making: a grid, a projector, a phone’s grayscale photo, a photo editor’s auto-enhance, a digital brush that imitates texture. Tools are fine. Writing them down keeps the record honest and reminds you what helped.

References, with source. What you worked from: “from life, my own kettle,” “my own photo, 12 October,” “open-access image, Cleveland Museum of Art, with its credit line.” If you worked from another person’s photograph, note whether you had permission. This is the line that would have saved the lighthouse painter in Chapter 8.

Help received. Who helped, and how. “Saturday class teacher suggested darker darks; I made the change.” “My partner held the mirror.” Help is normal. Artists have always had teachers, friends and critics. Recording it isn’t a confession; it’s accuracy.

AI. Either “none,” or exactly what a tool did. “After my step back, asked a chatbot for three questions about edges; it made no marks.” By this book’s rule, a generated image is never filed, signed, shown or sold as your work, so if an AI tool produced any part of the picture, this line says which part, and your “my marks” line doesn’t claim it.

Consent. For any person pictured: did they agree, and to what? “Portrait of my neighbor; she agreed to the drawing and to a home show, not to posting online.” For children, only your own family, with their okay, and photos of them stay off shared computers and AI tools. If no one is pictured, write “no people.”

Signature. Your name or initials, signed by hand. It’s a small ceremony that says: these marks are mine.

Here’s what a filled card might look like, as an illustration:

Title: Kettle, no outlines #4 **Medium:** graphite and gray markers on sketchbook paper, 5 × 8 in **Date / hours:** 14 October 2026 · about 1¼ hours, two sessions **My marks:** all drawing and shading **Tools:** phone grayscale photo to check values **References:** my own kettle, from life, morning window light **Help:** class teacher suggested darker darks near the lid; I tried it **AI:** none **Consent:** no people **Signature:** _____

On a busy day, use the short version: **title, date, and “all mine” or “help from ____.”** Fill in the rest when you have five minutes. A short card beats no card.

Digital work and photographs use the same card with a few extra words. For a phone photo, the tools line names the edits: “cropped, exposure and contrast by hand; no filters” or “auto-enhance on.” For a digital drawing, note whether you saved your layers or stages, and keep them; they’re the digital version of process photos. If an app offered to “improve” the image with generated fill

or a style effect and you accepted, that goes on the AI line, and the part it made isn't claimed as your marks.

Keep the cards together: tucked into an envelope inside the back cover, clipped to the piece, or typed into one running document with the photo beside each entry. What matters is that the card and the piece can find each other.

The practice strip

The practice strip is the simplest record in the book and probably the most useful. It's one line per session with five parts:

Date · minutes · band · what · one note

“Band” means which kind of session it was: commute/lunch, desk-or-shift, or weekend deep sit. Here's a week, as an illustration:

12 Oct · 14 min · commute · daily page, the man's shoes across the aisle · first try without lifting the pen
 13 Oct · 0 — · missed; long day · fine
 14 Oct · 35 min · desk · kettle #4, value study · the darkest dark goes right against the shine
 16 Oct · 12 min · lunch · five color notes, parked car · sky was greener than I thought
 18 Oct · 70 min · deep · museum, one room, two sketches · stayed with the Dutch still life for 20 min

That's all. Keep it on the inside cover of your sketchbook, on one sheet of paper per month, or in a notes app. On a day when even one line feels like too much, a checkmark and a number of minutes will do.

The strip does three things over time. It shows you your real rhythm, not the one you imagine. It shows which band you actually live in, so you can plan around it instead of against it. And its one-line notes add up to a quiet record of what you've learned. At the end of each month, when you flip through your pages (the monthly flip from Chapter 2), add one sentence to the strip: what changed this month.

If you notice long gaps, that's information, not failure. Look at what was happening that week and ask what would have made a twelve-minute page possible. Often the answer is a smaller kit, or a different cue.

Progress redraws

Back in Chapter 1, you made a baseline page: a mug, your non-drawing hand and a corner of a room, ten minutes each, dated, left alone. That page is the most honest measure of progress this book has, because it's the same three subjects every time.

When to redraw. At week 6 and week 12 after you start, then every three months or so. Put the dates on a calendar now so they don't depend on your mood.

How to redraw. Keep the conditions as close to the first time as you can: the same mug, the same hand, the same corner, the same kind of pencil and paper, the same ten minutes each. Draw without

looking at the old page first. Date the new page and leave it alone, just as before.

How to compare. Here's the move. Lay the pages side by side on a table. Step back. Then look at them the way you learned in Chapter 7: describe before you judge. Look for:

- **Proportion.** Is the mug's height closer to its real height relative to its width?
- **Ellipses.** Is the top of the mug still football-shaped, or has it become an oval that sits?
- **Value.** Is there a real dark somewhere now?
- **Line.** Does the line look more certain? Are there fewer hairy, searching strokes?
- **Looking.** Can you tell, from the page, that you spent more time looking at the subject?

Write three differences you can point to. Not "it's better," but "the thumb joint is in the right place now," "the corner of the room has a ceiling line," "the mug has a shadow." Those sentences are your progress, stated plainly.

If you'd like one question to carry into the comparison, borrow the Hour's stem: "Before I fix, erase, or ask a tool: what do I actually see, what was I after, and what's the one change I'll try next?"

If a redraw looks worse. It happens. Maybe you were tired. Maybe you tried something harder: a trickier angle, a real shadow, a looser line. Growth in drawing isn't a straight line; it often looks messier just before it looks better. Note what was different that day, and look again at the next redraw. If you were drawing most days, you almost certainly learned something even if this page doesn't show it.

If you've been doing the mirror self-portrait from Chapter 3, it makes a good companion redraw. Same mirror, same lamp, every three months or so. Faces are hard, which is exactly why the change shows.

One more thing. Keep every baseline and redraw together, in order. By the end of a year, that little stack is the clearest answer you'll ever have to the question "Am I getting anywhere?"

A portfolio of twenty

A portfolio is your best ten to twenty pieces, photographed well, with a list. It's useful for applying to a class that asks to see work, for a community wall or a members' show, and simply for you, as a record of where you are.

Choosing. Start with a wall test from Chapter 8. Choose pieces you'd happily show a stranger, and let some of them be recent. A portfolio doesn't need to hang together as a series, but a few pieces from the same project show that you can stay with an idea. If twenty feels like a lot, start with five and add over the year.

Photographing. Here's the move:

- Use daylight from a window, not direct sun and not a lamp. Overcast days are ideal.
- Lay the piece flat, or tape it to a wall.
- Hold the phone square to the piece, parallel, not tilted, so the edges stay straight.
- Fill the frame, with a little margin you can crop later.

- Skip filters. If you adjust brightness, keep the colors true to the piece.
- Photograph framed work out of the frame, or without glass, to avoid reflections.

Naming and backing up. Give each photo a plain file name that matches the list, such as “03-kettle-no-outlines-4-2026-10-14,” and keep a second copy somewhere other than your phone: a computer, a memory card, or a cloud folder you control. Phones get lost, and a portfolio that exists only in one place isn’t really kept.

The list. One line per piece, taken from its whose-mark card: title, medium, size, date, hours, and a note on references, help and AI. Number the photos and the list the same way, so a reader can match them.

Keep your originals and a few dated process photos alongside the portfolio. They’re good memories, and if a question about authorship ever came up, they’re good evidence too.

Class records go in a separate folder. Your portfolio shows your work. Class records show where you studied. Keep them apart, and keep each one honest.

Classes, OLLI and CEUs, honestly

If you take classes as part of coming back to art, keep what the provider gives you. That usually means the course name, the provider’s name, the dates, the hours, and any completion letter or transcript. Keep it exactly as issued. The course keeps the name the provider gave it, even if a grander one is tempting, and several classes stay several classes rather than merging into one invented title.

Here’s how the common kinds of class work on paper.

Community college credit courses appear on that college’s transcript. If credit matters to you, for a degree or a teaching requirement, for example, the college’s registrar is the person to ask what will count.

Community college continuing education is usually non-credit. You may get a completion letter or a record of hours. Keep it; read what it actually says it certifies.

Osher Lifelong Learning Institutes (OLLI) offer non-credit courses for adults 50 and older, on university campuses across the country. The courses run without exams or grades, and the Osher Foundation supports 125 of these programs, with at least one in every state and the District of Columbia.⁶¹ Some offer art classes; what’s on offer varies by campus. An OLLI class is a fine way to learn among peers. Its record is simply that you took the course.

Continuing education units (CEUs) are a standard measure: one CEU equals ten contact hours of instruction.⁶² They matter only where an employer, a license or a school system recognizes them. A teacher’s professional development hours, for instance, follow local rules. If you hope an art class will count toward something, check with whoever does the counting *before* you enroll.

Art leagues, parks and recreation, libraries and senior centers may give you nothing on paper at all. That’s fine. Your practice strip records the hours, and your portfolio shows the work.

And here's what doesn't belong in your records:

- A certificate you made yourself, or one this book might seem to suggest. This book has no course, no credit and no certificate.
- This book's title presented as though it were a course.
- "Certified Artist," or any title nobody actually granted you.
- A "certificate of completion" produced by a chatbot. It isn't a record of anything.

None of this means your self-study is lesser. A year of dated practice strips, a stack of redraws and a portfolio of twenty with honest cards is a stronger record than most certificates. It's just called by its real name.

If you ever register a copyright

Most readers will never need this section. It's here because some adults sell work, show publicly or make pieces they'd like to protect more formally. This is general information about US law, not legal advice. For anything specific, talk to a lawyer.

You already have copyright. In the US, copyright exists the moment you fix an original work in a tangible form. Your sketchbook pages are protected today, without any form.⁵⁷

Why register, then? Registration is optional, but it matters in two situations. A US work has to be registered (or refused registration) before you can sue anyone for copying it. And if you register before an infringement happens, or within three months of first publishing the work, you can ask for certain kinds of damages and legal fees you otherwise couldn't.⁵⁷ For most home artists, that's a remote concern. For someone selling prints of their work, it may be worth knowing.

What it costs. At the time of writing (September 2026), the Copyright Office's fee page lists \$45 for a single application (one author, one work, not made for hire, with the author as the claimant) and \$65 for a standard application. The same page lists \$85 to register a group of two-dimensional artworks; group options have their own eligibility rules, so read them before choosing one. Fees change, so check the Copyright Office's current fee page before you file.⁶³

If a work includes AI material. The Copyright Office's position is plain. Material generated by AI can be protected only where a human author has determined enough of the expressive elements, and "not the mere provision of prompts."⁵ A federal appeals court agreed in 2025 that copyright requires a human author.¹⁷ When you register a work that contains AI-generated material that's more than trivial, the Office asks you to disclose it and to claim only your own part.⁶⁴ In one well-known case, the Office registered an author's text and her selection and arrangement of images in a comic, but not the individual images an AI system had generated.⁶⁵

This is where the whose-mark card earns its keep. If you ever need to say which parts of a piece are yours, the card already says so, dated, in your own hand. And the book's rule remains simpler than the law: sign only what you made.

You try this week

Pick what fits. Two of these is a good week; all of them is a generous one.

- **Start a practice strip.** On the inside cover of your sketchbook, draw five narrow columns: date, minutes, band, what, note. Fill in today's line, even if today's session was only a look.
- **Fill one full whose-mark card.** Choose the best piece you've made this month and fill every field. Notice which field was hardest. That's usually the one you've been skipping.
- **Put your redraw dates on a calendar.** Week 6 and week 12 from the day you made your baseline page. If you've already passed one, do it this weekend.
- **Photograph five pieces for your portfolio.** Daylight, square to the camera, no filters. Start the list with five lines.
- **Gather your class records.** Any completion letters, transcripts or hour records from classes you've taken. Put them in one folder, exactly as issued.
- **If you sell or plan to,** read the Copyright Office's current fee page once, and note the date you read it.

Then close the folder, open your sketchbook, and make today's page. Records are there to serve the practice, not the other way round.

Chapter 10 — Resources



This chapter is a map, not a shopping list. It won't tell you which class is best, which app to buy, or which museum to visit first, because the right answer depends on your week, your budget, your medium and where you live. What it will do is show you the kinds of places and programs that help adults keep an art practice going, starting with the ones that cost nothing.⁶⁶

Think of it the way a good librarian thinks. You don't walk up to the desk and get handed the "best book." You say what you're after, and they ask a question or two: how much time do you have, what have you tried, what do you enjoy? Then they point you toward something that fits. That's the spirit here. **Fit, not rank. Free first.**

A word on names. This chapter names public institutions and programs, such as museums, federal agencies and national programs, because you can look them up and they belong to everyone. It names one free software program as an example. It doesn't name paid courses or rank products, and nothing here is an advertisement. Where a detail might change, like a fee, an admission policy or a count, check the current page before you rely on it.

This week you can do one thing that pays off for years: go to your public library, get a card if you don't have one, and ask what they offer for adults who want to make art. Everything else in this chapter will be easier after that visit.

How to read a program

Before you sign up for anything, whether it's a class, an open session, an online series or a studio membership, run it through seven quick questions. You can do this in five minutes with the program's web page or flyer.

1. **Time.** When does it meet, and for how long? Does it fit a band you actually have: a lunch break, an evening at the table, a weekend morning?
2. **Cost shape.** Is it free, a one-time fee, a per-session drop-in, a monthly subscription or a term? Are materials extra? Is there a senior, student or low-income rate?
3. **Medium.** Is it the medium you want to work in now, or one you'd like to try? A drawing class won't help much if you're itching to paint.
4. **Level.** Who is it for? "All levels" can mean anything. If you're unsure, ask the organizer what a typical first session looks like.
5. **Feedback.** Will someone look at your work and respond? A class with feedback is a different thing from a demonstration you watch.
6. **Pause-ability.** Can you miss a week without losing your place or your money? For adults with shifts, caregiving or travel, this matters a great deal.
7. **Safety orientation.** For anything with chemicals, kilns, presses, sharp tools or live models, does the venue teach its rules before you start?

None of these is a pass-or-fail test. A class that's pricey but pause-able might suit you better than a cheap one that locks you in. Write the answers on an index card and compare two options side by side. That's usually enough to choose.

A simple habit helps: after the first session of anything, write one line in your practice strip. "Worth it: . **Not for me:** ." After three sessions, you'll know.

\$0 first: library, museums, open access

You can build a serious art practice without spending anything beyond a pencil, a pen and an inexpensive sketchbook. Here's where to look first.

Your public library. Libraries are the most underused art resource most adults have. Here's the move for a first visit. Borrow two technique books (ask the librarian for beginner drawing or watercolor if you're not sure where to start) and one book about an artist whose work you like. Then

ask three questions. Does the library lend museum passes? Does it offer online learning databases with art courses or video lessons? Does it host any art programs, sketch meets or exhibitions of local work? Many libraries also have meeting rooms, good light and quiet tables, which is a studio of sorts.

Free museum days and passes. Many museums have free days, free evenings or pay-what-you-wish hours, and some have free admission all the time. Check each museum’s own visiting page. Library museum passes, where offered, are another route. If you plan to sketch in the galleries, check the museum’s sketching rules before you go. Pencil in a small sketchbook is the usual allowance; wet media and easels usually aren’t.

Museums for All. If you receive SNAP food assistance, the Museums for All program offers free or reduced admission at more than 1,600 museums across the United States when you show your EBT card and a photo ID.⁴¹ Participating museums and their exact offers vary, so check the program’s site for places near you.

Open-access collections. Several major museums let anyone download high-quality images of public-domain works for free, for study, copying and more. “CC0” is a label some of them use; it means the image has been released for any use without asking permission. Places to start include the National Gallery of Art’s open-access images, Smithsonian Open Access (released under CC0), the Cleveland Museum of Art’s open-access collection (CC0), and the Metropolitan Museum of Art’s open-access program for public-domain works.^{42,43,44,46} Chapter 6 shows you how to use them: slow looking, labelled master copies, following a thread through history. When you save an image, save its credit line with it, and when you copy one, label your copy “copy after ____.”

Free software. If you’d like to try digital drawing or painting without buying software, free and open-source programs exist. Krita is one example: a free, open-source painting program made by artists.³⁸ Many free programs have their own tutorials and user communities, which count as free lessons too.

Free company: sketch groups. Urban-sketching groups, library sketch meets and informal drawing clubs meet in public places to draw together, and many cost nothing. Here’s how to try one. Look for a group that meets somewhere public, such as a café, a park, a station or a market. Bring your pocket kit. Sit near the group, draw what’s in front of you, and join the end-of-session look at everyone’s pages if there is one. If there’s no group near you, start the smallest possible version: a standing date with one friend, same place, once a month. Two meetups is a fair trial.

You’re in good company doing it this way. In a large federal survey of American adults, far more people who made art said they’d learned it on their own than in a class.²⁰ Both routes are ordinary. Many adults use both.

Classes by type

When you’re ready for a teacher and a room of other learners, these are the common kinds of class. Each has its own feel. None is best in general; one may be best for you this season.

Community college continuing education. Usually non-credit, often evenings or weekends, with

a real studio and an instructor. Good for structured progress in one medium over a term. Prices vary; many colleges have reduced rates for older adults.

Community college credit courses. Studio courses that appear on a transcript. Worth considering if credit matters, for a degree or a teaching requirement, for example. Chapter 9 covers keeping those records honestly.

Art leagues and art clubs. Membership organizations run by and for local artists. Many offer classes, open studio time, open figure sessions, critique nights and members' shows. For adults who want community and a place to show, a league is often the best fit there is.

Parks and recreation, libraries and senior centers. Low-cost or free drop-in classes and short series. Good for trying a new medium without committing to a term, and often friendly to true beginners.

Osher Lifelong Learning Institutes (OLLI), for adults 50 and older. Non-credit courses on university campuses around the country, run without exams or grades.⁶¹ Some programs offer art classes; others focus on lectures and discussion. What's on offer varies by campus. For retirees especially, an OLLI can be a warm, social way in.

Here's the move for choosing. List two or three nearby options, one of each type if you can. Run each through the seven questions above. Pick the one with the best fit for your time and medium, not the most impressive name. If you can't decide, start with a single drop-in class. One session tells you more than any description.

A good first class tends to feel a certain way. The teacher learns your name and asks what you've done before. There's a demonstration short enough to remember, then plenty of time for you to try it. Someone looks at your work and says something specific: what's working, and one thing to try. You leave a little tired and wanting to come back. If a class leaves you feeling small, or you spend most of it watching, that's useful information too. It's a fit problem, not a talent problem, and there's another room down the road.

Open figure sessions

An open figure session is a drawing session with a live model, usually run by an art league, a studio or a college continuing education program. Some are sessions where you draw on your own while the model holds a series of poses; others include a teacher. Chapter 3 teaches the drawing itself. This section is about finding a good session and being a good guest.

Finding one. Look for established venues: art leagues, community art centers, college continuing education programs and long-running studios. Good sessions have a professional model and a facilitator (sometimes called a monitor) who keeps time, manages the room and speaks for the model. Local art-supply shops and league members usually know where the reliable sessions are. Sessions may be clothed or nude; which you attend is your choice. Venues set their own age and conduct rules.

Being a good guest. Every venue has its own code, and you should read it before you go. Two published codes from long-standing venues share the same core courtesies:¹⁴

- Never touch the model.
- No photographs or recordings. One venue allows them only with the model's written permission obtained in advance; many allow none at all.
- Stay off the model's stand and out of their personal space.
- No comments about the model's body, and no personal questions during the session.
- Pose requests go through the facilitator, not directly to the model.
- Arrive on time, silence your phone, and thank the model at the end.

Your first visit. Bring a newsprint pad, charcoal or a soft pencil, and a board clip. Stick to the short poses. Gesture drawings of thirty seconds to two minutes are where everyone warms up. Leave when you're ready, quietly, between poses. A pad of gestures and one longer drawing is a very good first session.

Community studios

Some kinds of art belong in shared studios, not at home. Darkroom photography uses chemicals that need strong ventilation. Kilns for clay and glass need mechanical ventilation to the outdoors when they're indoors. Etching acids, solvent-based inks and presses need space, equipment and supervision. Spray finishes belong outdoors or in a proper spray booth with a NIOSH-approved respirator.⁶ Community studios exist so you can do all of this safely, with equipment you'd never buy alone and staff who know how.

Kinds of community studio. Community darkrooms, clay studios with shared kilns and wheels, print shops with presses, and maker spaces with a range of equipment. Some are run by nonprofits, some by colleges, some by cities.

How they usually work. Most start you with an introductory class or a safety orientation before you can use the space on your own. After that, many offer memberships or per-hour studio time. Firing fees for kilns and chemistry fees for darkrooms are common.

Here's the move. Find one community studio for a medium you're curious about. Call or email and ask two questions: "Do you offer an intro class or safety orientation?" and "What does a first visit look like?" If you can't find one, ask a community college's continuing education office; they often know every studio in the area. Booking one orientation is a complete step for this month.

Shared studios run on a few shared habits. Label your work and your shelf. Clean up fully before you leave, including the sink. Follow the posted rules for chemicals, glazes and waste even when nobody's watching, because the next person is breathing the same air. Ask before you use someone else's tools. Studio staff and long-time members are usually generous with advice if you ask at a quiet moment.

Online learning by type

Online learning can be wonderful for adults, because it fits odd hours and can be paused mid-sentence. It works best alongside your own practice, not instead of it. Here are the main types.

- **Museum video channels and artist interviews.** Many museums post talks, studio visits and short films about works in their collections. Watching an artist talk about their process is one of the best free lessons there is.
- **Public-television art series.** Long-running art instruction and artist-profile programs, many with archives you can watch free.
- **Library online learning databases.** Your library card may unlock video courses in drawing, painting, photography and design at no cost. Ask at the desk.
- **University open courseware.** Some universities post course materials, lectures and reading lists for anyone to use.
- **Free software tutorials.** Free programs usually come with tutorials and user forums.
- **Paid course platforms.** Subscription or per-course sites with video lessons in every medium. Quality and fit vary widely. Use the seven questions before you pay, and look especially at whether the course assigns practice and whether you can pause.

Four fit questions matter most for online learning. Does it ask you to practice, not just watch? Can you follow the demonstration at its pace, or pause and rewind easily? Is there any feedback, even from other learners? What does it cost per month, and can you stop without penalty?

Chatbots and other AI tools can also act as a kind of tutor: explaining a technique, making a study plan, quizzing you on terms. The Art Refresh Hour's AI box sets out how to use them well, after your own attempt and never as the hand.

One habit keeps online learning honest: after each lesson, put the device down and make something. Even ten minutes. The Art Refresh Hour's order still holds. Look, then sketch, then make.

Making art with kids: the sibling books

This book is the last of four in a family of art books. The other three are written for a parent or teacher working with children, and each has its own session ritual and activity bank sized to its age group. If you make art alongside kids and would like to teach them more fully, here's one pointer to each.⁶⁷

- ***Art for Little Thinkers*** is for young children, about ages 5 to 10.
- ***Art for Young Minds*** is for the middle years, about ages 11 to 14.
- ***Art for Emerging Adults*** is for teenagers, about ages 15 to 18, including portfolios and records for high school.

Chapter 8 covers making art *alongside* kids from your side of the table: separate pages, no correcting, and materials carrying the AP Seal at a shared table. Photos of children and family members stay off shared computers and AI tools, including any shared bot computer.

Safety contacts

Keep these where you work. Tape a card to the inside of your supply cabinet or the underside of the shelf. The Art Refresh Hour's safety spine explains each habit; this is the contact list.

Poison Control: 1-800-222-1222. Available 24/7 in over 100 languages.¹⁵ Call if someone swallows, breathes in, or gets a material on their skin or in their eyes and you're worried. Keep the product container nearby when you call so you can read the label. If someone is unconscious, having trouble breathing or having a seizure, call emergency services first.

US Consumer Product Safety Commission (CPSC): *Art and Craft Safety Guide*. A free federal guide covering ventilation, dust, solvents, oily rags, kilns, darkrooms and more.⁶ It's the backbone of this book's safety spine, and worth reading once in full.

Art & Creative Materials Institute (ACMI): seal lookup. ACMI certifies art materials and publishes the meaning of its seals.¹¹ The **AP Seal** is for kids in sixth grade or younger. The **CL Seal** is for adults and kids older than sixth grade, and you need to read the product label in full before opening. ACMI's site lets you look up products and seals.

ASTM D-4236 on a label. A federal law, the Labeling of Hazardous Art Materials Act, makes ASTM D-4236 labelling mandatory for art materials.¹⁰ A label saying a product "conforms to ASTM D-4236" means it was reviewed so the label carries any needed warnings. It isn't a "non-toxic" stamp. Read what the label actually says.

For aerosols: outdoors, or in a spray booth with a NIOSH-approved respirator. **For pain in your eyes, hands, wrists or back:** stop and ask a clinician. **For a venue's rules:** read the posted safety sheet or ask the staff before you start.

A fit table (seed, not a ranking)

Use this table to match what you need right now to a *kind* of resource. It's a starting point. Your library, your league and your own practice strip will refine it.

If what you need most is...	Try this kind of resource first	Then, if it fits
To start with no money	Public library books and databases; open-access collections	Free museum days; a free sketch group
Company and a regular date	A sketch group or library sketch meet	An art league membership
Structured progress in one medium	Community college continuing education	A credit course, if credit matters
A gentle, social start after 50	An OLLI course or a senior-center drop-in	A parks-and-recreation series
Drawing people from life	An established open figure session, short poses first	A figure class with an instructor
Darkroom, clay, printmaking	A community studio's intro class and safety orientation	A studio membership
Feedback on your work	An art league critique night or a class with critique	A partner response process at home (Chapter 7)

If what you need most is...	Try this kind of resource first	Then, if it fits
Learning at odd hours	Library online databases; museum video channels	A paid course platform that lets you pause
Digital drawing or painting	Free software and its tutorials	A class that includes digital work
Showing your work	A home show; a library or café wall	An art league members' show
Making art with kids	Side by side at home (Chapter 8)	The sibling book for their age
Museum visits on a tight budget	Free days; library passes; Museums for All if eligible	Open-access collections between visits

Read across a row, not down a column. Nothing here is ranked above anything else. A retiree and a parent of toddlers might sit on very different rows this year and swap next year. Both are using the table right.

You try this week

Pick one or two. Each is a complete step.

- **Library first.** Go to your library, get a card if you need one, and borrow two technique books and one artist book. Ask about museum passes and online learning databases. Write what you found in your practice strip.
- **Find the class that fits.** List two or three nearby classes of different types. Run each through the seven questions on an index card. Enroll in one, or book a single drop-in.
- **Find an open session.** Look up one established open figure session nearby. Read the venue's code of conduct. Put a date on the calendar, and plan to stay with the short poses.
- **Find a community studio.** Choose a medium you can't do at home. Email one studio to ask about an intro class or safety orientation.
- **Find a sketch group,** or text one friend to set a monthly drawing date in a public place.
- **Make the safety card.** Write Poison Control's number, 1-800-222-1222, on an index card with "CPSC Art and Craft Safety Guide" and "ACMI seal lookup" beneath it. Tape it inside your supply cabinet.

Then put the list away and make today's page. The resources are there when you need them. The practice is already in your hands.

A Note on Sources

Studies, standards, museum pages, government pages and platform terms named in the chapters are listed in Notes, in one series at the back, so the teaching pages can keep a warm, plain voice. When the same source comes up in several chapters, it has one note, and every mark that cites it carries that note's number.

Most sources were re-read on 29 September 2026. A few were read only at abstract or summary level, and their notes say so: the habit study by Lally and colleagues, the drawing-skill studies by Ostrofsky and colleagues and by Chamberlain and colleagues, and Voelcker-Rehage's review of motor learning in older adults. The World Health Organization's arts-and-health review, the Reviewing Education and the Arts Project and the *Studio Thinking* research were read through their summaries and publisher listings, and the high-school mathematics trial cited in the Hour's AI box and the detector study by Liang and colleagues were confirmed through publisher listings and search records rather than a full re-read. Several studies come from students, laboratories or another subject, and they are used for what they show about a method, not as findings about adults coming back to art.

A few things stay open, and the book leaves them open rather than filling them. The Metropolitan Museum of Art's open-access page blocked automated reading on 29 September 2026, so the Met is named without a count. Gamblin's solvent-free method is a paint maker's guidance, not an independent standard; the fire risk of oily rags rests on the federal *Art and Craft Safety Guide*. The figure-session codes are two venues' policies, not universal rules. The dose suggestions, the home-versus-venue lists, the whose-mark card and the other practice rules are this book's own suggestions, not findings, and the readers, pages and paintings in the examples are illustrations or composites, not real people or real work.

Platform terms, fees, museum programs and counts change; the dates in each note say when they were read. Nothing here is legal, tax or medical advice. Access date for web sources: 29 September 2026.

Notes

1. Dale J. Cohen and Susan Bennett, “Why Can’t Most People Draw What They See?,” *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance* 23, no. 3 (1997): 609–621, author’s copy at <https://people.uncw.edu/cohend/research/papers/Cohen%20and%20Bennett%2097.pdf> (accessed 29 September 2026). Four candidate sources of error were tested with trained and untrained adult undergraduates: misperception of the object was the major source; the drawer’s decision-making was a relatively minor source; motor coordination was “a very minimal source”; misperception of one’s own drawing was not a source. A laboratory study with college students. The value → proportion → edges → composition → color order used in Chapter 7 is a teaching convention built on this finding, not a tested sequence.
2. Alexander Schlegel et al., “The Artist Emerges: Visual Art Learning Alters Neural Structure and Function,” *NeuroImage* 105 (2015): 440–451, author’s copy at https://kohlerlab.com/assets/papers/schlegel_et_al_ (accessed 29 September 2026). Undergraduates in a three-month introductory observational drawing or painting course improved at drawing from observation compared with non-art controls; the authors “did not find any significant changes in perceptual ability” on the perceptual tests used. Small sample; one course. Brain-imaging findings are not used in this book.
3. This week’s plan draws on the book’s named try-its: the baseline page (START-01), the why card (START-02), the daily page (SKB-01), nine thumbnails (SKB-02), the negative-space chair (OBS-03), the one-room visit (MUS-01), the practice strip (LOG-02) and the progress redraw (LOG-03). Codes appear only in notes; full entries live in the chapters named. The twelve-week route is the book’s own suggestion, not a course and not a credit.
4. Phillippa Lally et al., “How Are Habits Formed: Modelling Habit Formation in the Real World,” *European Journal of Social Psychology* 40, no. 6 (2010): 998–1009, <https://doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674> (accessed 29 September 2026). Of 96 volunteers who chose a daily eating, drinking or activity behavior in a consistent context, 82 provided enough data. Automaticity rose along an asymptotic curve; the median time to reach 95 percent of the plateau was 66 days (range 18–254); missing one opportunity to perform the behavior did not materially affect habit formation. Read at abstract level.
5. US Copyright Office, “Copyright Office Releases Part 2 of Artificial Intelligence Report,” News-Net Issue 1060 (29 January 2025), <https://www.copyright.gov/newsnet/2025/1060.html>, and *Copyright and Artificial Intelligence, Part 2: Copyrightability* (January 2025), <https://www.copyright.gov/ai/Copyright-and-Artificial-Intelligence-Part-2-Copyrightability-Report.pdf> (both accessed 29 September 2026). Outputs of generative AI are protectable “only where a human author has determined sufficient

expressive elements,” which can include a human-authored work perceptible in the output or creative arrangements or modifications of it, “but not the mere provision of prompts”; the report concludes that “prompts alone do not provide sufficient human control” to make a user the author of the output; and using AI to assist a human creator does not bar protection of the human’s contribution. Not legal advice.

6. US Consumer Product Safety Commission, *Art and Craft Safety Guide* (Pub. 5015), <https://www.cpsc.gov/s3fs-public/5015.pdf> (accessed 29 September 2026). The guide is the source for: “Never eat, drink, or smoke in studios”; keep art materials out of children’s reach; choose water-based products over solvent-based ones and read the product label; “You cannot tell the toxicity of materials by the absence or presence of a particular smell”; “Adequate ventilation means that clean air is flowing toward the artist and contaminated air is flowing away. Blowing air around with a fan without a source of clean air is not adequate ventilation, and can actually increase exposures to harmful substances”; family members may be exposed to vapors from a home studio with inadequate ventilation, so “Keep art studios separate from living areas and clean yourself before entering living areas”; pastels and charcoal (avoid lead chromate pigments, tap rather than blow excess dust, clean with a wet cloth or mop; oil pastels create less dust); “Use clear acrylic polymer emulsion to fix drawings”; “Never hold brushes or tools in your mouth, tip brushes with your lips”; pigment hazards (for example, lead carbonate, chrome yellow and cobalt arsenate), with advice to avoid materials with lead, cadmium and other heavy metals for children; “Linseed oil or solvent-soaked rags can spontaneously combust, so rags should be stored in a covered container that does not allow air in or vapors out”; spray painting and aerosols outdoors if possible, or with a spray booth or fume hood and a NIOSH-approved respirator with an organic vapor cartridge; darkrooms need ventilation that brings in fresh air and exhausts contaminated air “at the rate of at least 10 room volume changes per hour”; indoor ceramic kilns need mechanical ventilation to the outdoors; etching acids and solvent-based inks carry their own hazards; relief printing (water-based inks, cut away from the body, bench hooks, tools stored with guards, rest often); and computer work (position devices comfortably, keep wrists straight, take short breaks often, look into the distance, use task lighting). The book’s home rules (no indoor sprays; darkroom, kiln, press and etching at community venues) are practice rules drawn from the guide. General safety guidance, not medical advice.

7. SpaceXAI, “Frequently Asked Questions,” Grok Bot documentation, SpaceXAI Docs (last updated 21 September 2026), <https://docs.x.ai/grok-bot/faq> (accessed 29 September 2026): “Every Bot on your account uses one persistent cloud computer. They share its files, browser sessions, and logins”; “The computer is assigned per user, not per Bot. Do not use separate Bots as a security boundary”; deleting a bot can leave files and logins on that computer. Grok (a chatbot) and Grok Bot (an agent service) are different things.

8. The Hour draws on named items whose homes are elsewhere in the book: the daily page (SKB-01, Chapter 2), step back (CRIT-01, Chapter 7), the whose-mark card (LOG-01) and practice strip (LOG-02), both taught in Chapter 9, the monthly flip (SKB-07) and the progress redraw (LOG-03), and the first three safety items (SAFE-01 read the label, SAFE-02 the food line, SAFE-03 fresh air in, dirty air out, Chapter 2). Band timings are this book’s design, not a research finding.

9. The two try-it examples are versions of slow contour (OBS-01) and three values, then five (OBS-05), both taught fully in Chapter 3.

10. Electronic Code of Federal Regulations, 16 CFR 1500.14(b)(8), “Products requiring special labeling under section 3(b) of the act,” <https://www.ecfr.gov/current/title-16/chapter-II/subchapter-C/part-1500/section-1500.14> (accessed 29 September 2026). The Labeling of Hazardous Art Materials Act (1988) made the labelling requirements of ASTM D-4236 mandatory for art materials. D-4236 is a labelling procedure for chronic hazards that involves a toxicologist’s review, not a “safe” or “non-toxic” rating.

11. Art & Creative Materials Institute (ACMI), “Classroom Art Materials Safety,” <https://acmiart.org/classroom-art-materials-safety>, and “Materials Safety,” <https://acmiart.org/materials-safety> (both accessed 29 September 2026). AP Seal: for kids in sixth grade or younger. CL Seal: “For adults and kids older than sixth grade”; users “Must read the product label in full before opening.” ACMI advises never giving children in sixth grade or younger a product with the CL Seal.

12. Gamblin Artists Colors, “Solvent-Free Oil Painting,” <https://gamblincolors.com/studio-safety/solvent-free-painting/> (accessed 29 September 2026). Maker guidance, not an independent standard: wipe excess paint from the brush with a rag, dip it in safflower oil, wipe again with a second rag, and wash with soap and water after the session; mineral oil and cooking oil are non-drying and should be kept out of painting; oil-soaked rags “should be – at a minimum – properly stored in an Oily Rag Safety Can” until thrown out, or, better, soaked in water in a closed container and put out in the outdoor trash.

13. National Eye Institute, “Presbyopia” (last updated 4 December 2024), <https://www.nei.nih.gov/learn-about-eye-health/eye-conditions-and-diseases/presbyopia> (accessed 29 September 2026). Presbyopia is a normal part of aging, “usually after age 45”; brighter reading lights and reading glasses help. General information, not medical advice; see an eye doctor about changes in vision.

14. Providence Art Club, “Figure Drawing Code of Conduct,” <https://providenceartclub.org/figure-drawing-code-of-conduct/>, and Santa Cruz Art League, “Figure Drawing Etiquette,” <https://scal.org/figure-drawing-etiquette> (both accessed 29 September 2026). Two published venue codes: do not touch the model; no photographs (at Providence, only if the model has granted written permission in advance); no comments on the model’s body; directions and requests go through the instructor or facilitator; no personal questions (Santa Cruz); thank the model (Providence). These are two venues’ policies, not universal rules; every venue sets its own.

15. Health Resources and Services Administration, “Poison Help,” <https://poisonhelp.hrsa.gov/> (accessed 29 September 2026): 1-800-222-1222; “Poison Help is available 24/7 in over 100 languages.” The advice to call emergency services first for unconsciousness, breathing trouble or a seizure is general first-aid guidance, not taken from this page. The full safety spine is in The Art Refresh Hour.

16. Hamsa Bastani, Osbert Bastani, Alp Sungu, Haosen Ge, Özge Kabakçı and Rei Mariman, “Generative AI Without Guardrails Can Harm Learning: Evidence from High School Mathematics,” *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 122, no. 26 (2025): e2422633122, <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2422633122> (the publisher page blocked automated reading on 29 September 2026; details confirmed through the publisher’s listing and search records). A field experiment with high-school mathematics students in Turkey: unrestricted access to a chatbot during practice improved practice performance and lowered performance once access was removed. Off-age and off-subject for this book; cited once, here only, as the reason for “try first.”

17. *Thaler v. Perlmutter*, No. 23-5233 (D.C. Cir. decided 18 March 2025), <https://media.cadc.uscourts.gov/opinion/5233.pdf> (accessed 29 September 2026). The court affirmed the denial of registration for a work listed as created autonomously by an AI system: the Copyright Act of 1976 requires that eligible work be authored in the first instance by a human being. Not legal advice.
18. OpenAI, “Terms of Use” (effective 1 January 2026), <https://openai.com/policies/terms-of-use/> (accessed 29 September 2026). Users may not “Represent that Output was human-generated when it was not.” Platform terms change; check the current page.
19. Platform terms as read for this book (September 2026); terms change, so check the current page. SpaceXAI, “Terms of Service – Consumer” (updated 11 September 2026), <https://x.ai/legal/terms-of-service>: users grant an “irrevocable, perpetual, transferable, sublicensable, royalty-free, and worldwide right” to use inputs, extending to a person’s “image, likeness, voice” in user content. Midjourney, “Terms of Service” (effective 27 May 2026), <https://docs.midjourney.com/hc/en-us/articles/32083055291277-Terms-of-Service>: “By default, Your Content is publicly viewable and remixable,” with a perpetual, irrevocable licence to content you input. Google, “Gemini Apps Privacy Hub” (updated 24 September 2026), <https://support.google.com/gemini/answer/13594961>: human reviewers review some chats, and reviewed chats are “retained for up to three years.” All accessed 29 September 2026.
20. National Endowment for the Arts, *Arts Participation Patterns in 2022: Highlights from the Survey of Public Participation in the Arts* (2023), <https://www.arts.gov/sites/default/files/2022-SPPA-final.pdf> (accessed 29 September 2026). 52 percent of US adults (about 129 million) personally created or performed art in the 12-month period ending July 2022; 11.8 percent took any arts class or lesson in that year, while 25.5 percent learned by other means. See also National Endowment for the Arts, *Arts Indicator B.3: Personal Creation/Performance of Art* (2024), <https://www.arts.gov/sites/default/files/b3-report-202403.pdf> (accessed 29 September 2026). Survey self-reports of participation, not measures of skill.
21. Justin Ostrofsky, Aaron Kozbelt and Angelika Seidel, “Perceptual Constancies and Visual Selection as Predictors of Realistic Drawing Skill,” *Psychology of Aesthetics, Creativity, and the Arts* 6, no. 2 (2012): 124–136, <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0026384> (accessed 29 September 2026). Resistance to size constancy and visual selection together predicted realistic drawing accuracy (correlational). Read at abstract level.
22. Rebecca Chamberlain, Jennifer E. Drake, Aaron Kozbelt, Rebecca Hickman, Joseph Siev and Johan Wagemans, “Artists as Experts in Visual Cognition: An Update,” *Psychology of Aesthetics, Creativity, and the Arts* 13, no. 1 (2019): 58–73, <https://doi.org/10.1037/aca0000156> (accessed 29 September 2026). The review describes training-associated perceptual differences in artists; the direction of cause is not settled. Read at abstract level.
23. Brooke N. Macnamara, David Z. Hambrick and Frederick L. Oswald, “Deliberate Practice and Performance in Music, Games, Sports, Education, and Professions: A Meta-Analysis,” *Psychological Science* 25, no. 8 (2014): 1608–1618, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0956797614535810> (accessed 29 September 2026). Deliberate practice explained 26 percent of the variance in performance for games, 21 percent for music, 18 percent for sports, 4 percent for education and less than 1 percent for professions. No visual-art domain was included; the book uses it only for the general point that focused practice with feedback is the lever a learner controls, and never for “10,000 hours.”

24. Claudia Voelcker-Rehage, “Motor-Skill Learning in Older Adults—A Review of Studies on Age-Related Differences,” *European Review of Aging and Physical Activity* 5 (2008): 5–16, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11556-008-0030-9> (accessed 29 September 2026). Older adults retain the capacity to learn new motor skills; age differences are task-specific and larger on complex tasks. Read at abstract level.
25. John Dunlosky, Katherine A. Rawson, Elizabeth J. Marsh, Mitchell J. Nathan and Daniel T. Willingham, “Improving Students’ Learning With Effective Learning Techniques,” *Psychological Science in the Public Interest* 14, no. 1 (2013): 4–58, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1529100612453266> (accessed 29 September 2026). Distributed (spaced) practice and practice testing were rated high-utility techniques. The samples were students, not adult art learners; the translation to adult art practice is this book’s.
26. Jared A. Nielsen et al., “An Evaluation of the Left-Brain vs. Right-Brain Hypothesis with Resting State Functional Connectivity Magnetic Resonance Imaging,” *PLOS ONE* 8, no. 8 (2013): e71275, <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0071275> (accessed 29 September 2026). In 1,011 people aged 7–29, lateralization was local to networks, with no evidence of whole-brain “left-brained” or “right-brained” types.
27. Girija Kaimal, Kendra Ray and Juan Muniz, “Reduction of Cortisol Levels and Participants’ Responses Following Art Making,” *Art Therapy* 33, no. 2 (2016): 74–80, <https://doi.org/10.1080/07421656.2016.1166832> (accessed 29 September 2026). 39 healthy adults made art for 45 minutes; salivary cortisol fell significantly on average, regardless of prior art experience. No control group.
28. Daisy Fancourt and Saoirse Finn, *What Is the Evidence on the Role of the Arts in Improving Health and Well-Being? A Scoping Review*, Health Evidence Network Synthesis Report 67 (WHO Regional Office for Europe, 2019), <https://www.who.int/europe/publications/i/item/9789289054553>; NCBI Bookshelf copy <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK553773/> (both consulted 29 September 2026; neither page loaded for automated reading that day, so the scope is taken from the report’s published summary). A scoping review of more than 900 publications, with designs ranging from uncontrolled pilots to randomized trials; not a systematic review.
29. Ellen Winner, Thalia R. Goldstein and Stéphan Vincent-Lancrin, *Art for Art’s Sake? The Impact of Arts Education*, Educational Research and Innovation (OECD Publishing, 2013), <https://doi.org/10.1787/9789264180789-en> (accessed 29 September 2026). The review found “no evidence that training in visual arts improves overall academic skills or verbal skills (literacy)”; its one close-transfer finding was that close looking at art improved observation of scientific images.
30. Ellen Winner and Lois Hetland, eds., “The Arts and Academic Improvement: What the Evidence Shows,” Reviewing Education and the Arts Project (REAP), *Journal of Aesthetic Education* 34, nos. 3/4 (2000), <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3333636> (accessed 29 September 2026). A review of 188 reports, 275 effect sizes and 10 meta-analyses found no demonstrated causal link from arts study in general to verbal or mathematics achievement; its narrow exceptions (such as classroom drama and verbal skills) do not involve visual art. Read through the project’s summaries.
31. US Bureau of Labor Statistics, “American Time Use Survey — 2025 Results,” news release, 25 June 2026, <https://www.bls.gov/news.release/atus.nr0.htm> (accessed 29 September 2026). Adults

35–44 averaged 3.9 hours of leisure and sports a day, less than any other age group (everyone 15 and over, 5.2 hours; 75 and over, 7.4 hours). ATUS operations were suspended from 1 October through 12 November 2025 during a federal shutdown, and the 2025 estimates were reweighted to cover the gap.

32. This chapter’s try-its are the START bank: the baseline page (START-01), the why card (START-02), the old-sketchbook audit (START-03) and the one-inch return (START-04). The baseline page is redrawn at weeks 6 and 12 as the progress redraw (LOG-03, Chapter 9).

33. This chapter’s try-its are the SKB bank (the daily page, SKB-01; nine thumbnails, SKB-02; the permission page, SKB-03; the cue and the kit, SKB-04; line warm-ups, SKB-05; the page of one subject, SKB-06; the monthly flip, SKB-07) and the first four items of the SAFE bank (read the label, SAFE-01; the food line, SAFE-02; fresh air in, dirty air out, SAFE-03; the studio corner away from living space, SAFE-04). The oily-rag rule (SAFE-05) belongs to Chapter 4; eyes, hands and screens (SAFE-06) and venue-only processes (SAFE-07) to Chapter 5. The short whose-mark card is LOG-01, taught in Chapter 9.

34. Elizabeth A. Fallon et al., “Prevalence of Diagnosed Arthritis — United States, 2019–2021,” *Morbidity and Mortality Weekly Report* 72, no. 41 (13 October 2023): 1101–1107, <https://www.cdc.gov/mmwr/volumes/72/wr/mm7241a1.htm>, accessed 29 September 2026. During 2019–2021, 21.2 percent of US adults (53.2 million) reported diagnosed arthritis. Setup suggestions in the body are general comfort measures, not medical advice.

35. Try-its in this chapter come from the book’s teaching bank: OBS-01 Slow contour; OBS-02 Sight-size and measuring (the two-mug first try-it); OBS-03 Negative space; OBS-04 Upside-down copy; OBS-05 Three values, then five; OBS-06 Perspective in your own room; OBS-07 Café gesture; LIFE-01 The open figure session; LIFE-02 Mirror self-portrait; LIFE-03 Hands, yours; LIFE-04 Portrait with permission; LIFE-05 Place: one street corner. The whose-mark card is LOG-01 (Chapter 9). Codes appear only here so the teaching pages stay readable.

36. National Eye Institute, “Color Blindness,” National Institutes of Health (last updated 5 November 2025), <https://www.nei.nih.gov/learn-about-eye-health/eye-conditions-and-diseases/color-blindness>, accessed 29 September 2026.

37. Try-its in this chapter come from the book’s teaching bank: PNT-01 The watercolor swatch grid; PNT-02 Wet-in-wet and wet-on-dry; PNT-03 Gouache fruit in three passes (the first try-it); PNT-04 Acrylic block-in; PNT-05 Solvent-free oil start; PNT-06 The one-hour landscape; PNT-07 Repaint one passage; COL-01 Value before color; COL-02 Limited palette mixing chart; COL-03 Warm and cool light; COL-04 Five-minute color notes; COL-05 Color from a master; SAFE-05 The oily-rag rule. The whose-mark card is LOG-01 (Chapter 9). Codes appear only here.

38. Krita Foundation, “Krita: Digital Painting. Creative Freedom.,” <https://krita.org/en/> (accessed 29 September 2026). A free and open-source painting program made by artists, licensed under the GNU GPL. Named once in Chapter 5 and once in Chapter 10, as an example by fit, not rank.

39. Try-its in this chapter come from the book’s teaching bank: PHO-01 Twenty frames of one thing (the first try-it); PHO-02 Light walk; PHO-03 One-subject month; PHO-04 Edit with a note; PHO-05 Community darkroom day; DIG-01 Digital daily page; DIG-02 Layers as process; DIG-03 Screen-time sandwich; DIG-04 Scan and clean; DIG-05 Digital master study; DES-01 Card

layout; DES-02 Two-font rule; DES-03 The zine; DES-04 Block print at the table; SAFE-06 Eyes, hands, screens (taught in “Screens and bodies” and the screen-time sandwich); SAFE-07 Venue-only processes. The whose-mark card is LOG-01 (Chapter 9). Codes appear only here.

40. VTS Institute, “About Us,” <https://vtshome.org/about/>, accessed 29 September 2026. Open-ended art discussion method developed by Abigail Housen and Philip Yenawine; the three questions are the method’s own. Described here as a method for slowing down and noticing, within the organization’s own description.

41. “Museums for All,” an initiative of the Institute of Museum and Library Services, administered by the Association of Children’s Museums, <https://museums4all.org/> (accessed 29 September 2026). People receiving SNAP food assistance can get free or reduced admission “to more than 1,600 museums throughout the United States” by presenting an EBT card and a photo ID. Participating museums and offers change; check the current list.

42. National Gallery of Art, “Free Images and Open Access,” <https://www.nga.gov/artworks/free-images-and-open-access> (accessed 29 September 2026). “More than 60,000 images are available for download,” free of charge for any use; admission is always free.

43. Smithsonian Institution, “Smithsonian Open Access,” <https://www.si.edu/openaccess> (accessed 29 September 2026). “More than 5.2 million 2D and 3D digital items” from the collections, released under CC0.

44. Cleveland Museum of Art, “Open Access,” <https://www.clevelandart.org/open-access> (accessed 29 September 2026). High-resolution images of public-domain artworks and collection data are released under Creative Commons Zero (CC0).

45. Art Institute of Chicago, “Open Access Images,” <https://www.artic.edu/open-access/open-access-images> (accessed 29 September 2026). “Free, unrestricted use of over 50,000 images” of works believed to be in the public domain, under Creative Commons Zero (CC0).

46. The Metropolitan Museum of Art, “Open Access,” <https://www.metmuseum.org/hubs/open-access>. The page blocked automated retrieval on 29 September 2026, so the program is described without a count; check the Met’s page for what is currently included.

47. Jennifer Jenkins and James Boyle, “Public Domain Day 2026,” Center for the Study of the Public Domain, Duke University School of Law, <https://web.law.duke.edu/cspd/publicdomainday/2026/>, accessed 29 September 2026. US works published in 1930 entered the public domain on 1 January 2026; publication status for artworks is often unclear. US law only; not legal advice.

48. William H. Walters and Esther Isabelle Wilder, “Fabrication and Errors in the Bibliographic Citations Generated by ChatGPT,” *Scientific Reports* 13 (2023): 14045, <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-023-41032-5> (accessed 29 September 2026). In the conditions tested, 55 percent of GPT-3.5 citations and 18 percent of GPT-4 citations were fabricated.

49. Try-its in this chapter come from the book’s teaching bank: LOOK-01 Three open questions (the first try-it); LOOK-02 Ten-minute slow look; LOOK-03 Master copy, labelled; LOOK-04 Follow a thread; LOOK-05 The decision you’d borrow; LOOK-06 Living artist hour; MUS-01 The one-room visit; MUS-02 Free first; MUS-03 Open-access folder; MUS-04 Gallery walk. The whose-mark card is LOG-01 (Chapter 9). Codes appear only here.

50. Liz Lerman, “Liz Lerman’s Critical Response Process,” [lizlerman.com](https://lizlerman.com/critical-response-process/), 2026 (method devised 1990). <https://lizlerman.com/critical-response-process/>. Accessed 29 September 2026. The four steps (statements of meaning; artist as questioner; neutral questions; permissioned opinions), the three roles (artist/maker, responder, facilitator), the optional “next step” talk, and the description of the method as feedback on work in progress meant to leave the maker eager to get back to work are from the originator’s page. The originator’s page presents the name with the registered-trademark symbol (Critical Response Process®). The solo, partner and group adaptations in this chapter are the book’s.

51. Lois Hetland, Ellen Winner, Shirley Veenema and Kimberly M. Sheridan, *Studio Thinking 2: The Real Benefits of Visual Arts Education* (Teachers College Press, 2013); Project Zero, Harvard Graduate School of Education, “Eight Habits of Mind,” <https://pz.harvard.edu/resources/eight-habits-of-mind>, accessed 29 September 2026 (the older project URL no longer loads; the study details below are confirmed through the publisher’s and search listings). The eight habits come from a study of 38 visual-arts classes taught by five teachers in two Boston-area arts high schools. Used here as vocabulary, not as a scoring rubric.

52. Bank items used in this chapter (codes appear in notes only): CRIT-01 Step back; CRIT-02 Solo response process; CRIT-03 Response process with a partner; CRIT-04 The group crit; CRIT-05 Diagnose a wrong one; CRIT-06 Feedback from a tool, after (Tools, including AI); WRITE-01 The one-line caption; WRITE-02 The 100-word statement; WRITE-03 Process note; WRITE-04 Look-and-write; WRITE-05 The talk for friends. Eleven items, all home to this chapter. Composite examples (the statement, the two friends at the table) are illustrations, not reported people.

53. Weixin Liang, Mert Yuksekgonul, Yining Mao, Eric Wu and James Zou, “GPT Detectors Are Biased Against Non-Native English Writers,” *Patterns* 4, no. 7 (2023): 100779. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.patter.2023.100779>. Confirmed through the publisher listing, 29 September 2026. Seven detectors gave an average false-positive rate of 61.22% on 91 human-written TOEFL essays by non-native English writers.

54. SAND Lab, University of Chicago, “What Is Glaze,” glaze.cs.uchicago.edu, 2026. <https://glaze.cs.uchicago.edu/what-is-glaze.html>. Accessed 29 September 2026. The page describes Glaze as disrupting style mimicry and says it is “not a permanent solution.” An option, not a guarantee.

55. Coalition for Content Provenance and Authenticity (C2PA), “C2PA / Content Credentials,” c2pa.org, 2026. <https://c2pa.org/>. Accessed 29 September 2026. An open standard for recording a file’s origin and edits, described by the coalition as like a nutrition label. It records provenance; it doesn’t prevent copying.

56. Internal Revenue Service, “Here’s How to Tell the Difference Between a Hobby and a Business for Tax Purposes,” IRS Newsroom, [irs.gov](https://www.irs.gov/newsroom/heres-how-to-tell-the-difference-between-a-hobby-and-a-business-for-tax-purposes), 2026. <https://www.irs.gov/newsroom/heres-how-to-tell-the-difference-between-a-hobby-and-a-business-for-tax-purposes>. Accessed 29 September 2026. A hobby is pursued without the intention of making a profit; the listed factors are weighed together and no single factor is decisive; hobby income is reported on Schedule 1 (Form 1040), line 8. Business guidance is in IRS Publication 334. Not tax advice.

57. US Copyright Office, *Copyright Basics* (Circular 1), <https://www.copyright.gov/circs/circ01.pdf>

(accessed 29 September 2026). Copyright protects original works of authorship from the moment they are fixed in a tangible form; ideas, procedures, methods and systems are not protected; registration is voluntary, but a US work must be registered (or refused) before an infringement suit; registration before infringement or within three months after publication makes statutory damages and attorneys' fees available. Not legal advice.

58. US Copyright Office, "U.S. Copyright Office Fair Use Index," [copyright.gov](https://www.copyright.gov/fair-use/), 2026. <https://www.copyright.gov/fair-use/>. Accessed 29 September 2026. Fair use weighs four factors: the purpose and character of the use (including whether it is transformative), the nature of the copyrighted work, the amount used, and the effect on the market for the original. Not legal advice.

59. Bank items used in this chapter (codes appear in notes only): BODY-01 Ten of one thing; BODY-02 The constraint project; BODY-03 Trip or season sketchbook; BODY-04 The year of small pieces; BODY-05 Wall test; BODY-06 The next piece; SHOW-01 The home show; SHOW-02 Community walls; SHOW-03 Posting with care; SHOW-04 Price it simply; FAM-01 Side by side; FAM-02 The family critique; FAM-03 Museum with kids, adult pace too; FAM-04 Fridge show. Fourteen items, all home to this chapter. The lighthouse painter is a composite illustration, not a reported person.

60. Bank items used in this chapter (codes appear in notes only): LOG-01 The whose-mark card; LOG-02 The practice strip; LOG-03 Progress redraw; LOG-04 Portfolio of twenty. Four items, all home to this chapter. The baseline page (START-01) belongs to Chapter 1 and the monthly flip (SKB-07) to Chapter 2; they're referred to here, not retaught. Composite examples (the kettle card, the practice week) are illustrations, not reported people.

61. Bernard Osher Foundation, "Osher Lifelong Learning Institutes," <https://www.osherfoundation.org/olli.html> (accessed 29 September 2026). Non-credit courses designed for people 50 or older, for learning "without examinations or grades." The foundation "supports 125 lifelong learning programs on university and college campuses across the country, with at least one grantee in each of the 50 states and the District of Columbia." Numbers change; check the foundation's page.

62. IACET, "About the CEU," [iacet.org](https://www.iacet.org/standards/ansi-iacet-2018-1-standard-for-continuing-education-and-training/continuing-education-unit-ceu/about-the-ceu/). <https://www.iacet.org/standards/ansi-iacet-2018-1-standard-for-continuing-education-and-training/continuing-education-unit-ceu/about-the-ceu/>. Accessed 29 September 2026. "One (1) CEU is equivalent to ten (10) contact hours of participation in an organized learning experience delivered under responsible sponsorship, capable direction, and qualified instruction." Whether CEUs count for anything depends on the employer, licensing body or school system.

63. US Copyright Office, "Fees," [copyright.gov](https://www.copyright.gov/about/fees.html), 2026. <https://www.copyright.gov/about/fees.html>. Accessed 29 September 2026. At the time of writing: Single Application \$45 (single author, same claimant, one work, not for hire); Standard Application \$65; "Registration of a claim in a group of two-dimensional artworks" \$85. Eligibility for group options is set out on the Office's registration pages; confirm all fees on the live page before filing.

64. US Copyright Office, "Copyright Registration Guidance: Works Containing Material Generated by Artificial Intelligence," 88 Fed. Reg. 16190 (16 March 2023), [copyright.gov](https://www.copyright.gov/ai/ai_policy_guidance.pdf), 2023. https://www.copyright.gov/ai/ai_policy_guidance.pdf. Accessed 29 September 2026. Applicants must disclose AI-generated content that is more than de minimis and exclude it from the claim.

“More than trivial” in the text is the book’s plain-English rendering of “more than de minimis.”

65. US Copyright Office, letter re *Zarya of the Dawn* (Registration # VAu001480196), copyright.gov, 21 February 2023. <https://www.copyright.gov/docs/zarya-of-the-dawn.pdf>. Accessed 29 September 2026. The Office registered the author’s text and her selection, coordination and arrangement of text and images, but not the individual images generated with Midjourney.

66. Bank items used in this chapter (codes appear in notes only): OUT-01 The class that fits (Classes by type; You try this week); OUT-02 Open session finder (Open figure sessions); OUT-03 Community studio (Community studios); OUT-04 Library first (\$0 first); OUT-05 Sketch group (\$0 first). Five items, all home to this chapter.

67. Michael Gannotti, *Art for Little Thinkers* (SMF Works / SMF WisdomForge, 2026), *Art for Young Minds* (SMF Works / SMF WisdomForge, 2026) and *Art for Emerging Adults* (SMF Works / SMF WisdomForge, 2026), the earlier titles on the WisdomForge Art Hour ladder, for ages 5–10, 11–14 and 15–18.